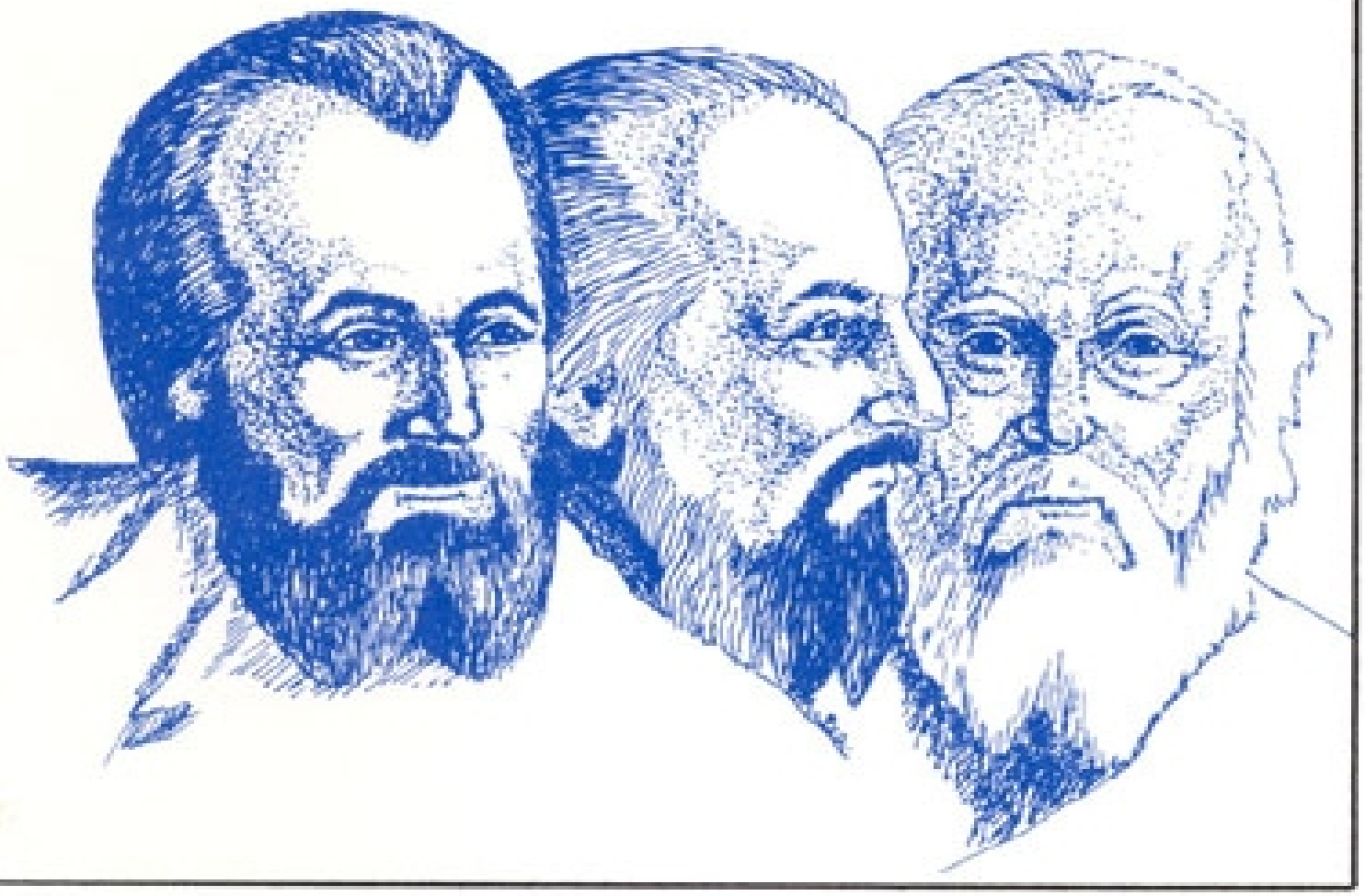
Paul

HIS APOSTLESHIP AND MESSAGE

By: C. R. STAM



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and MESSAGE

by

CORNELIUS R. STAM

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- The Author

THE JACKET ARTWORK

The artwork for the jacket was done by our own Bernadette (Mrs. Russell) Miller, giving us her conception of how Paul might have looked during his early, middle and later years as a servant of Christ. There is one thing about Bernadette's portraits; they have character. To this sister also, our heartfelt thanks.

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PREFACE

The present volume on *Paul, His Apostleship and Message,* falls somewhat into the same category with our recent book on *Our Great Commission.* As with *Our Great Commission,* we became increasingly concerned with the fact that while we had written scores of articles in the *Searchlight* and in booklets on Paul and the various aspects of his ministry, we had never written a comprehensive book on the subject. Indeed, with the hundreds of books that have been written on Paul, we know of no volume that deals with his apostleship and message dispensationally in any comprehensive way. Thus the publication of such a book becomes a matter of *urgency* for it is the *lack* of knowledge about Paul as the Apostle of Grace, and the failure to acknowledge the distinctive character of his ministry that is chiefly responsible for the theological confusion and division that have gripped the Church for centuries.

The contents of this volume have been taken largely from articles written over a span of 44 years, and their basic argument has never been successfully challenged; indeed, the arguments presented against some of them have served to confirm "grace believers" in their stand for Paul's God-given ministry as separate and distinct from that of the twelve apostles. Meanwhile - only by the grace of God - these articles have brought further light and understanding of the Word to a multitude of sincere believers. This fact would seem to indicate that *Paul, His Apostleship and Message* may, under God, be used to help many of its readers in their understanding of the Scriptures-at a time when this is so sorely needed.

We claim no superior understanding of the Word of God or any special gift for imparting its truths to others. Rather, we sincerely acknowledge that *any* light or blessing gained from the reading of this book will have come *from God.* Thus we earnestly pray that the Holy Spirit will open hearts to receive any *truth* which this book presents and to discern any errors that may appear. We ask no one to believe us, but rather to compare our words with the Word of God, to consider our arguments sincerely, in the light of the Scriptures, rightly divided.

As this volume goes to press, then, we trust that the facts presented as to *Paul, His Apostleship and Message,* will bring rich blessing to the hearts of our readers as indeed they have to the heart of the writer.

- Cornelius R. Stam

Chicago, Illinois
April 15, 1985

We are convinced that the basic arguments set forth in this book cannot *possibly* be answered by those who consider the so-called "Great Commission their "marching orders." Yet we do not challenge them to try. Rather we pray that, like the noble Bereans, they will consider them with open heart and mind, searching the Scriptures diligently to see "whether these things are so."

INTRODUCTION

THE CONVERSION OF SAUL OF TARSUS

One event in history which probably stands next in importance to the death and resurrection of Christ, is the conversion and commission of Saul of Tarsus, later known as *Paul the Apostle.* Yet this great event is all but ignored by historians, nor are any celebrations or holidays ever held in its memory.

Moreover, the significance of Paul's place in history and in the program of God has been all but lost sight of *by the Church.* As a result he is considered, even by Christian believers, as merely "an apostle" along with the twelve. Yet he was chosen entirely apart from the twelve, far from Jerusalem, out on Gentile territory. And he had *not* been a follower of Christ as they had been (Matt. 19:28); rather, just before his conversion he was *"yet breathing out threatenings and slaughter against the disciples of the Lord"* (Acts 9:1). And *at* his conversion he was immediately appointed an apostle (Acts 26:16,17; cf. 20:24).

The conversion of Paul is more fully described and more often referred to in Scripture than any other conversion, or indeed, than any other one personal experience outside of the crucifixion and resurrection of Christ. The major parts of three separate chapters in Acts are taken up with this account and it forms the *main* subject of two of Paul's five recorded discourses. So conscious is the apostle himself of the importance of his conversion in connection with the gospel of the grace of God that he refers to it over and over again in his epistles

In Paul we learn *what the Lord Jesus Christ accomplished at Calvary,* for Paul was, as he himself testifies, the chief of sinners, saved by the infinite grace of God (I Tim. 1:13-16), grace which could be justly bestowed only *"through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus"* (Rom. 3:24).

The argument that Paul's sincerity in his opposition to Christ offered some excuse for his murder and blasphemy is groundless, for thus "what you sincerely believe" takes the place of *what God has said in His Word,* and man is no longer responsible to obey the revealed will of God. We are reaping the fruits of this Godless philosophy all about us today.

But the strange fact is that some who abhor this philosophy seem to make an exception in the case of Saul of Tarsus. In an effort to prove that he was *not* the chief of sinners, they point to his sincerity and make a rather good man of him after all! And that when they know that God utterly repudiates even the best deeds of Christ-rejectors.

The fact is that Paul *could* and *should* have known that Jesus was the Christ, but he did not wish to know this. He had deceived himself into thinking that he "ought to do many things contrary to the name of Jesus of Nazareth."

Saul's deep hatred of Christ had raised him to a high position in Israel. As he "persecuted the Church of God and laid it waste," he "profited in the Jews' religion above many [of his] equals" (Gal. 1:13,14).

In the light of all this, God must have had some very *special* purpose in saving him. This is what this volume is really about. It is written to demonstrate *from the Scriptures* that God raised up Paul to be both the herald and the living demonstration of His grace to a doomed world.

Chapter I

PAUL THE PATTERN

THE MYSTERY UNFOLDED

The conversion of Paul marked the *beginning* of the unfolding of the mystery of God's purpose and grace. Indeed, the very fact that *another* apostle, quite separate from the twelve, had been raised up, clearly indicates that God had begun to usher in a *new* dispensation: *"the dispensation of the grace of God"* (Eph. 3:1-4). Dr. I. R. Dean said of this:

"Why was it necessary for Paul to have a new revelation of the gospel if he was to preach the same gospel that John the Baptist and Christ and His disciples had preached? Wherein lies the difference?

"John the Baptist and Christ and His disciples offered *Israel* a Messiah. . . . *Paul's gospel* does not offer Israel a Messiah at all; God is not offering anyone a *Messiah* now" *(The Coming King,* P. 210).

Dean was right, for rather than offering a Messiah now, God is offering reconciliation by grace to all men, in a world where Messiah, the King, was, and remains, rejected.

"For God hath concluded them all in unbelief that He might have mercy upon all" (Rom. 11:32).

BORN OUT OF DUE TIME

One further word should be said about the conversion of Saul. In I Cor. 15:8 he calls himself *"one born out of due time."* Here he appears to compare his own conversion with the future conversion of Israel, for the term in the Greek indicates a "miscarriage," or untimely birth.

But had not many Jewish believers been saved under our Lord's earthly ministry and at Pentecost? Were they not also born "out of' or before the due time? Yes, but something significant had taken place between the two.

The Jewish disciples had been saved during what Christ called, *Israel's day* and *the time of her visitation* (Luke 19:41-44). Our Lord also called this "the acceptable year of the Lord" for Israel (Luke 4:19). Moreover this "acceptable year of the Lord" was prolonged by our Lord's intercession from the cross (Luke 23:34; cf., Luke 13:8).

The Apostles could not have known, however, that Pentecost, when the kingdom was actually to be *offered,* was not the "due time" for Israel's conversion, for our Lord had declined to tell them this (See Acts 1:6,7).

But with the murder of Stephen and the "great persecution" that followed, it became evident that Israel would not accept Christ. By this act of rebellion the nation answered the question of Christ's apostles as to the establishment of His kingdom. Now Israel's conversion must await a *future* day; the "due time" still lay ahead, even though all did not yet understand this.

This is why Paul speaks of himself as having been born *before* the "due time" rather than *"in* due time." It does not follow from all this, however, that Paul's conversion was necessarily typical of Israel's throughout.

Paul, having been born *out of,* or *before* the due time, has a more direct relationship to us Gentiles than to Israel. Israel will be born again *in* due time, while we, like Paul, are born "out of' or before the due time. Let us state this more simply thus:

When is the "due time" for Israel, as a nation, to be saved: past, present, or future? The answer, of course, is *future.* When is the "due time" for the Gentiles to be saved? The answer of prophecy is that this is also future, for the Gentiles, according to covenant and prophecy, are to be saved *through redeemed Israel* (Isa. 60:1-3; Luke 2:30-32). When *Jews* are saved today, then, are they saved "in due time," prophetically speaking, or "before the due time"? *"Before the due time,"* of course, and *by grace.* And when *Gentiles* are saved today, are they saved "in due time," or "before the due time"? The answer is also *"before the due time,"* for according to prophecy, the salvation of the Gentiles was to have been - and will be - the *result* of Israel's conversion, while *now* Jews and Gentiles are saved on an equal basis.

Thus, when Jews and Gentiles are saved today, and reconciled to God in one body, they are saved "out of' or *before* the "due time," not on the basis of any covenant God has made with them, but by *grace,* not according to prophecy, but according to the *mystery* revealed to and through the Apostle Paul.

Some insist that Saul's conversion was "a pattern" of Israel's conversion only, but *he* does not say this. He says, by inspiration of the Spirit, that Christ, in his case, showed *"all longsuffering for a pattern to them which should hereafter believe on [Christ] to life everlasting"* (I Tim. 1:16).

DO WE GIVE PAUL UNDUE PROMINENCE?

Do we, then, make too much of Paul in our preaching and writing? Do we give him undue prominence? It is true that we often refer to Paul in our teaching and often base our discourses on what he says in his epistles. Indeed, there is only

one person of whom we speak more often - much more often - than Paul, and that person is *the Lord Jesus Christ.* But there is *a valid reason* why we refer to Paul as often as we do, and only less than we speak of Christ.

PAUL THE PATTERN

Not only did our Lord commit to Paul the message and program for us today; He set him forth as a pattern for us to follow (1) in *salvation,* (2) in *service,* and (3) in *conduct.* Let us demonstrate this from the Scriptures. Modernists and Liberals have taught for years that Christ is our example or pattern; that we should walk "in His steps" and follow Him to be saved and blessed. But this is contrary to the Scriptures.

OUR PATTERN IN SALVATION

How could the Lord Jesus Christ be our pattern for salvation? He lived a *perfect* life, thus His perfection could only call attention to our imperfection. His holiness could only draw attention to our sin and unworthiness. His life would *condemn* us; it is His death that saves us. This is why Paul proclaims to us "the gospel . . . by *which ye are saved.* . . how that *Christ died for our sins"* (I Cor. 15:1-3).

But further, our Lord could not be our pattern in salvation because He lived under a different dispensation. He lived under the Law, as we read in Gal. 4:4, and many other passages. He was circumcised on the eighth day in a religious ritual. He attended the synagogue every Sabbath (seventh) day. He kept the feast days of the Law. Are we to follow Him in all these things?

No! The Lord Jesus Christ stands alone. He is the Son of God, God the Son, our *Savior.* It is true that when on earth He said, "Follow Me," but instead of following Him they cried, "Away with Him!" and nailed Him to a cross, sending Him back to heaven as an exile from His own world. And here is where Paul comes m.

Our Lord knew He would be rejected. The Scriptures had predicted this long before. Thus in wonderful love and mercy the rejected Lord, instead of judging the world immediately, interrupted the prophetic program and *saved* Saul of Tarsus, the chief of sinners and the leader of the world's rebellion. Thus He not only ushered in "the dispensation of the grace of God," but set Paul forth as the pattern for our salvation - a poor, unworthy sinner, saved because "the grace of our Lord was exceeding abundant." How could the apostle state this more clearly than he does in I Tim. 1:13-16:

“[I] was before a *blasphemer,* and a persecutor, and *injurious;* but I obtained mercy because I did it ignorantly in unbelief.

"And *the grace of our Lord was* exceeding *abundant,* with faith and love, which is in Christ Jesus.

"This is a faithful saying, and worthy of all acceptation, that Christ Jesus came into the world to *save* sinners; of *whom* I am *chief.*

"Howbeit *for this cause I obtained mercy, that in me first Jesus Christ might show forth all longsuffering, FOR A PATTERN to them which should hereafter believe on Him to life everlasting."*

Here the reader should carefully consider Rom. 5:20,21 to see that Paul, in his conversion represented the bringing in of a new dispensation in which grace *reigns.* He was not our pattern in every respect, but in the grace shown to him as a sinner (I Tim. 1:14,16).

As we have seen, the Lord Jesus Christ *could not* be our pattern in salvation, but Paul surely makes an ideal pattern: a sinner - a great sinner - saved by "grace. . . exceeding abundant"! Thus, to be saved, we must take Paul as our pattern and Christ as our Savior. We must take our stand with Paul, as it were, and say, "I am a sinner too - a grievous sinner," trusting *Christ* as our Savior. As we do we may rejoice in the truth of Eph. 1:7:

"In [Christ] we have redemption, through His blood, the forgiveness of sins according to the riches of His grace."

It was this message of abundant, indiscriminate grace to sinners that Paul burned out his life to proclaim and defend.

OUR PATTERN IN SERVICE

As Paul is our pattern in salvation, he is our pattern in service too. See what Eph. 3:8,9 say about this:

"Unto me, who am less than the least of all saints, is this grace given, that I should preach among the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ" (Ver. 8).

Why did God choose one who was "less than the least of all saints" to fill this high position? Verse 9 tells us:

"And to make all men see what is the fellowship[1] of the mystery, which from the beginning of the world hath been hid in God, who created all things by Jesus Christ."

The sense, simply stated, is, that Paul, *less than the least of all saints,* was chosen to proclaim among the nations "the unsearchable riches of Christ" -

[1] *Textus Receptus* has *koinonia,* or fellowship. The author once followed those who contend it should be *oikonomia,* or dispensation, but further study has convinced him that "fellowship" is correct. If it were "dispensation," however, this would also be *true,* for Paul did proclaim the dispensation of the mystery.

"And," i.e., *and so,* to show all men *"what is the fellowship of the mystery,"* i.e., to show them *what kind* of people God uses in this “joint stewardship." Thus as the chief of sinners was *saved* to show that God will save the vilest sinner so he, who was "less than the least of all saints," was *used* of God to show that God will use the poorest of saints.

How often Christians have said, "Oh, He could not use me." But He can. Did He not use Paul, less than the least of all saints, to proclaim the unsearchable riches of Christ? But does the reader ask, "Do you believe that Paul was *really* 'less than the least of all saints?"' Well, God's inspired Word says that he was the chief of sinners and less than the least of all saints. Is God's Word true? Paul did not write these things merely from modesty, but by divine inspiration. "But," you say, "See how God used him!" Ah, yes, but this was *""grace given"* (Ver. 8; cf. Gal. 2:9).

Does not I Cor. 1:27 declare that God has chosen the weak things of this world to confound the things that are mighty; and the things which are not, to put to naught the things which are? And read the closing verses of Romans 7 and see how the apostle struggled with his own old nature and cried,

"O wretched man that I am! Who shall deliver me from the body of this death?"

In the very last verse, however, he exclaims: "I thank God, through Jesus Christ our Lord."

As God *saved* Saul, the chief of sinners, to assure any poor sinner that *he* may be saved, so He *used* Paul, less than the least of all saints, to assure any poor saint that God is waiting to use him.

What grace, that we have *""this treasure"* (the riches of God's grace) in "earthen vessels" (so easily marred and broken) ”*that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us"* (II Cor. 4:7). Let no child of God, then, demur to serve Him with the words, "Oh, He couldn't use *me."* Rather let us "stand on line," as it were, to ask Him, *“Lord, what wilt Thou have me to do?"*

OUR PATTERN IN CONDUCT

Finally, God chose Paul to be our pattern in *behavior* too. In our present condition and in "this present evil age" we will find no help for our conduct by simply trying to follow Christ as an example. True, we should possess the moral and spiritual virtues that are His but, except by grace, *we do not* possess these virtues. So far do we fall short in this that it appears as contrast rather than comparison. But Paul is an ideal pattern where our conduct is concerned. Hear him speak for himself:

"Not as though I had already attained, either were already perfect: . . . .
"Brethren, I count not myself to *have apprehended:* but *this one thing I do,* forgetting those things which are behind, and reaching forth unto those things which are before,

"I press toward the mark ["strain for the goal], for the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus" (Phil. 3:12-14).

And then he adds:

"Brethren, *be followers together of me, and mark them which walk so as ye have us for an example" (*Ver. 17).

We *cannot* follow Christ as our example, either morally or dispensationally. But Paul makes a perfect example for us to follow in our conduct. He freely acknowledged his own failure to fully "apprehend," or to reach perfection. But he had a secret! Knowing that to dwell on past successes would only puff him up, and to dwell on past failures would only discourage him, he was determined to *"forget those things which are behind. . . . reaching forth unto those things which are before,"* straining for that blessed goal - "the calling on high." And this is the secret for us too. When God graciously gives us a position in Christ, at His own right hand, there to be blessed with all spiritual blessings (Eph. 2:5, 6; 1:3), we should by faith *occupy* that position and *appropriate* those blessings. How great a victory to learn this blessed secret!

If God has indeed given us a position in the heavenlies, we may - yes we *should* occupy that position. And if God has blessed us with all spiritual blessings in the heavenlies, would it not be an insult to His love and grace, *not* to take Him at His Word and appropriate them?

And thus God has given us a great Savior to save and bless us, and a most appropriate pattern to follow, in salvation, in service and in conduct.

Chapter II

APOSTOLIC AUTHORITY

THE TWELVE APOSTLES AND PAUL

We, the members of the Body of Christ, will never enjoy doctrinal unity until we recognize the important fact that with Israel's rejection of Messiah and His kingdom the twelve apostles were superseded by *another* apostle who, as a representative of the rejected yet glorified Lord, ushered in the present *'"dispensation of the grace of God"* (Eph. 3:1-4).

THE TWELVE APOSTLES

Every Sunday School child knows that our Lord, when on earth, chose twelve apostles to accompany Him in His ministry. But, by contrast, how many preachers in the pulpit understand *why* He chose *twelve,* or what this involves?

What we *all* should understand is that our Lord, when on earth, proclaimed *"the gospel of the kingdom,"* the good news of the restoration of Israel's kingdom on earth, but in greater glory, and that in this kingdom the *twelve* apostles would sit upon *twelve* thrones with Him as judges over the *twelve* tribes of Israel (Matt. 19:28; Luke 22:28-30).

Our Lord explained to His disciples, however, that this kingdom would not be established until after He had first suffered, died and risen again, for the prophets had clearly foretold "the sufferings of Christ and the glory that should *follow"* (I Pet. 1:11).

When, after His resurrection, the apostles asked Him, *"Wilt Thou at this time restore again the kingdom to Israel?"* (Acts 1:6), He did not in any way qualify His promise, but said only, *"It is not for you to know the times or the seasons. . ."* (Ver. 7) for, humanly speaking, the answer to their question hung in the balance. It depended upon Israel's response to the amnesty prayed for by our Lord from the cross (Luke 23:34), and announced at Pentecost (Acts 2:38,39; 3:19-21; cf. Luke 13:6-9).

APOSTOLIC POWERS

In view of His coming ascension to heaven, our Lord gave the apostles official powers to exercise in His absence. Among other things He said to them:

"And I will give unto *thee* Peter the keys of the kingdom of heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt bind on earth shall be bound in heaven; and whatsoever

thou shalt loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven" (Matt. 16: 19).

"Verily I say unto you the twelve, Whatsoever ye shall bind on earth shall be bound in heaven: and whatsoever ye shall loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven" (Matt. 18:18).

"Whose soever sins ye remit, they are remitted unto them; and whose soever sins ye retain, they are retained" (John 20:23).

What reasonings there have been among Protestants over these verses; what efforts to explain them away! But next to Roman Catholic claims their arguments have been as weak as cotton thread.

Shall we then return to Rome and commit our souls to *men,* men who can either bless or curse us according to their will - men who do not know as much about us as we ourselves? By no means!

The solution to this problem is a dispensational one. The apostles *were* given authority to act officially in Messiah's absence, even to the forgiveness of sins, representatively, of course. Did not Peter, at Pentecost, command his convicted hearers: "Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ *for the remission of sins"?* And did not Peter and the others then proceed to baptize those who *had* repented?

But could not some shrewd person have deceived the apostles? No. *Did Ananias deceive them?* He was carried out dead! But could there be no mistake? No, for *"they were all filled with the Holy Ghost"* (Acts 2:4) and were given special miraculous powers, including the "gift of knowledge."[2]

As we know, Judas "fell by way of transgression," but in obedience to Scripture, Peter and the other apostles and disciples soon acted to bring the number of apostles up to twelve again. As a result "Matthias . . . was numbered with the eleven. . . . *And they were all filled with the Holy Ghost"* (Acts 1:15-2:4).[3]

ANOTHER APOSTLE

But while thousands turned to Christ under the ministry of the twelve, the nation as such, and especially the rulers, remained obdurate in their rejection of Christ and His reign. Finally Stephen was stoned and a great persecution arose against the followers of Christ. In response God raised up *another* apostle, Paul, to usher in a new and different dispensation, *"the dispensation of the grace of God"* (Eph.

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[2] This subject is discussed more comprehensively in the author's brochure, *The Apostolic Authority of the Twelve.*

[3] The question whether Paul should have taken Judas' place is discussed in depth further on in this volume. But the fact that they were all filled with the Holy Spirit is proof enough that Matthias was God's choice.

3:1-3). Thus began the "casting away" of Israel for a season (Rom. 11:13-15,25).

That Paul proclaimed a distinctive message, never proclaimed before, is evident from many of his writings, but we cite here his important statement in Gal. 2:2,9:

"And I went up *by revelation* and communicated unto them *that gospel which I preach among the Gentiles,* but privately to them which were of reputation, lest by *any* means I should run, or had run, in vain. . . . And when James, Cephas and John, who seemed to be pillars, perceived the grace that was given unto me, *they gave to me and Barnabas the right hands of fellowship, that we should go unto the heathen [Gentiles) and they unto the circumcision."*

By no means can the above passage be interpreted to mean that Paul went to Jerusalem to "check with the apostles there" to make sure they were all preaching the same thing.

The passage tells us that Paul "went up *by revelation."* He was *sent up* by God. And when he arrived there, he says, "[I] communicated unto them *that gospel which I preach among the Gentiles."* Surely the words *"that gospel which I preach"* stamps his message as *different* from theirs. But there is more. He says: "[I went] *privately* to them which were of reputation, lest by any means I should run, or had run, in vain." Why should he do this if his message was the same as theirs? But to complete the evidence, we read further that James, Cephas [Peter] and John, seeing the validity of his ministry, publicly shook hands with him and Barnabas, solemnly and officially agreeing that Paul should continue to go to the Gentiles, while they should confine their ministry to Israel.

Thus those who had originally been sent to "all nations" and "all the world," now agreed that a change had taken place. God had appointed *Paul* to go to the Gentiles with "the gospel of the grace of God," so that they were now to confine their ministry to "the circumcision." Thus, in effect, they loosed themselves from their "great commission," and clearly, what they loosed on earth by a solemn, public agreement, was also loosed in heaven.

PAUL'S CLAIMS

Paul's own Spirit-inspired claims for the distinctive character of his ministry as the apostle of the Gentiles leave no room for doubt as to this matter. Consider this sampling:

Rom. 11:13: "For I speak to you Gentiles, inasmuch as *I am the apostle* of *the Gentiles;* I magnify mine office."

Gal. 1:11,12: "But I certify you, brethren, that the gospel which was preached of me is not after man.

"For I neither received it of man, neither was I taught it, *but by the revelation of Jesus Christ."*

Eph. 3:1-3: "For this cause, I Paul, *the prisoner of Jesus Christ for you Gentiles,*

"If ye have heard of *the dispensation of the grace of God, which is given me to you-ward:*

"How that *by revelation He made known unto me the mystery. . . .*"

Col. 1:25: ". . . I am made a minister, according to *the dispensation of God which is given to me for you,* to fullfil *[fill full, or complete]* the Word of God."

I Tim. 2:5-7: "For there is one God, and one *Mediator between God and men, the Man Christ Jesus;*

"Who gave Himself a ransom for all, *to be testified in due time,*

"Whereunto I am ordained a preacher, and an apostle (I speak the truth in Christ and lie not) a *teacher* of *the Gentiles in faith and verity."*

Tit. 1:2,3: "In hope of eternal life, which God, that cannot lie, promised before the world began;

"But hath in *due times* manifested His Word *through preaching which* is *committed unto me,* according to the commandment of God our Savior."

TWELVE TRIBES AND ONE BODY

THE TWELVE AND PAUL AS REPRESENTATIVES

It has often been taught that the twelve apostles represent the Church of this dispensation just as the twelve patriarchs represented Israel.

This, of course, comes from the same old tradition that Pentecost marked the beginning of the Body of Christ, but it is absolutely without Scriptural foundation.

In Matthew 19:28 it is clearly stated that *the twelve apostles* represented the nation *Israel.*

"And Jesus said unto them, Verily I say unto you, That ye which have followed Me, in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of His glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel."

This promise was made without qualification by Christ the King to the twelve apostles and He will surely fulfil it. God had another apostle to represent the

Body of Christ. It was Paul. To those who doubt this we would ask the question: If the twelve apostles represented the Church of *this dispensation* and if at Pentecost their message brought three thousand souls into the Body of Christ - *why Paul?*

Scripture clearly teaches that as the twelve represented Israel (Matt. 19:28), so Paul represented the Body of Christ (Col. 1:24,25).

Let us consider Paul.

Was he a Jew or a Gentile?

You say: "He was a Hebrew."

Well, was he a *born* Hebrew or a *naturalized* Hebrew?

Oh, you say: "He was a *born* Hebrew, 'of the tribe of Benjamin.' "

Then was he very much a Hebrew or just barely so?

Again you answer: "He was *'an Hebrew of the Hebrews.'"*

And you are right. Paul was *intensely* Hebrew.

But wait, *Paul was a Roman too!*

After his midnight experience at Philippi he struck terror into the hearts of the rulers there by saying:

"They have beaten us openly, uncondemned, being Romans, and have cast us into prison; and now do they thrust us out privily? Nay, verily, but let them come themselves and fetch us out" (Acts 16:37).

Thus he was very much a Roman!

In Acts 21:39 we find him telling the chief captain in Jerusalem: "I am a *man which am a Jew of Tarsus, a city in Cilicia, a citizen of no mean city,"* and in the next chapter he says to a centurion:

"Is it lawful for you to scourge a man that is a Roman and uncondemned? When the centurion heard that, he went and told the chief captain, saying, Take heed what thou doest; for this man is a Roman. Then the chief captain came and said unto him, Tell me, art thou a Roman? He said, Yea. And the chief captain answered, With a great sum obtained I this freedom. And Paul said, *but I was freeborn.* Then straightway they departed from him which should have examined him: and the chief captain also was afraid, after he knew that he was a Roman,

and because he had bound him" (Acts 22:25-29).

So Paul was very much a Hebrew but he was also very much a Roman; a Hebrew religiously and a Roman politically.

He was both Hebrew-born and Roman-born.

What a fitting representative of the Church of *this dispensation!* A representative of Jew and Gentile in *one person!* That is just what the Church of today is: a 'Joint body" composed of believing Jews and Gentiles. Moreover, Paul had been an *enemy* of Christ, now gloriously *reconciled* by grace, and this is just what the Church of today is:

Eph. 2:14 "For He is our peace, who hath made BOTH ONE..."

Eph. 2:15 ". . . to make in Himself OF TWAIN ONE NEW MAN.. ."

Eph. 2:16 "That He might reconcile BOTH unto God in ONE BODY by the cross, having slain the enmity thereby.

Chapter III

I HEARD A VOICE

A STATEMENT BY PETER II Pet. 1:16-18	A STATEMENT BY PAUL Acts 22:7,14,15
"For we have not followed cunningly devised fables, when we made known unto you the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, but were eyewitnesses of His majesty. "For He received from God the Father honor and glory, when there came such A VOICE TO HIM FROM THE EXCELLENT GLORY. This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased. "AND THIS VOICE. . . WE HEARD, when we were with Him in the holy mount."	"And I fell unto the ground, and HEARD A VOICE saying unto me, Saul, Saul, why persecutest thou Me?" "And he [Ananias] said, The God of our fathers hath chosen thee, that thou shouldest know His will, and see that Just One, and shouldest HEAR THE VOICE OF HIS MOUTH. "For thou shalt be His witness unto all men of what thou hast seen and heard."

Both Peter and Paul saw the Lord in glory. Both heard voices from heaven. And both were sent to be witnesses of the things which they had *seen and heard* (Acts 4:20; 22:15). Yet there was a distinct difference in the circumstances and the significance of their experiences.

Peter saw the Lord in His glory *on earth;* Paul saw Him in His glory *in heaven.* Peter saw Him in His *kingdom* glory; Paul saw Him in the glory of His grace, at the Father's right hand. The voice Peter heard had the *acceptance* of Christ in view *("Hear ye Him,"* Matt. 17:5); the voice Paul heard had the *rejection* of Christ in view *("Why persecutest thou Me?"* Acts 9:4). Peter's experience was a demonstration of *"the power and coming"* of Christ; Paul's was a demonstration of *the grace that caused Him to delay His coming*[4] (II Pet. 3:9,15). Peter's experience harmonized with his *kingdom* ministry; Paul's harmonized with his ministry as the apostle of *the grace of God.*

PETER ON THE MOUNTAIN TOP

In Matt. 4:17 we read, *"From that time* Jesus began to preach and to say,

[4] I.e., to judge and reign.

"Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand," and the tenth chapter tells us how He sent the twelve forth with this same message.

How was this message received? See the record in Matt. 16:21:

"From that time forth [some two years later] began Jesus to show unto His disciples, *how that He must go unto Jerusalem, and suffer many things of the elders and chief priests and scribes, and be killed, and be raised again the third day."*

Imagine the apostles' feelings now! Already they had been discouraged over the lack of response to their proclamation of the kingdom and now that the opposition of the rulers becomes more determined the Lord begins to talk about being killed.

What about His kingdom claims? True, He predicted that He would rise again the third day, but that seemed too much to believe. Luke 18:34 tells us with a three-fold emphasis that they could not take this in. All they could see was His present rejection by Israel, the possibility of His death, and the failure of their kingdom hopes. Notice Peter's reaction:

"Then Peter took Him, and began to rebuke Him, saying, Be it far *from* Thee, Lord: this shall not be unto Thee" (Ver. 22).

Undoubtedly this attitude of doubt and fear was one of the reasons for the transfiguration of our Lord. That day Peter, James and John became *""eyewitnesses of His majesty"* and heard God's voice from heaven, confirming what they saw.

How they needed this just before the cross! Now, no matter what might happen, they at least had no *reason* to doubt that Christ *would* reign in glory on earth, according to prophecy.

SAUL ON THE ROAD TO DAMASCUS

As we know, Peter and the other apostles were unable to bring Israel to repentance or convince the nation that Jesus was the Christ. The opposition of the government against their message became increasingly bitter, even after His resurrection, until finally *"the blood of. . . Stephen was shed"* and then more blood, and more and more.

This is where we first read of Saul of Tarsus, for it was he who inspired and led the "great persecution" that soon raged against the Pentecostal believers.

Concerning the brutal murder of Stephen we read, *"And Saul was consenting unto his death,"* and in the same verse, *"And at that time there was [arose] a great persecution against the Church which was at Jerusalem. . . . As for Saul,*

he made havoc of the Church" (Acts 8:1,3).

In this bitter persecution Saul of Tarsus was unquestionably the representative of Israel's spirit of rebellion against Messiah, but on the road to Damascus, when the persecution was at its height, the rejected Lord Himself intervened and Saul, like Peter, saw the Lord in His glory - now His glory *in heaven* - and heard His voice from the Father's right hand.

But how different the circumstances! Peter, as the Lord's apostle, had *seen and heard* that Jesus was indeed the Christ, but Saul was Peter's bitterest enemy for proclaiming this fact. Peter was the leader of the Pentecostal Church. Paul was the leader of the violent persecution against that Church.

Two facts in particular should be observed about the voice that Saul heard from heaven. First, *the Lord's rejection by Israel was now assumed.* Before the stoning of Stephen and the rise of Saul as the leader of the rebellion, it had been assumed, or at least hoped, that Israel would repent and accept Messiah as her King (Acts 1:6-8; 2:14-21; 36-41; 3:19-21). But now, with Israel waging a relentless persecution against the Church, with Saul making havoc of the Church[5] and laying it waste, the rejected Lord calls from heaven, *"Saul, Saul, why persecutest thou Me?"* After that the kingdom was never again offered to Israel.

Second, it should be observed that while the Lord here recognizes Saul as His enemy, yet He deals with Him in tender love and grace. Indeed, instead of judging him He *saves* him!

All this is deeply significant, for since Israel had turned against Messiah, God was now to conclude them, along with the Gentiles, in unbelief, *"that He might have mercy upon all" (Rom.* 11:32).

Looking back, years later, Paul speaks of himself as one "who was before *a blasphemer, and a persecutor, and injurious,"* but goes on to explain that "the grace of our Lord was exceeding abundant," adding:

"This is a faithful saying, and worthy of all acceptation, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners; *of whom I am chief."*

But now notice most carefully how he closes his statement, for this the Church has almost completely overlooked:

"Howbeit *for this cause* I obtained *mercy, that* in me first Jesus Christ might show forth all longsuffering, *for a pattern to them which should hereafter believe on Him to life everlasting"* (I Tim. 1:13-16).

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[5] The Pentecostal Church, of course, not "the Church which is His [Christ's] Body."

It is difficult for this writer to understand how anyone can read this portion of Scripture without I realizing that God began something new with the conversion of Saul. Rather than judge Israel and the world immediately, God demonstrated *"the exceeding riches of His grace"* in the salvation of Saul, and ushered in the present *"dispensation of the grace of God."*

THE SUFFERINGS AND THE GLORY

What Peter saw and heard "in the holy mount" concerned the glory which he himself was to share at the reign of Christ. What Paul saw and heard, however, concerned the Lord's sufferings as well as his own. The One who had asked Saul, *"Why persecutest thou Me?"* said to Ananias, with respect to Saul, "*I will show him how great things he must suffer for My name's sake"* (Acts 9:4,16). The Lord was to be rejected still, but Paul, the sinner saved by grace, was to bear the sufferings of His rejection. Thus he declares in Col. 1:24:

"[I] now rejoice in my sufferings *for* you, and *fill up that which is behind*[6] of *the afflictions* of *Christ* in my flesh, for His body's sake, which is the Church."

Surely Paul did not mean, here, that he could add anything to our Lord's finished work for salvation. The point is simply that Christ is still rejected by the world, but rather than judge the offenders immediately He chose to remain a Royal Exile, leaving Paul -- and us -- here as ambassadors of His grace. Thus Saul, the persecutor, now became Paul, the persecuted, an ambassador for Christ on enemy territory.[7] The twelve also suffered for Christ, of course, but always in the hope that the nation would yet receive their Messiah, while Paul declares that he has been left here to proclaim an offer of grace and reconciliation to *a Christ-rejecting world.*

Christ is *still* rejected by Israel and the world, but who bears the sufferings of His rejection? We do - or should. We are in a world at enmity against God and His Son. Standing before men as the representatives of Jesus Christ, we cry:

". . . we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God did beseech you by us, we pray you in Christ's stead, be ye reconciled to God.

"For He hath made Him [Christ] to be sin for us, [Him] who knew no sin, that we might be made the righteousness of God in Him" (II Cor. 5:20,21).

Israel and the world have both been alienated from God, but we are here as ambassadors among enemy aliens, pleading with them to be reconciled to God through Christ who died for them.

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[6] I.e., which still remains - for Christ is rejected still.

[7] Thus Acts leaves Paul in prison at Rome. *"An ambassador in bonds."* How could God more clearly show His grace to His enemies?

Like Paul, we plead with men, saying in effect: "Christ is not here; you did not want Him. But we are here in His stead to tell you that He loves you and died for you so that you might be reconciled to God."

TWO MORE VOICES

We are loathe to close this chapter without dealing with the voices both Peter and Paul heard while they were in trances. Interestingly enough, it was Paul's experience, this time, that concerned the Jews and Peter's that concerned the Gentiles! But again we shall see the perfect harmony of the Scriptures in the unfolding of God's purpose.

PETER AT JOPPA
Acts 10:9-16

"On the morrow…Peter went up upon the housetop to pray, about the sixth hour.
"And he became very hungry, and would have eaten, but while they made ready, he fell into a trance, and saw heaven opened, and a certain vessel descending unto him, as it had been a great sheet, knit at the four corners and let down to the earth:
"Wherein were all manner of fourfooted beasts of the earth, and wild beasts, and creeping things, and fowls of the air.
"And there came a voice to him, Rise Peter; kill, and eat. But Peter said, Not so, Lord; for I have never eaten anything that is common or unclean. And the voice spake unto him again the second time, What God hath cleansed, that call not thou common.
"This was done thrice: and the vessel was received up again into heaven."

PAUL AT JERUSALEM
Acts 22:17-22

"And it came to pass, that, when I was come again to Jerusalem, even while I prayed in the temple, I was in a trance;
"And saw Him [Christ] saying unto me, Make haste, and get thee quickly out of Jerusalem, for they will not receive thy testimony concerning Me.
"And I said, Lord, they know that I imprisoned and beat in every synagogue them that believed on Thee;
"And when the blood of Thy martyr Stephen was shed, I also was standing by, and consenting unto his death, and kept the raiment of them that slew him.
"And He said unto me, Depart: for I will send thee far hence unto the Gentiles."
"And they gave him audience unto this word, and then lifted up their voices, and said, Away with such a fellow from the earth: for it is not fit that he should live."

Here again, Peter and Paul each heard a voice, but this time each while in a trance, and each while engaged in prayer.

Peter's experience concerned God's purpose to go to the Gentiles. Paul's concerned His purpose to *turn from* Israel. Both talked back to God, but both experiences emphasized God's purpose to turn from Israel to the nations.

Peter, in his abhorrence of the unclean, objected that he had never eaten anything common or unclean. Paul in his eagerness to win his kinsmen according to the flesh, argued that they all knew that he had imprisoned and beaten the believers and had even had a part in the stoning of Stephen. Surely they would listen to *him!*

In each case, however, the Lord insisted on carrying out His purpose. To Peter He said, "*What God hath cleansed, that call not thou common,"* and bade him go to the Gentile household of Cornelius, "nothing doubting." To Paul He replied summarily: *"Depart;* for I will send thee far hence unto the Gentiles."

We are quite aware of the fact that Peter did not proclaim the mystery of God's purpose and grace to these Gentiles. He did not even know it. Indeed, he did not even know why God was sending him and merely explained to his critics: "*What was I, that I could withstand God?"* (Acts 11:17).

Nevertheless, Peter's commission here was one of the first steps in the unfolding of the mystery of God's plan to bless the nations in spite of Israel's rejection of Christ. He made this very clear when, later defending Paul's Gentile ministry, he said: ". . . *ye know how . . . God made choice among us that the Gentiles by my mouth should hear the word of the gospel and believe"* (Acts 15:7). Spirit-led strategy, this, for how could the Jewish brethren object to Paul's Gentile ministry when their own Christ-appointed leader had been sent to preach the gospel to a Gentile household, and this under circumstances that clearly confirmed it to be God's will?

It was when Peter quoted an Old Testament prophecy which touched only upon faith in Christ for the remission of sins (Acts 10:43)[8] that God *interrupted* his discourse and the Holy Spirit came upon these Gentiles. Amazing incident! Thus while recognizing fully any kingdom aspect of Cornelius' conversion, we may not overlook the following important facts:

1. It took place *after* the conversion of Saul and is recorded in the very next chapter.

2. Peter was *not* sent to Cornelius under the so-called "great commission" but by a *special* commission (Acts 10:17, 20, 28, 29).

3. God did not send Peter to Cornelius because Israel was *accepting* Messiah, but because Israel was *rejecting* Him. In other words, it was not the next step in the carrying out of the "great commission," for the apostles had not yet finished their ministry at Jerusalem (Luke 24:47; Acts 1:8; Acts 8:1; Note: *"except the*

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[8] At Acts 10:43 *Prophecy and the Mystery coincide.* Thus the interruption of Vers. 44-45 before Peter even got to the *offer* stipulated in his "great commission" (Mark 16:16; cf. Acts 2:38), so that these uncircumcised Gentiles were saved entirely apart from water baptism. This subject is discussed more fully in *Acts Dispensationally Considered,* Vol. II, pp. 97-100.

apostles").

4. Again and again, in the story of Cornelius, it is emphasized that God had put *"no difference"* between Jew and Gentile. This will not be so when the "great commission" is carried out (Matt. 24:14). Then Christ will be king in Jerusalem and Israel will be exalted *above* the nations. But before the book of Acts draws to its close it is fully demonstrated (through the ministry of Paul) that there is "no difference" between Jew and Gentile, either as to sin (Rom. 3:22,23) or as to God's grace:

"For there is no difference between the Jew and the Greek, for the same Lord over all is rich unto all that call upon Him,

"For whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved" (Rom. 10:12,13).

5. It was on the basis of Peter's experience that Paul's ministry to the Gentiles was recognized by the Church at Jerusalem (Acts 15, cf. Gal. 2).

As to Paul's experience, it again emphasized the fact that God was about to send salvation to the Gentiles because of Israel's rejection of Christ. As Paul tells us, it took place upon his first return to Jerusalem after his conversion. Thus it shows us that Israel's rejection of Christ was now to be assumed, for the Lord said to him: *"They will not receive thy testimony concerning Me."* The rulers of Israel, and the nation as a whole, had not listened to the twelve; neither would they listen to Paul. God had *concluded them in unbelief* and was about to break off His dealings with them, as a nation.

As we have seen, God cast Israel out along with the Gentiles, so that He might deal with Jews and Gentiles *as individuals,* and in *grace.* We will have much more to say about this.

Chapter IV

TWO TIMES WHEN THE LORD ASKED WHY

THE KEY TO HEAVEN

The two greatest riddles of the universe and of human history are expressed in two questions asked by our Lord - on the two principal occasions when He who "knoweth all things" asked *"Why?"*

Once it was to God he cried "Why" and once to *Saul of Tarsus,* once to the *Holy One* and once to the *chief of sinners.* Once He cried "Why" from the *shameful cross* and once from *His glory in heaven.* In each case the name of the person addressed was repeated.

In Matt. 27:46 we find the first anguished "why?" wrung from His heart and lips as He cried from the cruel cross, *"My God, My God, why hast Thou forsaken Me?"* The other is found in Acts 9:4, where we read how He called from His throne in heaven, *"Saul, Saul, why persecutest thou Me?"*

"My God, My God, why host Thou forsaken Me?"

"Saul, Saul, why persecutest thou Me?"

These two questions represent the greatest riddles of history, and yet, strangely, one is the simple explanation of the other! One is the complement to the other.

Why did God forsake His beloved Son? Why did He *allow* wicked men to outrage and crucify the sinless, harmless Christ? You will find the answer only when you ask why mankind (represented by Saul) hated and hounded Christ to His death. God's action was the only antidote to man's. Christ's death was the only remedy for man's sin. It was because of the utter unreasonableness of man's sin, that a gracious God, to save him, had to be more than reasonable.

That "Christ died" is a historical fact that everyone knows. "Our sins" also constitute a fact which no one can deny. Yet either of these facts standing alone remains an insoluble mystery. We must accept God's explanation: *"Christ died FOR our sins"* (I Cor. 15:3) or we have two vexing problems we cannot explain. It has been rightly said that in the little preposition "for," here, we have *"the key to heaven."*

Thus in the two "whys" we here consider, the problems of Christ's death and our sin are solved. They solve each other. The Savior and the sinner are brought together. The blasphemer, the persecutor, is thoroughly transformed, and as he

considers Christ crucified, he gratefully exclaims, *"He loved me, and gave Himself for me"* (Gal. 2:20).

SAUL THE SINNER

Consider the picture given to us in the Book of Acts. There is one nation, only one, which God recognizes as His own and, behold, *this* nation joins the others in rebellion against Him! And who inspires and leads the rebellion? *Saul of Tarsus!*

But who is this Saul of Tarsus? A ruffian, a cut-throat? Indeed not! He is one of the chosen race, highly respected by his nation. He is a scrupulous observer of the Law, zealous of the traditions of his fathers.

Is he ignorant of the Old Testament prophecies, then, that he does not recognize Christ? No! He is a Pharisee, the son of a line of Pharisees, a Hebrew of the Hebrews, of the proud tribe of Benjamin, a spiritual leader in Israel with a profound knowledge of the Law and the prophets.

Yet this man leads Israel in a bitter persecution against the followers of Christ, determined to stamp out the name and memory of Jesus.

The divine Record relates how, at the stoning of Stephen, *"Saul was consenting unto his death,"* and informs us that the murder of Stephen touched off a *"great persecution"* in which *"Saul. . . made havock of the Church, entering into every house, and haling men and women, committed them to prison"* (Acts 8:1-3).

Indeed, Paul himself later acknowledged: *"'And being exceedingly mad against them, I persecuted them even unto strange cities"* (Acts 26:11). It was in connection with the last of these "strange cities," that we read:

"And Saul, yet breathing out threatenings and slaughter against the disciples of the lord, went unto the high priest,

"And desired of him letters to Damascus to the synagogues, that if he found any of this way, whether they were men or women, he might bring them bound unto Jerusalem" (Acts 9:1,2).

Armed thus with *"authority and commission from the chief priests"* (Acts 26:12), Saul made it his determined purpose to apprehend as many disciples as he could and *"bring them. . . bound unto Jerusalem for to be punished"* (Acts 22:5).

This purpose was never fulfilled, for he himself was apprehended by the glorified Lord and was saved on the road to Damascus. But when the Lord sent Ananias to minister to him, Ananias replied,

"Lord, I have heard by many of this man, how much evil he hath done to Thy

saints at Jerusalem;

"And here he hath authority from the chief priests to bind all that call on Thy name" (Acts 9:13, 14).

And when the Damascus believers heard him testify of Christ, they said, *"Is not this he that destroyed them which called on this name in Jerusalem?"* (Acts 9:21).

Later, in prayer, Paul confessed to Christ: *"I imprisoned and beat in every synagogue them that believed on Thee"* (Acts 22:19), and before Agrippa he testified:

"And many of the saints did I shut up in prison . . . and when they were put to death I gave my voice [vote] against them.

"And I punished them oft in every synagogue, and compelled them to blaspheme" (Acts 26: 10, 11).

All this and more we find in Luke's record of Paul's deeds and confessions, but to this the Apostle adds his own written statements:

". . . beyond measure I persecuted the Church of God and wasted it [laid it waste]" (Gal. 1:13).

"For I am the least of the apostles, that am not meet to be called an apostle, because I persecuted the Church of God, but by the grace of God I am what I am" (I Cor. 15:9,10).

"And I thank Christ Jesus our Lord, who hath enabled me, for that He counted me faithful, putting me into the ministry, who was before a *blasphemer, and* a persecutor, *and injurious" (I Tim. 1:12,13).*

It is true that the Apostle explains in this passage that he "did it ignorantly in unbelief," but he does not do this to absolve himself from guilt. As Saul, the Pharisee, he could and *should* have known that Jesus was the Christ, but he did not wish to believe this. His ignorance, therefore, was unreasonable and inexcusable. His ignorance and unbelief, indeed, moved the compassionate heart of God, just as we might pity one who injures himself by his blind obstinacy, but his attitude was nevertheless totally inexcusable.

Indeed, he himself emphasizes his *sin* as he points out that it was only because *"the grace of our Lord was exceeding abundant* that he, the *"chief"* of *"sinners"* was saved. In fact, it is from this premise that he argues that the grace of God is sufficient to save *any* sinner (I Tim. 1:15,16).

SAUL AND THE HUMAN RACE

It should be clearly understood that Saul of Tarsus, the blasphemer and murderer, represented the whole human race in its rebellion against God and His Christ. The only channel through which God had still maintained relations with the world in Saul's day was the nation Israel, and Saul had become the leader of Israel's rebellion. Saul represented Israel and Israel represented the world. Saul represented the spirit of Israel's rebellion, yea, the spirit of *the world's rebellion against God and His Christ* (Psa. 2:1-3).

It was the incredible unreasonableness of the world's enmity against Christ, that our Lord expressed when He called from heaven: *"Why persecutest thou Me?"*

CHRIST AND THE HUMAN RACE

All about us people are asking "Why?" *Why* this long, painful illness? *Why* this unbearable burden? *Why* this heart-breaking bereavement? *Why* this horrible war? *Why* does God permit all this sorrow and trouble and misery and death? *Why? ... why? ... why?*

But those who ask why God permits sorrow and misery and death to afflict humanity generally overlook a much greater question. *Why did God forsake Christ at Calvary?* We sinners may expect sorrow and misery and trouble, but Christ had not sinned. Why should He, the Holy One, who "went about doing good," be made to suffer agony and shame for sins He had never committed? How could a just God, much less a loving Father, stand by and allow evil men to subject His Son to suffering and death - yea, the "death of the cross"?

But this raises another question: Why did God permit *sin* in the first place? If it be answered that originally God created man in His own image, as a free moral agent, with the power to choose for himself, then *why* did God create him thus or why, at least, did He not prevent him from sinning, or somehow restrict or qualify his power to actively choose between right and wrong? And the more such questions we ask, the more they raise.

Doubtless all such questions can be met in Scripture with, not only satisfactory, but *satisfying,* even *gratifying* answers. But the basic solution to this great riddle is found at *Calvary.* There we find ample evidence that God did not act impulsively or capriciously, or without regard to man's good, in permitting sin to enter the human race. There we see Christ, God's beloved Son, *dying* as a malefactor *for our sins.*

Thus we have the solution to *both* riddles: *Christ's death* and *our sins,* in those blessed words from Paul's God-given message: *""Christ died for our sins"* (I Cor. 15:3). It is indeed true that in the little preposition "for," here, we have *""the key to heaven."*

"Christ died FOR our *sins"* (I Cor. 15:3).

This is the solution to the two greatest riddles of the universe and of history: the riddles of the death of Christ and the sin of man.

"This is a faithful saying and worthy of all acceptation, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am chief" (I Tim. 1:15).

If it is not true that the Lord Jesus Christ came into this world voluntarily and especially to suffer and die for our sins, then there is no reason for anything. Then, to be sure, "Right is on the scaffold" and "wrong is on the throne," and God Himself might well be charged with injustice, even cruelty, for allowing one who was at least a good and innocent man to die in agony and disgrace at the hands of wicked men.

The "Why?" of the cross, then, is explained by the "Why?" of the Damascus road. Because of the unreasonableness of man's enmity and sin, God, to save him, had to be *more than reasonable* and give His Son – Himself - to pay the penalty for man's sin, and this in infinite love and grace, He did.

THE RICHES OF GRACE REVEALED

We read in Luke 18:31-33 that our Lord told the twelve apostles that He would suffer and die and rise again the third day, but the record goes on to say:

"They understood none of these things; and this saying was hid from them, neither knew they the things which were spoken" (Ver. 34).

After His death and resurrection, of course, these apostles understood that the Scriptures had been fulfilled, but they did not, even yet, understand the full significance of Christ's death and resurrection. This was still "hid from them." God was waiting to reveal it at a later time, through the Apostle Paul.

"For there is one God, and one Mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus;

"Who gave Himself a ransom for all, TO BE TESTIFIED IN DUE TIME.

'Whereunto I [Paul] am ordained a preacher and an apostle, (I speak the truth in Christ and lie not), a teacher of the Gentiles in faith and verity" (I Tim. 2:5-7; cf. Gal. 3:23; Tit. 1:2,3).

Peter at Pentecost did not proclaim our Lord's death as God's great remedy for sin. He *charged* Israel with the death of Christ and warned that God had raised Him from the dead to sit on David's throne, their rejection of Him as their King

notwithstanding (Acts 2:25-36). He did not say: "Christ died for your sins. Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ and you will be saved." It was Paul who first said this some time later. Peter said to his convicted hearers: *"Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins. . . ."* (Acts 2:38).

Many, confusing Peter's ministry with Paul's, still proclaim water baptism for the remission of sins, or require it for church membership, or at least add it *after* having proclaimed the "finished" work of Christ for salvation.

But what saith the Scripture? It is not until Paul arrives upon the scene that we learn that believers may be *"justified freely by [God's] grace, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus"* (Rom. 3:24).

It is Paul, and no one until Paul, who declares:

"But now the righteousness of God *without the low* is manifested, being witnessed by the law and the prophets" (Rom. 3:21).

"[We] declare, I say, *at this time*, His righteousness; that He might be just and the Justifier of him which believeth in Jesus" (Ver. 26).

There is a vast difference between the message of Peter at Pentecost and Paul's subsequent message concerning the death and resurrection of Christ. And there is a vast difference between Peter's demand for repentance and baptism "for the remission of sins," and Paul's later offer of Christ's righteousness "for the remission of sins."

If Peter, at Pentecost, laboring under the so-called "great commission," had known that *"we have redemption through His [Christ's] blood, the forgiveness of sins according to the riches of His grace,"* would he not have preached this glorious truth to the guilty multitude? But the Scriptures make it unmistakably clear that this great truth was not "testified" until "due time" *through the Apostle Paul* (I Tim. 2:5-7; Tit. 1:2,3; *et al).*

To understand God's prophesied purpose concerning the kingdom to be established on earth, always associate Christ with the twelve apostles and the twelve tribes of Israel. But to understand God's hidden purpose, "the mystery," always associate our Lord with *Paul.* Bring the Savior and the chief of sinners together, and *what a happy combination!* Hear again Paul's own testimony about this:

"This is a faithful saying and worthy of all acceptation, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of *whom I am chief.*

"Howbeit, FOR THIS CAUSE, I obtained mercy, that in me first Jesus Christ

might show forth all longsuffering, for a pattern to them which should hereafter believe on Him to life everlasting" (I Tim. 1:15,16).

AN OLD TESTAMENT ILLUSTRATION

Perhaps an Old Testament episode will serve to illustrate salvation under *'"the dispensation of the grace of God"* and to explain why God specifically chose the chief of sinners to demonstrate and proclaim this message of grace.

THE HARLOT RAHAB

"By faith the harlot Rahab perished not with them that believed not, when she had received the spies with peace" (Heb. 11:31).

The report that the twelve spies brought back from Canaan while Israel was still in the wilderness was a challenging one to say the least.

On the one hand Canaan was reported to be *"an exceedingly good land,"* flowing, as it were, *"with milk and honey"* (Num. 14:7,8). But on the other, its inhabitants were *"strong"* and the cities *"walled, and very great'* (13:28). Or, as Deut. 1:28 has it: *"The people is greater and taller than we; the cities are great, and walled up to heaven. . . ."*

Jericho was the foremost of these great walled cities. Archeological excavations have confirmed the testimony of ancient writers as to the size of the walls in Joshua's day. In addition to an outer wall, six feet in thickness, there was an inner wall, twelve feet thick and thirty feet high. This afforded almost invincible protection against the mightiest armies of those days.

THE FAITH OF RAHAB

Yet, inside the city there was fear. Fear of Israel, whose God, Jehovah, had delivered them from Egypt, had dried a path for them through the Red Sea, had brought them, families and cattle included, across the wilderness, and had already given them significant victories in their conquest of Canaan.

It was to this city that Joshua had sent two spies, who had now found protection in the house of Rahab, the harlot, atop Jericho's wall. That the spies were not in Rahab's house for any immoral purpose is clear from the record of Scripture, but, more than this, Rahab not only feared Jehovah now; she *believed* in Him. Hear her moving testimony:

"And she said unto the men, I know that the Lord hath given you the land, and that your terror is fallen upon us, and that all the inhabitants of the land faint because of you.

"For we have heard how the Lord dried up the water of the Red Sea for you, when ye came out of Egypt; and what ye did unto the two kings of the Amorites, that were on the other side of Jordan, Sihon and Og, whom ye utterly destroyed.

"And as soon as we had heard these things, our hearts did melt, neither did there remain any more courage in any man, because of you: FOR THE LORD YOUR GOD, HE IS GOD IN HEAVEN ABOVE, AND IN EARTH BENEATH" (Josh. 2:9-11).

The closing statement of this passage points up the difference between Rahab and the rest of Jericho's inhabitants, for it was an expression of her personal faith in Jehovah, God of Israel. They *feared* Him, but she feared *and believed* in Him. This is why she *"perished not with them that believed not"* (Heb. 11:31).

FURTHER EVIDENCES OF HER FAITH

The evidences of Rahab's faith are seen in her testimony, in the fact that she hid the spies and made a covenant with them, and in other ways. But on the moral and spiritual side the evidence is most touching of all.

Doubtless ashamed of her past, she now becomes concerned about the family she has disgraced, for she goes on to say:

"Now, therefore, I pray you, swear unto me by the Lord [Heb., Jehovah] since I have showed you kindness, that ye will also show kindness unto my father's house, and give me a true token:

"And that ye will save alive my father, and my mother, and my brethren, and my sisters, and all that they have, and deliver our lives from death" (Josh. 2:12, 13).

Before escaping out of Rahab's window by the scarlet rope she had provided, the spies not only swore to *"deal kindly and truly"* with her, but went even farther. See the record:

"Behold, when we come into the land, thou shalt bind this line of scarlet thread[9] in the window which thou didst let us down by; and thou shalt bring thy father, and thy mother, and thy brethren, and all thy father's household, home unto thee.

"And it shall be, that whosoever shall go out of the doors of thy house into the street, his blood shall be upon his head, and we will be guiltless; and WHOSOEVER SHALL BE WITH THEE IN THE HOUSE, his blood shall be on our head, if any hand be upon him" (Josh. 2:18,19).

That wonderful word, *whosoever!* How often we find it in the epistles of Paul and the writings of John in connection with salvation! Here it appears in type! Nor

[9] The "true token."

does this in any way indicate that "the mystery" revealed to Paul was after all *not* a secret "hid from ages and generations," for *no one* at the time knew that these people and things *were* types, much less what they typified. They only show *us now* that God's heart was full of His "eternal purpose."

Thus another evidence of Rahab's faith is seen in Ver. 21, where we read: "... and they departed; and she bound the scarlet line in the window," as "a true token" - both to her and to them. The same scarlet line which was the means of *their* escape would also be used as the means of *her* escape and that of all who would be with her in her home.

What a beautiful foreshadowing was this scarlet line of *"the precious blood of Christ,"* through which all believers *"have redemption. . . according* to *the riches of His grace"!* (I Pet. 1:18,19; Eph. 1:7).

"THEM THAT BELIEVED NOT"

We know that the vast majority of the inhabitants of Jericho "believed not," for Josh. 6 informs us that after the deliverance of Rahab and all that were with her, the city was utterly destroyed," with all that was in it (Vers. 20-23).

But is there a hint, a rather broad one, that some of Rahab's own family did not believe? *She* had asked the spies to swear that they would save alive her whole family, including "my sisters, and all that they have" (Josh. 2:13), but they had not promised to do this. Rather they said, "and thou shalt bring thy father, and thy mother, and thy brethren, and all thy father's household,[10] home unto thee" (Ver. 18).

Why did they omit Rahab's sisters, for whose deliverance Rahab had specifically pleaded? Was this a careless oversight on their part? Or, rather, was it an inspired omission, because her sisters were not to be with her in her home when the city was taken?

The ensuing record explains. In the 6th chapter, where we have the record of the conquest of Jericho, we read that the spies went in and delivered "Rahab . . . and her father's household, and all that she had" (Ver. 25), but this is a general statement (as in Verso 22,23) and the "all that she had" may well refer to all that she had *with her* in the house, for we know that only these were to be saved (2:19; 6:17).

But Josh. 6:23, the passage which enumerates specifically those who were saved, again omits the sisters from the list. The passage reads:

"And the young men that were spies went in, and brought out Rahab, and her father, and her mother, and her brethren, and all that she had; and they brought

[10] The household would include the servants.

out all her kindred,[11] and left them without the camp of Israel" (6:23).[12]

In this case the omission of the sisters from the list can hardly be the result of an oversight, for here we have, not the record of what the spies *said,* but the inspired record of what actually *happened.*

We bring this matter up, first to emphasize the fact that *only* those who were with Rahab in the house were saved, according to the promise. None were saved merely because they were related to her. But further, as we see it, this omission of Rahab's sisters emphasizes also the relation of human pride to unbelief.

It is easy to imagine the reaction of some of Jericho's inhabitants upon learning that whoever should be in the house with Rahab when Israel attacked, would be spared! "Go into a house of ill repute to find mercy! Take refuge with a harlot! Never! We will take our chances with the good people of Jericho," some would say. And of Rahab's family it would doubtless be her sisters who were most loathe to enter in, having been most deeply hurt by her conduct.[13]

Thus, to be saved from Jericho's ruin, it was necessary to take shelter in a house of ill repute, with a fallen, now-redeemed, woman. "Whosoever shall be with thee in the house"; these were the distinct conditions of the promise.

RAHAB AND PAUL

Here we can practically hear some reader object: "Are you going to compare Paul with *Rahab!"* Well, did not Paul call himself the chief of sinners in I Tim. 1:15? This was not from mere modesty on Paul's part; he wrote *by divine inspiration;* it is part of the written Word of God.

Is it objected that Rahab's sin was worse than Paul's had been? We do not deny that Paul had been a different kind of sinner, but he was *no less* a sinner. Recall how our Lord had answered Nicodemus (another Pharisee), the religious philosopher, with a blunt *"Ye must be born again"* (John 3:7), while in the next chapter He graciously says to the fallen woman of Samaria:

"If thou knewest the gift of God, and who it is that saith to thee, Give me to drink; thou wouldest have asked of Him, and He would have given thee living water"

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[11] I.e., all that were "with her in the house."

[12] The record describes how God had Israel's army march around Jericho until the soldiers must have been utterly exhausted. Thus the victory, and certainly the overthrow of the walls, was wholly the work of God, and *had* to be by faith rather than by fighting. But here some famous artists have erred, depicting Rahab's house perched precariously atop one small segment of the wall that did *not* fall. But the walls *did* fall in their entirety *after* the spies had gone in, doubtless via the scarlet line, and delivered Rahab and her household (Vers. 22,23).

[13] We find no indication that Rahab's corrupt pursuit had any connection with Jericho's religion. She was merely "a harlot," living atop the city wall, where Jericho's soldiers were most apt to be found.

(John 4:10).

Moreover, He bluntly said to Israel's religious leaders,

"Verily I say unto you, that the publicans and the harlots go into the kingdom of God before you" (Matt. 21:31).

Thus does a holy God hate pride in sinful man, and thus do we read in God's Word that he "resists the proud" and "knows them afar off."

True, Paul, as Saul of Tarsus, had been *conscientious* in his religious beliefs, but he was also self-righteous and a rebel against Christ, determined to stamp His name and memory from the pages of history. And, as we have said, he clearly states the reason why he, the chief of sinners, had been saved, in his moving declaration of I Tim. 1:16:

". . . FOR THIS CAUSE I OBTAINED MERCY, THAT IN ME FIRST [OR CHIEFLY][14] JESUS CHRIST MIGHT SHOW FORTH ALL LONGSUFFERING, FOR A PATTERN TO THEM WHICH SHOULD HEREAFTER BELIEVE ON HIM TO LIFE EVERLASTING."

Thus, as in the case of Jericho deliverance was promised to all who should be with Rahab in her house, so today salvation is promised to all who take their place with Paul, the chief of sinners saved by grace; who say in effect: "I am a sinner too; I will follow the Apostle Paul and trust the Lord Jesus Christ as the One who 'came into the world to save *sinners.'"*

In conclusion, Rahab the harlot, like Ruth the Moabitess, become *an ancestress of our Lord Jesus Christ!* Her name is still illustriously inscribed among the four women mentioned in our Lord's genealogy (Matt. 1:5). What an honor!

Thus does our great and loving God take the lowest who trust Him, and give them the highest places of honor and blessing. As we think of Rahab's past and what God graciously did for her, how can we help recalling Eph. 2, where we read of those who were once *"the children[15] of disobedience,"* and therefore, *"by nature the children[16] of wrath, even as others":*

"But God, who is rich in mercy, for His great love wherewith He loved us,

"Even when we were dead in sins, hath quickened us together with Christ (by grace ye are saved),

"And hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in

[14] The same root rendered "chief' in Ver. 15.
[15] Gr., *huios,* grown sons.
[16] Gr., *teknon,* born ones.

Christ Jesus:

"That in the ages to come He might show the exceeding riches of His grace in His kindness toward us through Christ Jesus" (Eph. 2:4-7).

May God help any unsaved reader of this chapter to take His place with Paul, the chief of sinners saved by grace, and so come to know the joy of salvation by grace through faith alone.

Chapter V

A NEW BUILDING

THE FOUNDATION LAID

Paul's first letter to the Corinthians contains a passage which every preacher and Christian worker should consider very prayerfully. It is I Cor. 3:10-15:

"According to the grace of God which is given unto me, as a wise masterbuilder, *I [Paul] have laid the foundation*, and another buildeth thereon. But let every man take heed how he buildeth thereupon.

"For other foundation can no man lay than that is laid, which is Jesus Christ.

"Now if any man build upon this foundation gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay, stubble;

"Every man's work shall be made manifest; for the day shall declare it, because it shall be revealed by fire, and *the fire shall try every man's work of what sort it is.*

"If any man's work abide, which he hath built thereupon, he shall receive a reward.

"If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: but he himself shall be saved, yet so as by fire."

Mark well, the Apostle did not build upon the foundation which the twelve had laid;[17] he *laid the foundation* of the Church, the Body of Christ. The above exhortation, then, is sounded particularly to the builders of the Church of the present dispensation.

In Ver. 9 he says, "For *we* are *laborers together with God. . . ye* are *God's building."* In other words, Paul and those associated with him as workers for Christ were the *builders,* while the Corinthian believers as a body were the *building - part* of that greater building which is called *the Church.*

In order to get the full significance of this passage let us consider another which centers not around Paul, but around Peter.

PETER AND THE MESSIANIC CHURCH

"When Jesus came into the coasts of Caesarea Philippi, He asked His disciples,

[17] Except as his message was a *further* revelation of truth (Eph. 2:20).

saying, whom do men say that I, the Son of man, am?

"And they said, some say that Thou art John the Baptist, some Elias, and others, Jeremias, or one of the prophets.

"He saith unto them, But whom say ye that I am? "And Simon Peter answered and said, Thou art the Christ, the San of the living God.

"And Jesus answered and said unto Him, Blessed art thou, Simon Bar-jona: for flesh and blood hath not revealed it unto thee, but My Father which is in heaven.

"And I say also unto thee, that thou art Peter, and upon this rock I will build My church; and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it.

"And I will give unto thee the keys of the kingdom of heaven; and whatsoever thou shalt bind on earth shall be bound in heaven, and whatsoever thou shalt loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven" (Matt. 16:13-19).

Note carefully that it was Peter's *confession* that won for him the name "rock" (Gr., Petros, a stone), for it was upon this "Rock" (Gr., *Petra,* a mass of rock) that the Messianic Church was to be built. It is a great mistake to fail to note the distinction between these two Greek words, and to make Peter himself the foundation, for, as we have just seen from I Cor. 3:11 *"Other foundation can no man lay than that is laid, which is Jesus Christ."*

It should be further noted that Peter here confessed Jesus as *"the Christ* [Heb., *the Messiah],* the Son of the living God."

For some time John the Baptist, our Lord and the twelve had been crying to Israel, *"Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand."* This was the *theme* of their message.[18] But the kingdom of heaven, the Church of which our Lord spoke was, of course, to be set up *on earth,* for the Old Testament abounds with prophecies concerning the rule of the heavens on earth, with Christ as King. Referring to the "Stone" which should smite the last of earth's kingdoms, Daniel says:

"And in the days of these kings shall the God of heaven set up a kingdom which shall never be destroyed: and the kingdom shall not be left to other people, but it shall break in pieces and consume all these kingdoms, and it shall stand forever" (Dan. 2:44).

This is the "kingdom of heaven" which the twelve were sent to *proclaim* (Matt. 10:7), to *practice* (Matt. 10:8-10), and to *pray for* in the prayer, "Thy kingdom *come,* Thy will be done, *in earth as it is in heaven"* (Matt. 6:10).

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[18] In Matthew this is specifically noted of *John* (3:1,2), and *Christ* (4:17), and *the twelve* (10:7).

Peter's confession agrees with Nathanael's: *"Rabbi, Thou art the Son of God; Thou art the King of Israel"* (John 1:49) and with half a dozen such confessions found in the four Gospels.

Thus it was Peter's confession, "Thou art *the Christ, the Son of the living God,"* upon which this Church and kingdom were to be built. That is, it was to be built upon a recognition of Jesus as God's anointed *King*[19] *- Messiah.*

PETER'S POSITION

This is not to minimize, for a moment, the importance of Peter's position in the building of this Church, for in view of Israel's rejection of Christ, Peter, as the leader of Israel's twelve future judges (Matt. 19:28), was given the *keys* of the kingdom; the power to admit or shut out. Indeed, in Matt. 16:19 Peter is told, even before the others,

"Whatsoever thou shalt bind on earth shall be bound in heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven."

Thus he was given *official* powers until Christ Himself should return and the twelve should judge and reign with Him.[20]

Before our Lord left this world He went so far as to say to His apostles:

"Receive ye the Holy Ghost: Whose soever sins ye remit they are remitted unto them; and whose soever sins ye retain, they are retained" (John 20:22,23).

Confused Protestantism has had a difficult time explaining these verses to Roman Catholics, and we shall presently see why.

However, these high official powers, including even the remission of sins, should be viewed in the light *of* Acts 2:4 and 38, for our Lord surely did not put the forgiveness of sins into the hands of failing, erring believers: *God* would be working *through* them.

"And they were all FILLED WITH THE HOLY GHOST."

"Then Peter said unto them, Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of *Jesus* Christ *for* the remission of sins. . . ."

They could baptize for the remission of sins only because they were *filled with the Holy Spirit,* completely under His control.

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[19] Actually His anointed Prophet, Priest *and* King.

[20] Remember, the present dispensation was then still a "mystery hid in God."

ANOTHER BUILDING

Israel, however, did not repent as a nation and the building of that Church could not go on to completion. With Messiah, the Foundation and Corner Stone rejected, the building soon lay in ruins.

It was when Israel had resisted the Holy Spirit and refused to acknowledge even the risen Lord as Christ that God began to unfold the mystery of His secret purpose and grace. They had refused to build upon the foundation which Peter had laid. Now God was to erect *another* building.[21]

The blessing of the nations *through Israel* was now to be held in abeyance until a future day (Rom. 15:8,9; cf. Rom. 11:15,25,26). He would cast Israel away nationally (Rom. 11:15) so that He might deal with the whole world in grace (Rom. 11:32),

"And that He might *reconcile both* [believing Jews and Gentiles] unto God in one *body* by the cross, having slain the enmity thereby" (Eph. 2:16).

This is the "one new man" of Eph. 2:15, the building whose foundation, under God, was laid by Paul (I Cor. 3:10), the Church of the present dispensation, "the church, which is His Body" (Eph. 1:22,23). To see further Paul's connection with this new program the reader should study carefully Eph. 3:1-11.

In a sense God has always had His *Church,* His called-out people. Yet we must be careful not to confuse the present Church of which Ephesians speaks with the Church of which our Lord spoke to Peter. *That* was a prophesied Church. *This* was a mystery, a secret, until the raising up of Paul. The plans and specifications for *that* Church are found in the Old Testament Scriptures. The plans and specifications for *this* Church were *"kept secret since the* world began" (Rom. 16:25), *"hid from* ages and *generations"* (Col. 1:26), *"in other ages. . . not made known"* (Eph. 3:5).

You ask, "Did not Peter and Paul both build on the same foundation?" Yes, but *that* Church was built upon Jesus Christ *as Israel's Messiah,* whereas *this* Church is built upon Him *as the glorified Head of the Body,* rejected on earth, but exalted at God's right hand.

This distinction is clearly seen by a comparison of Acts 2 with II Tim. 2.

In the former passage *Peter* says distinctly that God raised Christ from the dead *to sit on the throne of David* (Acts 2:29,30 and cf. Vers. 31-38).

But in the latter *Paul* says:

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[21] Though still part of the great superstructure which God has been building through the ages. See the author's brochure, *The Temple of God.*

"Consider what I say; and the Lord give thee understanding in all things.

"Remember that Jesus Christ, of the seed of David, was raised from the dead *according* to *my gospel;*

"Wherein I suffer trouble, as an evil doer, even unto bonds; but the Word of God is not bound" (II Tim. 2:7-9).

To understand what Paul means when he informs us that Christ, the Seed of David, was also raised from the dead according to *his* gospel we should turn to Eph. 1 and 2, where Paul prays that believers might be given the spiritual perception to appreciate:

". . . what is *the hope of His calling, and what the riches of the glory of His inheritance in the saints,*

"And what is *the exceeding greatness of His power to us-ward who believe, according to the working of His mighty power,*

"Which He wrought in Christ, when He raised Him from the dead and set Him at His own right hand in the heavenly places,

"For above all principality, and power, and might, and dominion, and every name that is named, not only in this world, but also in that which is to come" (Eph. 1: 18-21).

"But God, who is rich in mercy, for His great love wherewith He loved us,

"Even when we were dead in sins, hath quickened us together with Christ, (by grace ye are saved);

"And *hath raised us up together,* and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus" (Eph. 2:4-6).

The reader should study the whole passage from Eph. 1:15 right through Eph. 2:11 and see the wonderful power of God in raising Christ from the dead and exalting Him *"far above all,"* and see how this mighty power is extended *"to us-ward who believe"* as He raises *us* from the dead with Christ and gives us a position with Him in the heavenlies!

Surely Peter would have preached this glorious message at Pentecost had he known it. But he did not know it. At Pentecost he *accused* his hearers of the murder committed at Calvary, and preached Christ as the Savior-King *whom God had raised from the dead to sit on David's throne.* He called upon Israel to repent and be baptized for the remission of sins so that the times of refreshing, so long

promised, might come, and that God might send back Jesus, whom they had refused (Acts 3:19,20).

Peter's message was accompanied by great miraculous demonstrations, but who would sigh for "Pentecostal power" when he has come to know "the power of His resurrection?" (Phil. 3:10). Little wonder that Paul said, *"Remember that Jesus Christ of the seed of David* was raised from the dead according to *my gospel."*

It is this message that Satan so hates, and for which Paul was made to suffer trouble as an evil doer. It seemed that with Israel's rejection of Christ all hope was gone. It seemed not only that man had rendered his own salvation impossible, but that God's promises had failed. *And then came the revelation of the mystery!*

Before judging this Christ-rejecting world and setting His Anointed up as King, He *saved* the very leader of the rebellion and sent him forth with the glorious proclamation of grace, an offer of reconciliation to all His enemies, by grace through faith alone. What had been accomplished at Calvary; what our Lord's death and resurrection had wrought, had now been gloriously demonstrated by the salvation of the chief of sinners. Moreover, the salvation of Saul was a master-stroke of divine strategy, for it robbed the enemy of its flaming leader and put all his energies and all his devotion to work proclaiming *grace* to a condemned humanity!

This is the climax of divine revelation. No wonder Satan hates it. It demonstrates the exceeding sinfulness of man's sin and the riches of God's grace. It shows the *utter* helplessness of man and the mighty power of God. Indeed, it proclaims Satan's *utter* defeat, as we read with reference to the cross in Col. 2:15:

"And having spoiled [plundered, ruined] principalities and powers, He made a show of them openly, *triumphing over them IN IT."*

PAUL, THE MASTERBUILDER

Paul was not presumptuous when he called himself the "masterbuilder" of the Church of this age. He makes it clear that this position was given to him *"according to the grace of God."* Indeed, he consistently associates his unique position with the "over-abounding" grace of God, and when he emphasizes it he does so only to exalt the grace of God.

Moses was the masterbuilder of the tabernacle. God gave him the plans and specifications and said,

"See. . . that thou make all things according to the pattern showed to thee in the mount" (Heb. 8:5).

But as Moses represented the Law so Paul represents grace, for to him, as a "wise," or instructed masterbuilder, our Lord committed the plans and specifications for the Church of the dispensation of grace. Paul did not receive the full plan at once, to be sure, but step by step it was made known to him by direct revelations from the Lord Himself.

Little wonder he warns: "*I have laid the foundation. . . . Let every man take heed how he buildeth thereupon."*

How deplorable that many, yes most, preachers and teachers of the Word have ignored this warning! They have taken Petrine and Mosaic material and built it upon the foundation of grace laid by Paul. They talk about "building the kingdom," and try vainly to carry out the *wrong* commission - that given to the twelve. They have taken baptism, tongues, healings and signs of the times from another dispensation and brought them into "the dispensation of the grace of God," until the Church is so confused and divided that no one knows what to believe.

Are our spiritual leaders unaware of the condition of the Church, or have they forgotten that they will give an account before God when the building is inspected?

Surely God is not to blame for the condition of the Church. *The builders are to blame.* The truth of the matter is that most of them keep so busy "getting things going" that they have little time left to study the Word.

It is often argued that "souls are being saved," but will the builders of the Church never awaken to the fact that hands raised and people coming forward *do not measure the success of their work? Does thei*r *work abide? Will it abide the fire of His inspection?* These are the questions that must take first place (I Cor. 3:13-15).

When we consider the thousands upon thousands who have professed Christ in the vast evangelistic campaigns of the last decades alone, one would surely expect that Philadelphia, Chicago or New York City would be thoroughly shaken by the gospel, but not so. *Some* are truly converted to Christ, thank God, but great numbers of these "converts" go back into the world, and the majority who remain are so weak and untaught that the world laughs at them.

Let us face the fact, then, the Church has lost the power of the Spirit. It is much larger than it was in Paul's day, but also much weaker, spiritually.

The solution? It is found in a passage often quoted, but all too little practiced:

"Study to show thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, *rightly dividing the Word* of *truth" (II Tim. 2:15).*

Chapter VI

PAUL AND WATER BAPTISM

WAS PAUL SENT TO BAPTIZE?

"I thank God that I baptized none of you, but Crispus and Gaius;

"lest any should say that I had baptized in mine own name.

"And I baptized also the household of Stephanas: besides, I know not whether I baptized any other.

"For Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel; not with wisdom of words, lest the cross of Christ should be made of none effect.

"For the preaching of the cross is to them that perish foolishness; but unto us which are saved it is the power of God."

- I Cor. 1:14-18

WAS PAUL SENT TO BAPTIZE?

Many sincere believers experience grave problems with this passage of Scripture. Particularly difficult for them to accept is Ver. 17, where the Apostle declares: *""Christ sent* me *not to baptize but to preach the gospel. . . .*"

Did he really mean that baptism was not part of his divine commission? Or did he mean that he was not sent *primarily* to baptize, but to preach the gospel?

The question of water baptism has, in the past, generated more heat than light, with the result that the real issue has been beclouded and churches have suffered deep divisions over *who* should be baptized and *how,* when they should first have faced up to the primary question: Should we practice water baptism at all? *Is it included in God's program for the dispensation of grace?*

Let us then go to the Word for the answer to this first and basic question, for the Bible *does* give us light, clear light, on this subject.

First, it is clear that John the Baptist *was* sent to baptize, for in John 1:33 we have his words:

". . . He that SENT ME TO BAPTIZE with water. . . ."

We know too that the eleven (their number later restored to twelve) were sent to

baptize, for in Matt. 28:19 we have the record of our Lord's commission to them:

"Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, *BAPTIZING THEM* in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost."

These words were spoken by our Lord after His resurrection. Thus not only did the twelve baptize when they labored with Christ on earth (John 4:2); they were later *sent,* under their "great commission," to teach and *to baptize* after our Lord's departure from this earth. They began to carry out this commission at Pentecost, baptizing about three thousand of their hearers in that one day.

But here comes Paul; converted to Christ *after* Pentecost, far away from Jerusalem, and entirely apart from the twelve. And where do we find that this *other apostle* was ever commissioned to baptize? Nowhere.

Thus we must conclude that he meant just what he said in I Cor. 1:11:

". . . Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel. . . . "

We have both negative and positive evidence, then, that the risen, glorified Lord did *not* send Paul to baptize; that baptism was *not* part of his special commission.

THE IMPORTANCE OF WATER BAPTISM UNDER JOHN AND THE TWELVE

As we have seen from I Cor. 1:14-16, Paul thanked God that he had baptized so few of the Corinthian believers.

We are aware of the argument that the Apostle had personally baptized so few only because he wanted no part in the divisions among them, or lest some should say that he had baptized in his own name, i.e., by his own authority. This argument is not valid, however, for these divisions arose *after* his departure from them. And should it be argued, rather, that he rejoiced that it had so *happened* that he had baptized only a few of them, we reply that neither John the Baptist nor the twelve could have legitimately said that *they* were glad they had baptized only a few under any part of *their* ministry for water baptism was part of their *commission.*

Let us examine the Scriptures further, then, as to why Paul, unlike John and the twelve, rejoiced that he had baptized so few of the Corinthian believers.

First, the importance of water baptism under John is clear. He was called "the Baptist," and Mark 1:4 emphatically states:

"John did baptize in the wilderness, and *preach the baptism of repentance for the remission of sins."*

Mark well, John *preached* baptism. This is why Peter referred later to "*the baptism which John preached"* (Acts 10:37) and why Paul said to his Epicedian audience, still later, that,

" . . . John had first preached before His [Christ's] coming, *the baptism of repentance* to all the people of Israel" (Acts 13:24).

Some pastors and Bible teachers have said to the author, "I don't *preach baptism;* I preach *Christ."* Well, fine, but let us not overlook the fact that John "the Baptist," who introduced our Lord as Israel's Messiah, *did* preach baptism. He demanded it as a demonstration of true repentance and a divine requirement for "the remission of sins."

Some who hold to water baptism acknowledge that under John the Baptist this rite was required for the remission of sins, but they think that this was changed after the death and resurrection of Christ, so that under the "great commission" we have "Christian baptism."

Changed? Was not Peter working under the "great commission" at Pentecost, and did he not, like John, proclaim *"the baptism of repentance for the remission of sins"?*

Peter did not tell his hearers at Pentecost that Christ had died for their sins. He *accused* them of the murder of Christ, and when, convicted, they asked, *"What shall we do?"* he replied:

"Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins . . .."

Indeed, Mark's record of the "great commission" clearly states: *"He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved; but he that believeth not*[22] shall be damned" (Mark 16:16). Christ gave this command *after* His death and resurrection.

This passage is clear enough: "He that believeth *and is baptized* shall be saved." If a pastor or Bible teacher *alters* this plain statement to make it mean:

"He that believeth and is saved ought *then* to be baptized," is it not reasonable to ask whether he might not also alter other important Scripture passages to make them fit his line of teaching? What security do we have in relying on the Word of God if every theologian can make it say what *he* thinks it ought to say?

In this case it says, "He that believeth *and is baptized* shall be saved," and Peter,

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[22] The argument that baptism is not required for salvation here because the passage does not say, "He that believeth not, *and is not baptized,* shall be damned," is most superficial. If one did not believe why would he be baptized? And if without faith he, for some reason, was baptized, would that baptism avail?

working under this commission, and filled with the Holy Spirit, said, *"Repent, and be baptized every one of you* in the name of Jesus Christ *for the remission of sins."*

Now think carefully: Would John the Baptist and Peter have obeyed their God-given commissions had *they* baptized only a few and had then say that they were *thankful* for this? Assuredly not, for with their hearer's water baptism was a matter of eternal life or death; thus they had been *commanded* to preach *and baptize.* In Luke 7:29,30 we read:

"And all the people that heard him [John], and the publicans, justified God,[23] being baptized with the baptism of John.

"But the Pharisees and lawyers rejected the council of God against themselves, being not baptized of him."

So important was the rite of water baptism *from John the Baptist all the way through Pentecost.*

PAUL AND WATER BAPTISM

But here Paul, that *other* apostle, declares to the Corinthian believers that he thanks God he has baptized only a few of them (I Cor. 1:14-16). Was he then remiss in the fulfillment of his divine commission? No, for *he* had *not* been commissioned to baptize (Ver.17). John the Baptist and the twelve were true to their commissions, but now God had raised up *another* apostle, to usher in *another* dispensation in which water baptism was to have no place (Eph. 3:1-4).

Some may object: But he did baptize some, did he not? True, but stop a moment and reflect: he also spoke with tongues, healed the sick, cast out demons, circumcised Timothy. But all this belonged to the dispensation under which he was saved and from which he gradually emerged as the Lord appeared to him in one revelation after another (Acts 26:16: II Cor. 12:1).

A QUESTION OF INSPIRATION

It is interesting to note that first the Apostle says, (in I Cor. 1:14,15); "I thank God I baptized *none* of you, *but Crisps and Gains;* lest any should say that I had baptized in mine own name." Mark well: *None but these two.*

Then, in Ver. 16, he adds, *"And I baptized also the household of Stephan's."* Now this is different! First he says two, and no more, and then he adds a whole household! And this is not all, for now, becoming more cautious, he goes on to say, *"'besides, I know not whether I baptized any other"* (Ver. 16). Let's get this whole picture clearly:

[23] I.e., in condemning them as sinners.

1. I baptized *only* Crisps and Gains, none besides.

2. I baptized *also* the household of Stephanas.

3. Besides these *I cannot recall* any others.

At first sight this seems strangely unlike divine inspiration, does it not? The Apostle seems unsure of himself. Ah, but here we encounter the wonder of the inspired Word, for the Bible, the written Word of God, like Christ, the living Word, is *wholly human and wholly divine.* Paul wrote naturally, as a man to his friends, not certain just how many of them he had baptized, but this is *also* God speaking and telling us that water baptism was even then losing its importance.

Paul was thankful he had baptized so few of the Corinthian believers; he wasn't even sure how many, but he knew it was only a few.

But *why* was he glad he had baptized only a few, and *why* was he not even sure just how many? We find the clear answer in the next verse. Read it thoughtfully. Read it prayerfully:

"FOR CHRIST SENT ME NOT TO BAPTIZE, BUT TO PREACH THE GOSPEL . . ." (Ver. 17).

And he adds:

"Not with wisdom of words,[24] *lest the* cross of *Christ should* be *made* of none *effect.*

"For the preaching of the cross is to them that perish foolishness; but unto us which are saved it is the power of God" (Vers. 17,18).

This is why water baptism passed off the scene and from the program of God. The "gospel of the kingdom," with its call to repentance and baptism had been superseded by *"the preaching of the cross,"* i.e., *as good news.* As Israel rejected the King and His kingdom, and all was ripe for the outpouring of God's wrath in the "great tribulation," God, in matchless love and mercy, interrupted the prophetic program, saving His chief enemy on earth, Saul of Tarsus, and sending him forth as the herald and the living demonstration of His boundless love. Thus was ushered in the dispensation of *"the mystery,"* "the dispensation of *the grace of God"* (Eph. 3:2,3).

[24] *"The Jews require a sign,"* says the apostle. *"and the Greeks seek after wisdom; but we preach Christ crucified. . .* (I Cor. 1:22,23). He would have neither "sign" nor "wisdom" detract from the cross of Christ.

THE PREACHING OF THE CROSS

THE POWER OF GOD

Has the reader ever noticed how many believers can readily quote I Cor. 1:18, but how few ever quote Verses 17 and 18 together? These verses belong together, for as surely as the connective "for" in Ver. 17 sends us back to the preceding verses, so surely does the connective "for" in Ver. 18 send us back to Ver.17.

"For Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel; not with wisdom of words, LEST THE CROSS OF CHRIST SHOULD BE MADE OF NONE EFFECT.

"FOR THE PREACHING OF THE CROSS. . . IS THE POWER OF GOD."

Does not this indicate that Paul's "gospel of the grace of God" is based upon the mighty accomplishments of Christ at Calvary? The Apostle would have *nothing* - neither a religious rite, nor the "wisdom of words" detract from this message, for it was in the proclamation of the cross that the power of salvation lay. Why? Because the cross demonstrates God's *righteousness* (as well as His love) in paying the just penalty for our sins. This is beautifully brought out in Rom. 1:16,17, where he states:

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel of Christ, for it is the power of God unto salvation to every one that believeth. . . .

"For therein is the righteousness of God revealed. . . ."

The love of God was also revealed in the gospel, and for this the Apostle was profoundly grateful, but what made him so *proud* ("I stand unashamed") of the gospel was that God's *righteousness* (Lit., *rightness)* was revealed therein. He did not go to the lost and say, "Repent, and God will forgive you." He said in effect, "I have wonderful news for you! Your sins have all been *paid for!"* This is the good news of God's grace to sinners.

Little wonder Paul wrote to the Galatian believers:

"God forbid that I should glory [boast], save in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ. . ." (Gal. 6:14).

He could boast in the accomplishments of Calvary. He could boast - and so can we - that God has dealt *righteously* with our sins; that salvation is based upon the solid foundation of a *penalty paid,* so that no one in heaven will be able to say to us, "What! You here! How did *you* make it?" We will all know how we got there and will rejoice forever in the blessed Savior who bore all the guilt and

punishment due us that we might be justified by His grace.

Much more could be said here about the power of the cross, for Paul has more to say about the blood, the death, the cross of Christ than any other Bible writer, indeed, than all the rest of them put together.

Thus the door has been opened wide and the offer of indiscriminate grace made to all men (I Tim. 2:4-7; Heb. 2:9; I John 2:2).

What a message we have to proclaim to this poor world! After the kingdom message, with its legal and ritual requirements, was refused by the favored race, God saved the chief of sinners and sent him forth, not to require repentance and baptism for the remission of sins, but to proclaim the grace that flows from Calvary. Little wonder he *emphasized* this, *"lest the cross of Christ should be made of none effect,"* even by "wisdom of words;" and declared: "Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel[25]. . . . for *the preaching of the cross is to them that perish foolishness, but unto us which are saved it is the power of God"* (I Cor. 1:17,18).

PAUL, CIRCUMCISION, BAPTISM AND THE CROSS OF CHRIST

CIRCUMCISION	WATER BAPTISM
"If I yet preach circumcision, why do I yet suffer persecution? Then is the offence of the cross ceased."	"For Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel; not with wisdom of words, lest the cross of Christ should be made of none effect.
"But God forbid that I should glory, save in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, by whom the world is crucified unto me and I unto the world" (Gal. 5:11; 6:14).	"For the preaching of the cross is to them that perish foolishness; but unto us which are saved, it is the power of God" (I Cor. 1:17, 18.)

The Apostle Paul clearly declares, especially in his *Epistle to the Galatians,* that where salvation is concerned, it is not circumcision, but Christ that avails, and that in view of His finished work circumcision has been done away. And, now, lo, our covenant theologians teach that water baptism has taken the place of circumcision! God says, *"Not circumcision, but Christ"* (Gal. 5:1-3); *they* say, *"Not circumcision, but baptism - and Christ."*

It is difficult to imagine where such a theory could have originated, for it is *not supported by a single line of Scripture,* much less do we find any support for their practice of infant baptism. Yet this has become the traditional belief of multitudes,

[25] I.e., *his* gospel, *"the preaching of the cross,"* and *"the gospel of the grace of God."*

including many Bible-believing Fundamentalists and Evangelicals.

BAPTISM AND ITS 1900-YEAR BACKGROUND

It is not strange that Paul had a spiritual battle on his hands over the subject of circumcision.

For 1900 years this rite had been practiced - Scripturally - by God's people, and long-established customs are not easily shaken.

Paul, however, had ushered in a new dispensation. He had proclaimed the *finished* work of Christ and with it the abolition of physical circumcision. Yet even believers in Christ kept reverting from the Substance to the shadows, from the reality to the rituals. They even sought to persuade each other that circumcision was "necessary," though they did not make clear just what they thought it was necessary *for,* except that, in a general way, it was required for salvation.

Thus "certain men. . . from Judaea" taught the believers at Antioch: *"Except ye be circumcised after the manner of Moses, ye cannot be saved,"* and as a result *"Paul and Barnabas had no small dissension and disputation with them"* (Acts 15:1,2).

Again at the Jerusalem council, certain of "the Pharisees which believed" rose up to declare that *"it was needful to circumcise"* the Gentiles, and the question was not settled until *"there had been much disputing"* (Acts 15:5-7).

The Judaizers had also persuaded some of the Galatian believers that they should submit to circumcision, even though they were already saved. As a result we have Paul's stern letter of rebuke, in which he points out to them how much is involved in adding the rite of circumcision to the finished work of Christ; that *logically* this would make Christ's work of none effect (Gal. 5:2), and make them debtors "to do the whole law" (5:3).

Today we have a similar spiritual battle on our hands where the rite of water baptism is concerned. Many sincere believers cling to this rite, and it is difficult to make them see how this logically affects the truth of the finished work of Christ. We can show them how water baptism, when in order, was required for salvation (Mark 1:4; 16:16; Acts 2:38) and that to add it now is to cast reflections on our Lord's *finished* work and to involve us logically in legalism to the same extent that circumcision once did. But, as it was in Paul's day with circumcision, it is often difficult to make them see this. This is largely because water baptism today, like circumcision in Paul's day, has a 1900-year background which is hard to overcome.

We do not mean that water baptism has been Scripturally in order for 1900 years, however, for we are convinced that Paul, knowing full well that water

baptism was associated with our Lord's Messiahship (John 1:31) expected it soon to pass off the scene. Certainly Paul was not sent to baptize a Cor 1:17); indeed he insists that today there is but *"one baptism"* (Eph. 4:5), by which we are baptized into Christ (Rom. 6:3) and into His Body (I Cor. 12:13).

Yet in his own lifetime there was already a large-scale return by believers to the legalism and ritualism which culminated in the dark ages, and from which the Church has never fully recovered.

CLOSING QUESTION

One closing question should be asked: If water baptism were Scriptural *for the present "dispensation of the grace of God,"* where would you expect to find it commanded in the Bible? In the Old Testament? In the four "Gospels" or the Acts? In the Hebrew Christian epistles or the book of Revelation? Your answer is doubtless no, for if it were binding on us *today* we should find it commanded in the Epistles of Paul.

Well, then, can you find any passage in the Epistles of Paul where he commands or even exhorts us to be *baptized with water?*

With this question we close this chapter, only reminding our readers that it is impossible to add to the finished work of Christ, without subtracting from His glory.

Chapter VII

PAUL'S UNIQUE APOSTLESHIP CONFIRMED

Among all the reasons why some reject, question or minimize Paul's apostleship, two stand out most prominently:

1. Our Lord *had* twelve apostles, and at Judas' defection another had been chosen to bring the number up to twelve again. Why still another? and why should so much be made of this other apostle?

2. Satan hates grace, and especially did he hate its chief representative, the Apostle Paul. Imagine the embarrassment of Satan when, only a few days after his "success" in having Christ crucified (Luke 22:3-6) more than "500 brethren" went everywhere crying from the housetops: *"He is alive! He is alive! We have seen Him!"*

But if this was embarrassing to Satan, imagine his dismay when he discovered that Christ's death was the divinely-appointed payment for sin, on the basis of which God could now offer to all men: *"redemption through His blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of His grace"!*

Surely God "taketh the wise in their own craftiness," and Satan, thus held in derision, has since done everything in his power to oppose and pervert "the gospel of the grace of God" and to discredit its chief representative. This is why it was necessary for Paul to defend his apostleship.

PAUL'S APOSTLESHIP AUTHENTIC

In the opening verses of most of Paul's epistles he states that he is an apostle of Jesus Christ *"by calling,"* or *"by the will of God."*

Further, in I Tim. 2:2, referring to his special message, he declares that he was *"ordained.* . . an apostle," and in II Tim. 1:11, *"appointed .* . . an apostle."

In defending his apostleship he sometimes uses bold language - necessarily so. We cite a few examples of this:

Rom. 11:13: "For I speak to you Gentiles, insomuch as I am the apostle of the Gentiles; I magnify mine office."

I Cor. 9:1,2: "Am I not an apostle? am I not free? have I not seen Jesus Christ our Lord? are not ye my work in the Lord?

"If I be not an apostle unto others, yet doubtless I am to you: for *the seal of mine apostleship are ye in the Lord."*

As we consider the geographical location of Corinth, with *two* seaports, one on either side, thus ridden with immorality and wanton living; as we consider its Godless culture and its vile religion, it is amazing indeed that a Christian church was ever established there and little wonder that Paul should call *this* church the *seal* of his apostleship.

II Cor. 11:5: "I suppose I was not a whit behind the very chiefest apostles."

II Cor. 12:11,12: "I am become a fool in glorying; ye have compelled me, for I ought to have been commended of you: for in nothing am I behind the very chiefest apostles, though I be nothing.

"Truly the signs of an apostle were wrought among you in all patience, in signs, and wonders, and mighty deeds."

Those who are taken with the signs and wonders of early Acts, especially of Pentecost, and thus belittle Paul's ministry, should take note that all the miracles wrought by Peter, were duplicated - and more -- by Paul. His miracles again and again proved to be greater than those of Peter. And when we come to Galatians 2, we find him calling the leaders at Jerusalem "those who *seemed* to be somewhat." And subsequently he *names* them: "James, Cephas [Peter], and John," *in that order.* Doubtless he calls them "those who seemed to be somewhat," because James, not even one of the twelve,[26] had usurped Peter's God-given position (Acts 15:13-19) and Peter had permitted it. Indeed, shortly after the great Jerusalem council, when "certain from James" would have intimidated Peter into separating himself from the Gentile believers, "*I withstood him to the face,"* says Paul, "because he was to be blamed" and "when I saw that they walked not uprightly, according to the truth of the gospel, *I said to Peter before them all.* . ." (Gal. 2:11-14).

Peter "had this coming," as we say, for he had been present at Jerusalem when "false brethren unawares brought in" sought to "spy out our [the Gentiles'] liberty which we have in Christ Jesus, that they might bring us into bondage," concerning which Paul writes:

"To whom we gave place by subjection, no, not for an hour, that the truth of the gospel might continue with you [Gentiles]" (Gal. 2:3-5).

And Peter had then supported Paul in this (Acts 15:7-11).

Thus Paul's apostleship is mightily established for us in Scripture - yet not only by

[26] The James of "Peter, James and John" had been slain in Acts 12:1,2

such arguments as the above.

HIS APOSTLESHIP EXPLAINED

Paul *explains* the circumstances surrounding his apostleship in Galatians 1 and 2. Again we will let him speak for himself, as we have done repeatedly thus far in this volume.

Gal. 1:1: "Paul, an apostle (not of men, neither by man, but by Jesus Christ, and God the Father who raised Him from the dead)."

This is important for it indicates that his apostleship did not originate with men - neither did that of Matthias, who had replaced Judas - but more than that, Paul was not appointed an apostle *by human instrumentality* ("neither *by* man"). This could not be said of Matthias' appointment, for God *had* used men to ordain him an apostle (Acts 1:15-26).

And now he throws down the certificate of his apostleship, as it were:

Gal. 1:11,12: "But I CERTIFY YOU, BRETHREN, THAT THE GOSPEL WHICH WAS PREACHED OF ME IS NOT AFTER MAN.

"For I neither received it of man, neither was I taught it, but BY THE REVELATION OF JESUS CHRIST."

Surely this should answer completely the arguments of those who claim that the twelve and Paul all proclaimed the same message.

Indeed, he presses this fact home in Vers. 15-17:

"But when it pleased God, who separated me from my mother's womb, and called me by His grace,

"To reveal His Son in me, that I might preach Him among the heathen; immediately I conferred not with flesh and blood;[27]

"Neither went I up to Jerusalem to them which were apostles before me; but I went into Arabia, and returned again unto Damascus."

Then, in Chapter 2, we find him going to Jerusalem *"by revelation."*[28] And there, he says, "[I] communicated unto them *that gospel which I preach among the Gentiles,* but privately to them which were of reputation, lest by any means I should run, or had run, in vain" (Ver. 2).

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[27] Lit., I did not immediately confer with flesh and blood, i.e., human beings.
[28] I.e., God *sent* him to Jerusalem.

Pray, why should he use the phrase, "that gospel which I preach among the Gentiles," or have to communicate this gospel "privately to them which were of reputation," if he preached the same gospel as they did?

Moreover he clearly states in Vers. 6,7:

". . . in conference [they] *added nothing to me, but contrariwise.* . . ." Clearly, he understood the prophetic program as they did; perhaps better than they, so they could add nothing to him, but "contrariwise," he was able to add something to them: "that gospel which he preached among the Gentiles."

And the glorious results: Even James, along with Peter and John, were so overcome by the Spirit that. they gave to Paul and Barnabas "the right hands of fellowship," publicly agreeing that Paul was now God's choice to go to the Gentiles while they went back to their ministry among the Jews (Vers. 7-9).

BOASTING OF GRACE

In defending his apostleship, Paul glorifies, not himself, but the grace of God.

While he did - and rightly - magnify his *office,* this was not to glorify himself, but the grace of God, for God had revealed the riches of His grace, not merely through a message, but through the individual appointed to proclaim that message: *the chief of sinners, saved by grace.* If the apostleship of Paul (the divinely-chosen vessel to *demonstrate* that grace) were disproved, so, of course, would be the message he proclaimed. Thus, while defending his apostleship he freely confesses that he himself is nothing.

In I Cor. 15:9 he freely acknowledges:

"For *I am the least of the apostles, that am not meet [worthy] to be called an apostle,* because I persecuted the church of God."

But he adds:

"But *by the grace of God / am what / am:* and His grace which was bestowed upon me was not in vain, but I labored more abundantly than they all; *yet not /, but the grace of God which was with me*" (Ver. 10).

Indeed, in Eph. 3:8 he goes even farther:

"Unto me, who am *less than the least of all saints,* is this grace given, that I should preach among the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ."

Thus he writes to the Corinthians in II Cor. 12:11:

". . . in nothing am I behind the very chiefest apostles, *though I be nothing."*

In I Tim. 1:12-16 he spells all this out, as it were:

"And I thank Christ Jesus our Lord, who hath enabled me, for that He counted me faithful, putting me into the ministry;

"Who was before a blasphemer, and a persecutor, and injurious: but I obtained mercy because I did it ignorantly in unbelief.

"And the grace of our Lord was exceeding abundant with faith and love which is in Christ Jesus.

"This is a faithful saying, and worthy of all acceptation, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save *sinners; of whom I am chief.*

"Howbeit *for this cause I obtained mercy, that in me first Jesus Christ might show forth all longsuffering, for a pattern to them which should hereafter believe on Him to life everlasting."*

How this all harmonizes with his basic claims as to his apostleship:

Rom. 1:5: "By whom we have received grace *and apostleship,* far obedience to the faith among all nations, for His name."

Eph. 3:6,7: "That the Gentiles should be fellow-heirs, and of the same body, and partakers of His promise in Christ by the gospel:

"Whereof I was made a minister, *according* to *the gift of the* grace *of God,* given unto me by the effectual working of His power."

Chapter VIII

THE EXTENT OF PAUL'S MINISTRY

GOOD NEWS FOR ALL NATIONS

"Go ye therefore, and teach flit., *make disciples of* All NATIONS. . ." (Matt. 28:19; cf., Luke 24:47).

"Go ye into All THE WORLD, and preach the gospel to EVERY CREATURE [Lit., in *all the* creation]" (Mark 16:15).

"And *this gospel* of *the kingdom* shall be preached in *all the world,* for a witness unto *all* nations, and THEN SHALL THE END COME" (Matt. 24:14).

"Now to Him that is of power to establish you according to *my gospel, and the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation* of *the mystery,* which was kept secret since the world began.

"But now is made manifest, and. . . MADE KNOWN TO All NATIONS for the obedience of faith" (Rom. 16:25,26).

". . . the gospel; which is come to you as it is in All THE WORLD, and bringeth forth fruit, as it doth also in you. . ." (Col. 1:6).

". . . the gospel which ye have heard, and WHICH WAS PREACHED TO EVERY CREATURE WHICH IS UNDER HEAVEN [Lit., in all the creation under heaven]; *whereof I*, *Paul, am made a minister*" (Col. 1:23).

The above passages of Scripture deserve the most careful scrutiny, especially as they relate to *each other.* The reader will note that we have divided them into *three portions;* the uppermost having to do with the ministry of the twelve apostles, the bottom having to do with the ministry of the Apostle Paul, and the one between declaring that when all nations shall have been reached with "the gospel of the kingdom" the "end" will come. A thoughtful consideration of these passages raises two basic questions, the answers to which further emphasize the distinctive character of Paul's apostleship and message. They are: (1) Was Paul's ministry a perpetuation of that of the twelve? and (2) Did Paul really get to all the world with the message of grace?

WAS PAUL'S MINISTRY A PERPETUATION OF THAT OF THE TWELVE?

If it was, why did not "the end" come? For Matt. 24:14 clearly states that when

"this gospel of the kingdom" shall have reached "all nations" *"then* shall the end come."

Now we know that the twelve did *not,* even through emissaries, reach "all nations" with their gospel. Indeed, at the great Jerusalem council they were released from their original commission, with Paul now recognized as the apostle to the nations (See Gal. 2:2-9). Thus, if Paul now perpetuated their ministry and, did reach all nations with their gospel, "the end" should have come.

What was "the end" referred to in Matt. 24:14? A glance at the context will reveal that our Lord there referred to the end of the Tribulation, and consequently the earthly establishment of the kingdom of Messiah.

Ah, but Paul's ministry was *not* a perpetuation of that of the Twelve. His was not "the gospel of the *kingdom"* but "the preaching of the *cross,"* not the proclamation of prophetic promises, but the proclamation of the *"mystery. . . kept secret since the world began, but now made manifest" through him."*

The prophesied program, with its "gospel of the kingdom," had, as we have seen, been interrupted by *"the dispensation of the grace of God."* When this dispensation has drawn to a close, then God will resume His dealings with Israel and "this gospel of the kingdom" will again be proclaimed, culminating in "the end" of the Tribulation and the return of Christ to reign on earth.

Thus Paul's ministry was *not* a perpetuation of that of the Twelve, but was rather distinct and separate from theirs; which brings us to our second question:

DID PAUL REACH ALL THE WORLD WITH HIS MESSAGE OF GRACE?

An examination of the third portion of Scripture passages cited above, indicates that he did. Rom. 16:25,26 declares that though "kept secret since the world began," it was subsequently "made known to *all nations* for the obedience of faith." Col. 1:6 declares to the Colossians that "the gospel [has] come to you as it is in *all the world,"* and Ver. 23 states that it had been *"preached to every creature [or in all creation] under heaven."*

Does the reader object that "the gospel of the grace of God" *could not* have actually reached "all the world" or "all creation"? We reply that we do not deny that to those addressed "all the world" would doubtless mean all the *known* world, and "all creation" would likewise mean all the creation *as they knew it.* But the terms "all nations," "all the world," and "all creation," in the so-called "great commission" are exactly the same, even in the Greek, as those three terms used in connection with Paul's ministry (Cr. Portion #1 above, with Portion #3). Thus what they mean in the "great commission" they must also mean when used with regard to Paul's ministry.

Whereas the twelve never got beyond their own nation in carrying out their commission, it is written *of* Paul that during his stay at Ephesus *"all they which dwelt in Asia* [in *Asia Minor] heard the word of the Lord Jesus"* (Acts 19:10). To the Romans he writes: *"From Jerusalem,* and *round about unto Illyricum, I* have *fully preached the gospel of Christ"* (Rom. 15:19), and mentions plans to go to Spain (15:24), plans which may well have been accomplished between his two imprisonment. Even *of* his helpers it was said, *"These that have turned the world upside down are come hither also"* (Acts 17:6). And to the Romans, who had come to know "the gospel of the grace of God" through his ministry,[29] he writes: *"Your faith is spoken of throughout the whole world"* (Rom. 1:8).

THE AMAZING ENERGY WITH WHICH PAUL PREACHED GRACE

We begin to grasp something *of* the scope *of* Paul's ministry as we read in the divine Record, for example, how at Pisidian Antioch *"almost the whole city"* came together to hear the Word of God, though the unbelieving Jews "raised persecution against Paul and Barnabas and expelled them out *of* their coasts" (Acts 13:49,50). Then, how at Iconium, where he next preached the gospel, *"the multitude of the city was divided,"* and how, in danger *of* being stoned, the apostles *"fled* to Lystra and Derbe. . . . *And there they preached the gospel"* (Acts 14:5-7). At Lystra he was actually stoned and dragged out *of* the city, and there left for dead (Acts 14:19).

And then, after preaching the gospel in Derbe, and teaching many, they went right back to the cities where they had risked their lives and had suffered such persecution,

"Confirming the souls of the disciples, and exhorting them to continue in the faith. . ." (Acts 14:22).

And we could go on and on, regarding his battle for Gentile liberty from the Law at Jerusalem, the "cold shoulder" he got at Athens, the terrible opposition and persecution at Corinth, the great uproar at Ephesus where, he says, *"we were pressed out of measure, above strength, insomuch that we despaired even of life"* (II Cor. 1:8). We could examine the details of his afflictions, persecutions and perils at Caesarea and all the way to Rome where, finally, he was beheaded by the wicked Nero. And we have not even mentioned the long list of his sufferings and persecutions found in II Cor. 11:23-29. It is amazing that by that time, about A.D. 60, he could already have suffered so much. But all this shows the amazing energy that, by God's grace, he put into the propagation of "the gospel of the grace of God."

[29] See the author's commentary on *Romans* Pp. XV to XIX.

DIVINELY EMPOWERED

But how, even recognizing Paul's organized efforts to send the gospel to "the regions beyond," could one man have accomplished so much? What was the source of the energy that took him from one uprising into another; that urged him on and on with his proclamation of "the gospel of the grace of God," even though lacking much-needed rest? How could he keep enduring stripes and imprisonments, stonings and shipwrecks, long journeys with perils of every sort? How could he go on bearing weariness, pain, watchings, hunger, thirst, cold, nakedness? And all these things in addition to "the care of all the churches" he had already suffered by the time he wrote his second epistle to the Corinthians (See II Cor. 11:23-28). Indeed, in his first epistle to them he writes:

"Even unto this present hour we both hunger, and thirst, and are naked, and are buffeted, and have no certain dwelling place" (I Cor. 4:11).

How could the apostle endure all this? The answer to this question is also given to us in his own inspired writings. It is simply that he was *divinely energized,* as the following passages indicate:

"For I will not dare to speak of any of those things which Christ hath not wrought by me, to make the Gentiles obedient, by word and deed" (Rom. 15:18).

"But by the grace of God I am what I am; and His grace which was bestowed upon me was not in vain, but I labored more abundantly than they all; yet not I, but the grace of God which was with me" (I Cor. 15:10).

"For He that wrought effectually in Peter to the apostleship of the circumcision, the same was mighty in me toward the I Gentiles" (Gal. 2:8).

"Whereunto I also labor, striving according to His working, which worketh in me mightily" (Col. 1:29).

"At my first answer [before Nero] no man stood with me, but all men forsook me; I pray God that it may not be laid to their charge.

"Notwithstanding the Lord stood with me, and strengthened me; that by me the preaching might be fully known, and that all the Gentiles might hear: and I was delivered out of the mouth of the lion" (II Tim. 4:16,17).

Thus alone it was that the apostle could write that

"The grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men" (Tit. 2:11).[30]

Alas, how this light has since been dimmed! How lightly men have esteemed the

[30] This subject is dealt with more fully in the author's book, *No Other Doctrine,* Chap. XII.

infinite grace of God! And this began during the apostle's own lifetime. To the fickle Galatians he had to write:

"I marvel that ye are so soon removed from him that called you into the grace of Christ unto another gospel" (Gal. 1:6).

And to Timothy, the pastor at Ephesus (from whence all "Asia" had been evangelized), he had to write:

"This thou knowest, that all they which are in Asia be turned away from me. . ." (II Tim. 1:15).

They had not turned away from God, but from Paul and the clear, strong message of grace he represented. It is evident from all the apostle had to say about the approaching apostasy - and what *Timothy* should do about it - that the revolt against his God-given message had already begun.

Chapter IX

REBELLION AGAINST PAULINE AUTHORITY

PAUL AND THE CHURCH FATHERS

Irenaeus is one of the earliest of the "Church Fathers" whose writings we still have in our possession. He lived in the second century after Christ and knew Polycarp, the noted martyr and disciple of the Apostle John.

Irenaeus is perhaps best known for his writings against the heresies of his day, yet he was not himself free from heresy and sometimes sought to refute what was not heresy but the truth.

One serious heresy which he held, and which the Church of Rome has seized upon for support of her claims, is that *the Church* is the final court of appeals where truth is concerned and that salvation is to be obtained only from her.[31] Referring to the testimonies of other Church fathers, he said in this connection:

"Since therefore we have such proofs, it is not necessary to seek the truth among others which it is so easy to obtain from the Church, since the apostles, like a rich man [depositing his money] in a bank, I lodged in her hands most copiously all things pertaining to the truth, so that every man whosoever will, can draw from her the water of life."

"Suppose there arise a dispute relative to some important question among us, should we not have recourse to the most ancient churches with which the apostles held constant intercourse, and learn from them what is certain and clear in regard to the present question?" *(Ante-Nicene Fathers,* Roberts and Donaldson, Vol. I, pp. 416, 417).

To Roman Catholics, of course, Irenaeus' argument appears sound, but the fact is that "the most ancient churches with which the apostles held constant intercourse" themselves fell into heresies, and that in the very days of the apostles themselves, years before Irenaeus was born! In how many cases the apostles deal with heresies *already then gaining ground in the Church!* Yet Irenaeus looked for doctrinal authority to the Church in his day, when even a greater number of heresies had arisen. And Rome would have us submit to the "authority" of the Church (herself!) *now,* in the twentieth century, after all sorts of heresies have arisen to pervert the truth - and certainly not less in Rome than in other branches of the professing Church.

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[31] Though, like Rome, he indulged in double talk here, *also appealing to the Scriptures* for confirmation of his argument that salvation is to be found only in the Church!

It is true that the doctrines of the Church were committed into the hands of men who were supposed to be faithful, but *no* man has ever been fully faithful. Irenaeus could hardly help seeing this and sought a safeguard in an even greater heresy, for he declared it his purpose to answer the heresies of his day by pointing out the "tradition derived from the apostles of the very great, the very ancient, and universally known Church, founded and organized at Rome by the two most glorious apostles, Peter and Paul; and also [by pointing out] the faith preached to men, which comes down to our time by means of the succession of the bishops. For it is a matter of necessity that every church should agree with this Church, on account of its pre-eminent authority. . . ." *(Ibid.* P. 415).

So we must get the truth from "the Church," but it is "a matter of necessity" that every church in the Church should agree with *one Church - that of Rome,* since the truth has been preserved for us by "the succession of the bishops" of that Church!

How one error leads to another! It appears that to maintain any false doctrine it is invariably necessary to defend its flaws by advancing another false doctrine!

In the light of the above it is not strange to find Irenaeus fighting against Pauline truth. Whatever heresies the Marcionites[32] of his day may have held, Irenaeus seeks to answer them by proving that Paul's message and ministry were *not* different from that of the twelve, and he doubtless misinterprets the Marcionites when he refers to them as "those who allege that Paul alone knew the truth and that to him the mystery was manifested by revelation" (Ibid. P. 436).

Straw dummies such as the former of these two charges are still set up by those who are desperate for answers to the inspired claims of the Apostle Paul, but the fact remains that Paul, by the Spirit, distinctly states that "to him the mystery was manifested by revelation": thus Irenaeus not only opposed Paul in this case, *but the Word of God,* in which the Apostle states:

"For this cause I Paul, the prisoner of Jesus Christ for you Gentiles,

"If ye have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God which is given me to you-ward:

"How that *by revelation He made known unto me the mystery*; as I wrote afore in few words" (Eph. 3:1-3).

This one passage -- and there are many others - from the Word of God, penned by Paul himself about 64 A.D., is enough to silence completely the arguments both of the Church fathers, who lived after him, and of those today who claim to

[32] The author's *Encyclopaedia Britannica* refers to Marcion as the first theologian of the second century who really tried to understand Paul's message.

have such reverence for the Word but will not believe it in this case.

Irenaeus sought to answer the arguments for Paul's distinctive message and ministry by the same process that many follow in our day.

1. By knocking down his own straw dummy and proving what no one denies: i.e., that others besides Paul *did* know the truth!

2. By pointing out what all likewise admit: that Paul and the twelve did preach much in common.

3. By pointing out that Luke, Paul's inseparable companion, did not mention, either in his Gospel or in the Acts, the mystery which Paul was supposed to have received by revelation. "Surely," he says, "if Luke, who always preached in company with Paul. . . learned nothing different from him. . . how can these men [the Marcionites].. who were never attached to Paul, boast that they have learned hidden and unspeakable mysteries [from him]?" (*Ibid,* P. 438).

But one would think that in order to learn whether a special mystery was revealed to Paul, one should inquire from *Paul,* not Luke, especially since he wrote on the subject by divine revelation. Certainly *Paul's* writings bear abundant witness that a glorious truth called "the mystery" had been revealed to him after having been "hid from ages and from generations" (See Rom. 16:26; Eph. 1:9; 3:1-11; 6:18-20; Col. 1:25-27; 4:3; etc.).

In the case of Luke's writings we have a telling example of divine selection in inspiration. Luke did not mention the mystery in his writings simply because he, like Paul, wrote by divine inspiration, and it was God's stated purpose to distinguish *Paul* as the one to whom the mystery was revealed and through whom it was to be proclaimed.

Further, it must never be forgotten that the Book of Acts is *not,* as generally supposed, the history of the birth and growth of the Church of this dispensation, but rather the history of the fall of Israel, fully justifying God for casting her aside (temporarily) and holding the establishment of the kingdom in abeyance, while sending Paul forth to proclaim "the gospel of the grace of God" to Jews and Gentiles alike.

Still further, Luke, in the Book of Acts, records how Peter and the twelve dominated early Acts, but were superseded by Paul in the latter half. Thus God reveals his purpose to make Paul the Apostle of the present dispensation.

The moral of all this? Don't go by "the fathers" or "the Church"; *go by the Book!* The very best of men are only men at the very best. Individually and collectively we all fail, and knowing this, true Bereans will *search the Scriptures* daily to check into the teachings of even the greatest men of God.

The Church fathers and the Church as a whole have done no better than Israel of old where the Word and will of God are concerned. Here, nearly 1800 years ago, we have Irenaeus assailing heresies in the Church, yet telling men to go to *the Church* for truth and salvation! He urged men to go "to the most ancient churches with which the apostles held constant intercourse," yet declared that those churches were wrong wherein they did not "agree with *this* church," - *Rome!* He urged men to trust in the "succession of the bishops" of Rome, yet upon arriving at Rome himself was mortified to find Eleutherus, the then Bishop of Rome, patronizing the Montanist heresy! (Ibid. P. 309).

There is *nothing whatever* in the Scriptures about apostolic succession or about the "authority" of the Church of this dispensation, but Paul did say to the Ephesian elders:

"I know this, that after my departing shall grievous wolves enter in among you, not sparing the flock.

"Also of your own selves shall men arise, speaking perverse things, to draw away disciples after them" (Acts 20:29,30).

Nor did Paul commend these Ephesians to Timothy, his "successor" at Ephesus. Rather he said:

"And now, brethren, I COMMEND YOU TO GOD, AND TO THE WORD OF HIS GRACE, which is able to build you up, and to give you an inheritance among all them which are sanctified" (Ver. 32).

Let us, then, go by the Book alone, and that "rightly divided," recognizing that while all the Word of God is for our profit, the writings of Paul, "the apostle of the Gentiles," are particularly addressed to us, giving us God's message for the world today and His program for the Church today.

But it was not only theologians of ages past who rebelled against Paul's God-given authority. Satan has opposed Paul's message all down through the ages since he suffered and died as an ambassador of grace. Indeed, opposition to Paul, either subtle or open is a pronounced phenomenon of our day.

Chapter X

DR. X, THE 12 APOSTLES, AND PAUL

THE "MISTAKES" OF PETER AND PAUL

In the early '60s one of America's leading Bible expositors vigorously opposed the truth of Paul's distinctive apostleship in a series of radio messages and printed booklets. His arguments on the subject, however, ran counter to so many Scripture passages that they stirred up a great deal of discussion and controversy.

The good Doctor's messages on *"The Mistakes of Peter and Paul"* reminded this writer of something that H. L. Hastings, that great defender of the faith, said more than a century ago. Said Hastings: "You have to pay fifty cents admission to hear Bob Ingersoll lecture on the mistakes of Moses. It would be worth five hundred dollars to hear Moses lecture on the mistakes of Bob Ingersoll!"

Not that we would place the Doctor in the same category with Bob Ingersoll. By no means, for this teacher of the Word was a militant Fundamentalist, only he was confused - also militantly - about the divinely appointed positions of the twelve and of Paul. This we propose to prove *from Scripture,* for while the Doctor is now with Christ, his writings are still with us, and these we will answer just as we did back in 1964, now using the past tense rather than the present. Also, to keep the personal element in the background we will refer to him simply as "Dr. X."

Since Dr. X advanced most or all of the arguments used by those who deny that Paul's apostleship and message were separate and distinct from that of the twelve, this procedure will enable us to give a more complete answer.

Dr. X believed that in God's sight Paul was one of the twelve apostles and that he labored under the same commission as they. In his determination to maintain this position he did much to discredit *both* Peter and Paul, accusing them of grave failures, while in fact the failure lay with himself.

DR. X AND THE APOSTLE PAUL

At the time referred to Dr. X published some of his radio messages in a booklet entitled, *The Blunders of Paul,* charging Paul with "a terrible mistake," which brought his "missionary" journeys to "an untimely end" (pp. 1,2). Accusing the apostle of *willful* rebellion against God in making his last journey to Jerusalem, Dr. X wrote: "Paul paid dearly for his disobedience" (P. 5). But probably the most reckless of his charges against Paul is found in his comments on Acts 21:13.

As we know, the preceding verses record Agabus' prophecy that at Jerusalem Paul would be bound and delivered to the Gentiles. Upon hearing this prophecy his friends besought him with tears not to venture to Jerusalem, and the record goes on to say:

"Then Paul answered, What mean ye to weep and to break mine heart? for I am ready not to be bound only, but also to die at Jerusalem for the name of the Lord Jesus" (Acts 21:13).

Does not this reply give touching evidence both of the apostle's tenderness of heart and of his readiness to suffer for Christ? The tearful pleas of his brethren were breaking his heart, yet he felt "bound in the spirit" to go to Jerusalem to bear witness for Christ.

But see how Dr. X interpreted this passage. Said he:

"The tenderhearted Apostle Paul, who could weep and cry for his converts, now is hard as a brick, and insensitive to the tender weeping of his dearest friends" (P.16).

We do not deny that Paul was human, and could, and did make mistakes. He was the first to acknowledge this. But who of us has been half so tenderhearted or half so faithful in his ministry for the Lord? We feel it was rather Dr. X who hardened his heart and closed his eyes to the great Pauline revelation, with its "one body" and "one baptism."

But in his determined opposition to this great truth of Scripture Dr. X discredited *both* Paul and the twelve apostles.

DR. X AND THE TWELVE APOSTLES

In Booklet No.1 of his *Studies in Acts* Dr. X had harsh things to say about Peter and the eleven with regard to the appointment of Matthias to take Judas' place among the twelve. We quote:

Page 12: "... impetuous, impatient Peter had another of his wild ideas. . . . He suggests they give the Lord a little assistance by appointing a twelfth apostle in the place of Judas."

Page 13: "Peter was completely out of order."

Page 14: "... they were compelled to resort to the dubious method of 'chance'" (In previous radio addresses he had described the apostles as "throwing dice" to choose Judas' successor, as though they were gambling on the outcome). And he continued, "But it was all in vain. This was not God's choice, but man's."

Page 16: "... this great mistake of Peter in engineering the appointment of Matthias."

Pages 16, 17: "... Peter's mistake" caused Paul "so much grief later."

Page 15: "The eleven. . . would not admit their mistake."

In confirming his contentions Dr. X made a very odd statement: With regard to Acts 1:26, he stated that Matthias "was numbered [counted] with the eleven, but NOT WITH THE TWELVE" (P.15, emphasis his own). But he inserted the word "counted" to convey the impression that Matthias was counted as *one of* the *eleven,* not of the twelve! What a perversion of an otherwise plain passage! Surely it is clear as day that the eleven were appointing a *twelfth* apostle, not an eleventh. They were bringing the number up from eleven to twelve again. At Pentecost Peter stood up *"with the eleven"* and as we learned at grade school, one man *with* eleven men adds up to twelve men. Acts 1:26 states that Matthias was numbered *"with* the eleven."

In the light of the Word of God Dr. X's case against Peter and the eleven is a masterpiece of confused thinking and blind refusal to accept what God has so clearly said on the subject. Let us be Bereans and see.

THE FACTS IN THE CASE

God's choice for Judas' place, said Dr. X, was *Paul,* and the apostles and disciples acted in the flesh in appointing Matthias. But the record of Scripture clearly indicates that:

1. The eleven apostles and the disciples had *"all continued with one accord in prayer and supplication"* since the ascension of Christ (Acts 1:14).

2. It was *"in those days"* of continued earnest prayer, that Peter arose to address not only the other apostles, but "about an hundred and twenty" disciples (Acts 1:15).

3. Peter reminded his hearers that "the Holy Spirit, by the mouth of David," had said concerning Judas: *"Let his habitation be desolate. . . and his bishoprick let another take"* (Acts 1:16,20; cf. Psa. 109:8).

4. Our Lord had promised that as a body of *twelve men* the apostles should occupy *twelve thrones* in His kingdom (Matt. 19:28).

5. The establishment of the kingdom was soon to be offered and there would have to be twelve men ready to occupy twelve thrones with Christ (Acts 3:19-21).

6. The apostles had been given official authority to act in Christ's absence (Matt. 18:18,19).

7. Any candidates for Judas' place had to be men who had companied with Christ and the twelve *"all the time"* during which Christ had ministered on earth, from *the first day* of His ministry *to the last* (Acts 1:21, 22). This was based upon the wording of our Lord's promise: "Ye which have *followed* Me" (Matt. 19:28) and "Ye which have *continued with* Me" (Luke 22:28, 29). And is it not extremely doubtful that there were more than two thus qualified?

8. Even the two thus qualified were taken to the Lord in prayer (Acts 1:24).

9. The final choice was left wholly to the Lord by the casting of lots (Acts 1:24,25).

10. "The lot fell upon Matthias. . . he was numbered with the eleven apostles. . . . *and they were all filled with the Holy Ghost'* (Acts 1:26; 2:4).

TRUTH PERVERTED

Our brother condemned the eleven for their appointment of Matthias on the basis of our Lord's instructions in Acts 1:4, to *"wait for the promise of the Father,"* i.e., the coming of the Holy Spirit. His interpretation of this command, however, is expressed in the following statements, also from Booklet No. 1 of his *Studies in Acts* (All emphasis his own):

"The apostles were to 'stay put' in Jerusalem, and DO NOTHING but WAIT for the promise of the Holy Spirit" (P. 5).

". . . they were to WAIT. They were to make no move" (P .5).

". . . the disciples were to WAIT for the Holy Spirit to give them instructions for the carrying out of the program for the Church" (P. 12).

"Jesus said WAIT for the Holy Spirit to guide you" (P. 17).

In the light of the record of Scripture, however, Dr. X was far off base here. Our Lord did not tell the disciples to *"do nothing* but wait," else even their joining in prayer would have been disobedience. Nor did He tell them to "wait for the Holy Spirit *to give them instructions,"* much less "to give them instructions *for the carrying out of the program for the Church."* All this was added to the sacred Record by our brother. To examine exactly what this passage does say, let us turn to Acts 1:4.

"And being assembled together with them, [He] commanded them *that they should not depart from Jerusalem, but wait for the promise of the Father. . . ."*

This agrees with the record in Luke 24:49, where our Lord said:

". . . *tarry ye in the city of Jerusalem, until ye be endued with power from on high."*

This is clear enough. The eleven were to wait for the coming of the Holy Spirit *before departing from Jerusalem.* This is quite different from waiting and *doing nothing,* a thought which Dr. X injected into this passage in his determination to make Paul one of the twelve and discount the unique character of his apostleship.

THE SCRIPTURES OBEYED

To call the appointment of Judas' successor another one of Peter's "wild ideas," seems to this writer worse than a blunder, especially in the light of the fact that Dr. X himself agreed that the Scriptures had previously declared that another should take Judas' "bishoprick" (Acts 1:20; cf. Psa. 109:8).

But to charge "impetuous, impatient Peter" with "engineering the appointment of Matthias," is still worse; it is adding slander to insult.

Throughout the record of Matthias' appointment there is not the slightest hint of impatience on Peter's part or of his "engineering" anything. Our Lord, with His ascension to heaven in view, had appointed Peter the head over the apostles and the Messianic Church (Matt. 16:19; cf. Matt. 18:18,19). Thus it was perfectly proper that he should take the lead in this matter.

Further, while at that time the Spirit had not yet descended *in power,* with the miraculous signs of the kingdom, these apostles *had* received the Holy Spirit (See John 20:22).

AN ACT BATHED IN PRAYER

On Page 14 of his booklet, Dr. X stated: "They should have prayed about it BEFORE they nominated their choice" (Emphasis his). In earlier messages too he gave the impression that the eleven, acting in the flesh, merely chose two men and then asked God to ratify what they had done. But nothing could be farther from the truth.

As we have already seen from Acts 1:13,14, ever since our Lord's ascension the apostles and disciples had *"continued with one accord in prayer and supplication"* and it was "in those days" that Peter arose to propose the matter of Judas' successor. Further, in the light of the strict requirements for a position among the twelve, along with any other natural requirements, it is extremely doubtful that more than two could have qualified, for the one chosen would have

had to have "companied with" Christ and the apostles *"all the time. . . beginning from the baptism of John* [i.e., the beginning of His ministry] *unto that same day that He was taken up from us. . ."* i.e., any applicant would have had to have followed with our Lord and the apostles *all the time from the first day of His ministry to the last.* How many, does the reader suppose, would have qualified?

But even after the field had been narrowed down to two men, the apostles did not "lean unto their own understanding" but prayed *again,* earnestly beseeching the Lord: *"Show whether of these two Thou hast chosen"* (Acts 1:24).

And to guard *completely* against exercising their own will in the matter they cast lots, leaving the outcome prayerfully to the Lord.

How unjust, then, of Dr. X to level charges of self-will on the one hand, and of gambling on the other, against men who, according to the *Sacred Record,* took every precaution *against* exercising their own wills and *prayerfully* - and *Scripturally* - cast lots to make certain that God would have *His* way!

THE CASTING OF LOTS

Again and again Dr. X had spoken disparagingly of the apostles throwing dice, gambling and leaving this matter to chance. What he failed to explain is that in such a case it was both Scriptural and appropriate to cast lots.

Long centuries before this God had declared that the land of Canaan should be divided to Israel *by lot* (Num. 26:55), and the book of Joshua describes how this was done. This was a familiar Old Testament method of ascertaining the Lord's will in such matters and was far removed from present-day gambling, in which men trust to "luck." Prov. 16:33 correctly declares: *"The lot is cast into the lap, but the whole disposing thereof is of the Lord."*

Here we must ask earnestly: Who, reading the account of Matthias' appointment with open mind and heart, would associate this incident with "gambling" or *a game of "chance"?* We are not aware that gamblers pray that the Lord might have His way before throwing their dice. But Dr. X evidently did not read this account with open mind and heart. He consistently took his stand against Paul's distinctive apostleship. He *must,* he felt, make Paul one of the twelve, working under the so-called "great commission" and, sadly, this involved discrediting *both* Paul and the circumcision apostles.

In the light of Dr. X's false accusations against Paul and the twelve, it is not strange that he publicly made false charges against those who stood for Paul's great message of the "Mystery."[33]

WHY PAUL *COULD NOT* HAVE BEEN

[33] See the author's book, *The Controversy,* pp. 68-73.

ONE OF THE TWELVE

Dr. X contended - on what authority who knows? - that "everywhere Paul went he had to defend his divine ordination as one of the twelve" and had to defend himself against "the charge that Matthias. . . was the true apostle" (P.15). He declared that "Peter's impatience was the cause of the mistake which caused Paul so much grief later" (pp.16, 17). He advanced not one passage of Scripture to prove all this, but if one fact is *certain beyond the shadow of* a *doubt,* as we consider the record of Scripture, it is the fact that Paul *could not* have been one of the twelve apostles. He was not, *at any time,* eligible for this position. Some of the reasons for this are as follows:

1. Paul was not saved until some time after Pentecost, so could not have been appointed as Judas' successor in time for Pentecost and the offer of the kingdom (Cf., Acts 2:14).

2. Could his appointment have waited, he would not have been eligible at *any* time for apostleship among the twelve. He had not "followed" Christ at all, much less gone "in and out" with Him and His apostles from the first day of His ministry to the last (See Matt. 19:28; Acts 1:20; I Cor. 15:8).

3. Matthias "was numbered with the eleven apostles. . . *and they were all filled with the Holy Ghost"* (Acts 1:26; 2:4). This alone is proof positive that Matthias, not Paul, was God's choice for Judas' place. Had the apostles and disciples been out of the will of God in the appointment of Matthias, we may be sure that *none* of them would have been filled with the Spirit, and had *Matthias* been the wrong man for this important position, surely *he* would not have been filled with the Spirit. But the record, in refutation of Dr. X's confused arguments, declares that *"they were all filled with the Holy Ghost."*

4. Paul was raised up for a *special* ministry, separate and distinct from that of the twelve (See Acts 20:24; Gal. 1:11, 12, 17-19; 2:2, 7-9; Rom. 11:13; 15:15, 16; Eph. 3:1-3).

5. Paul consistently refers to the twelve as a *separate body* of apostles, as in I Cor. 15:5-8, where he declares: *"[Christ] was seen. . . of the twelve. . . . And last of all He was seen of* me *also.* . . ." Moreover, this inspired reference to *twelve* apostles *between the resurrection and ascension of Christ* is further proof that God considered Matthias one of the twelve even before his official appointment in Acts 1. Evidently he was with the apostles when the risen Christ appeared to them. (Acts 1:20-23).

Paul, then, *cannot* legitimately be considered one of the twelve apostles. Nor, even, can he be considered as one *with* the twelve, as so many view him. As eleven apostles would have been too few for the twelve promised thrones, so thirteen would have been too many. God evidently had a very special reason for

raising Paul up later.

CONFUSION WORSE CONFOUNDED

Referring to the pre-Pentecostal days, Dr. X said: "They as yet knew nothing about the Church. That was still a mystery, not to be revealed until after the Holy Spirit came" (P. 6) and "the disciples were to WAIT for the Holy Spirit to give them instructions for the carrying out of the program for the Church" (P. 12, emphasis his). This is strange indeed, for if they were to learn about the Church, the Body of Christ, *at Pentecost,* how is it that they only *began offering* the kingdom *after* Pentecost? (Acts 2:29-31; 3:19-21). Was it not because of Israel's *rejection* of the kingdom that God began to form "the Body of Christ," with its heavenly position and calling?

Dr. X stated on Page 20: "How glad we are that the disciples were in the place where they *could* receive the Holy Spirit!" But, we ask, what difference if they did not accept the Spirit's teaching about the Body and proclaimed the kingdom instead?

And if these circumcision apostles were to learn the mystery of the Body, the Church of today, at Pentecost, how is it that Paul later declared:

"For this cause, I Paul, the prisoner of Jesus Christ for you Gentiles,

"If ye have heard of *the dispensation* of *the* grace of *God* which is given me [not "us”] to you-ward,

"How that by revelation He mode known unto me the mystery. . . ."

"Unto me, who am less than the least of all saints, is this grace given, that I should preach among the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ:

"And to make all men see what is the fellowship of the mystery, which from the beginning of the world hath been hid in God, who created all things by Jesus Christ" (Eph. 3: 1-3, 8, 9).

"Now to Him that is of power to establish you according to my *gospel,* and the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the mystery, which was kept secret since the world began" (Rom. 16:25).

Further, if, as Dr. X agreed, Gentiles were not even addressed at Pentecost, how could the twelve apostles have been proclaiming the troth of the “joint body" composed of Jewish *and Gentile* believers baptized into one body? (l Cor. 12:13).

Now, Dr, X taught that "Pentecost for the Church was once for all" (P.20) and

that at that time, and never again later, believers were baptized into the Body of Christ. In his Booklet No.2 on Acts, he declares: "This outpouring of the Spirit at Pentecost is the ONE BAPTISM of Ephesians 4" (P. 4, emphasis his).

It is not strange, then, that in the same booklet, in a passage where he cites I Cor. 12:13, he omits the words, *"whether we be Jews or Gentiles,"* for at Pentecost, where he said the baptism into one body took place "once and for all," *Gentiles were not included* (See Acts 2:5, 14, 22, 36) as they are in I Cor. 12:13.

And still further, if the Holy Spirit at Pentecost revealed to the twelve the mystery of the Body and the dispensation of grace, how is it that Peter commanded his repentant hearers to *"be baptized. . . . for the remission of sins"?* (Acts 2:38). The answer is that the mystery was *not* revealed at Pentecost and that the twelve were laboring under a *kingdom* commission, which stipulated: *"He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved. . ."* (Mark 16:16).

But confusion is worse confounded as Dr. X insists that Paul was one of the twelve, yet acknowledges that the twelve were promised twelve thrones in the kingdom and, at Pentecost, preached a kingdom message! How preposterous to have Paul, *the apostle of the Gentiles,* reigning with the twelve over *the twelve tribes of Israel!* And it is by no means debatable whether or not Dr. X held this position, for in this connection he wrote: "in the Church there are no apostles. These belong to the kingdom" (P.16).

This last statement is almost unbelievable from one who has long been acquainted with such passages as the following:

"And God hath set some in the Church, *first apostles. . ."* (I Cor. 12:28).

"And He gave some, apostles. . . for the edifying [building up] of the Body of Christ" (Eph. 4:11,12).

Says Dr. X: "In the Church there are no apostles. These belong to the Kingdom." Says *God;* He set apostles in the Church *first.*[34] Who is right, God or Dr. X?

Surely our brother knew that again and again Paul addresses himself to the local *Gentile* churches as *"an apostle of Jesus Christ."* But such confusion is common to those who rebel against any segment of the clear Word of God and endeavor to explain it away.

Such statements as the above can be accounted for only by Dr. X's blind determination to make Paul one of the twelve kingdom apostles and so to discount the special character of his apostleship as associated with the Church of our day. It seems he simply closed his eyes to even the plainest Scriptures that

[34] Among these were Paul, Barnabas (Acts 14:4,14), Silas and Timothy (I Thes. 1:1; 2:6); the latter three evidently in a secondary sense, as "sent ones" of Christ.

contradicted this theory.

Again, if, as our brother stated, "the disciples were to WAIT for the Holy Spirit to give them instructions for the carrying out of the program for the Church," why did he deplore "the rapid recent spread of Pentecostalism," to which he refers on Page 1? One of the chief results of the Holy Spirit's coming was the gift of tongues and other miraculous signs. And these signs were further bestowed only upon those who obeyed the command to "repent and be baptized. . . for the remission of sins" (Acts 2:38). Now, if the Holy Spirit was to come at Pentecost to give instructions for the carrying out of the program for the Church of this dispensation, as Dr. X held, what is wrong with Pentecostalism or with baptism for the remission of sins? Would not our brother have been more consistent to have joined either the Pentecostalists (who are seeking to recover the Pentecostal signs) or the Campbellites, the "Church of Christ" so-called (who insist on water baptism *for* salvation)? But then these two denominations are also sorely divided - because neither of them recognize Paul's special apostleship and ministry!

Referring to the ministry of the apostles under our Lord's commission of Matt. 10:5-7, our brother wrote: "But this offer of the Kingdom was not accepted and so instead of sitting upon the Throne of David, He was rejected by the nation and sent to the cross. . ." (P.10).

But where do we find any *offer* of the kingdom before the cross, or any hint that because Israel rejected the kingdom our Lord "went to the cross in*stead"?* How could He *offer* the establishment of the kingdom before going to the cross? There are scores of passages in Scripture to prove that Christ's kingdom glory was to *"follow"* His sufferings (Luke 24:26; I Pet. 1:11; *et al).* This is why we do not find *even* one *offer* of the kingdom until Pentecost and after - when Dr. X said the Church of this dispensation began!

Dr. X did not deny that in early Acts the twelve "… *still preached the message of the Kingdom"* (pp. 17, 18), but notice his explanation of this:

"Impetuous, impatient Peter," he said, could not wait for the Spirit to direct him, because "he was still thinking of the setting up of the Kingdom. . . ." "This had been postponed,"[35] he said, "but Peter could not accept that idea" (P.12).

So, according to Dr. X Peter and the eleven also proclaimed the kingdom in the energy of the flesh - a kingdom which had already been postponed! We glance at Acts 2:4 and say, *What confusion!*

All this gives us great confidence in our conviction that the Church of the present

[35] How could the kingdom have been postponed before Pentecost when *at* Pentecost Peter declared that Christ had been raised from the dead *"to sit on the throne of David"* (Acts 2:29-32), and soon after *offered His return to reign* (Acts 3:19-21)?

day, the Body of Christ, did not have its historical beginning until later, with the raising up of *Paul,* that *other* apostle.

If only our opponents were willing to see this, for it is indeed *so simple.* But Satan hates this truth and he who "blinds the minds of them that believe not," also does his best to confuse those who do believe in Christ.

What, actually, do we read about in the so-called "Great Commission" and the record of Pentecost? Do we read one word about "the gospel of the grace of God," or the salvation of the Gentiles through Israel's fall, or the one Joint Body, the Church of today? Not one word. We read rather about repentance and baptism for the remission of sins, about miraculous signs and about Christ as King (See Matt. 28:18-20; Mark 16:15-18; Luke 24:47; Acts 1-3). Not until Paul do we learn of salvation by grace through faith, "without the deeds of the law" (Rom. 3:12-28), or of Gentile salvation through Israel's fall (Rom. 11:11), or of "the Church which is His [Christ's] Body" (Eph. 1:22,23). Thus the *twelve* apostles represented Israel, with her *twelve* tribes, while Paul represents the *one Body.*

It does not take much investigation to learn that the Messianic kingdom was *prophesied* in Old Testament times, *proclaimed "at hand"* during our Lord's earthly ministry, and *offered* when the Holy Spirit came at Pentecost,

How could the Church, the Body of Christ, have begun at Pentecost, when the *first* offer of the kingdom was not made until Acts 3? Dr. X said that Peter "could not accept the idea" that the kingdom had already been postponed before Pentecost (P.12). Actually Peter was right and Dr. X wrong. The kingdom had *not* been postponed, and would not be postponed until our Lord's prayer from the cross (Luke 23:34) had been answered and Israel given a second chance at Pentecost.

This is why Spirit-filled Peter offered *"repentance* to *Israel, and the forgiveness of sins"* (Acts 5:31), and promised that Christ and "the times of refreshing" would come "from the presence of the Lord" if they would but repent and be converted (Acts 3:19,20).

It was Dr. X who could not, or would not, accept the great volume of Scripture which testifies to the distinctive character of Paul's position as "the apostle of the Gentiles" and of the present dispensation of the grace of God (Eph. 3:1-3).

To some of our readers this may seem a trivial matter. Actually it is of vast and vital importance.

Dr. X, strangely, adhered to the Pauline Epistles in proclaiming salvation by grace through faith alone. But he *also* contended that we are *to* labor under the so-called "great commission" and that the directions for the program of the

Church of today were given by the Holy Spirit at Pentecost. What conclusion, then, can the thoughtful unsaved person come *to* as he reads the various records of the "great commission" and the story of Pentecost? He may well conclude: "Dr. X *says* that salvation is by grace through faith alone, but the "great commission" says: "He that believeth *and is baptized* shall be saved." And Peter, working under the 'great commission,' said: *"Repent and be baptized, every one of you,* in the name of Jesus Christ, *for the remission of sins."* And how could Dr. X or his followers answer the Seventh Day Adventists in the light of Matt. 28:20, or the Pentecostalists in the light of Mark 16:17,18, or the Campbellites in the light of Mark 16:16 and Acts 2:38, or other unsound groups in the light of other parts of the "great commission," a commission which once was, but no longer is, in force?

Dr. X's confusion on these matters was indeed profound, but it was typical of the confusion that exists in the ranks of all who deny the distinctive character of Paul's apostleship and ministry and keep talking - only talking - about "obeying the great commission."

In our brother's case we fear that the blindness was willful, for he publicly maligned and misrepresented those who stood for the great Pauline revelation, charging them with heresies they never taught. While he wrote of "Paul's insistence upon having his own way" (*Blunders of Paul,* P. 16) it was rather *he* who insisted upon having his own way in this matter. Perhaps he should have quoted one of his statements about Paul to himself: *"How terrible is the sin of disobedience! How it blinds a person and twists his reason and judgment!"* (*Ibid,* P. 16).

God knows we never harbored the least ill-will toward this man of God who was used to reach vast numbers with the Word, if sometimes the Word wrongly divided. We have published the foregoing only that our readers may clearly see what confusion results from a denial of the important Bible truth that Paul is *our* apostle and the apostle of the present dispensation of the grace of God. Also, that to place ourselves under the commission given to the twelve (temporarily eleven) is to be laboring under the wrong commission.

What spiritual power the Church could exert if she knew Christ as presented by Paul in his message of grace and glory! How much confusion would be dispelled, how much division would disappear! What a refreshing spiritual revival would result! This is what the Church and our poor world need today. How long will our Fundamentalist leaders resist God's truth and hold back true revival? How long will they continue working under the *wrong* commission; a commission which none of them can or do fully or faithfully obey?

Chapter XI

WAS PAUL BOASTFUL?

HIS DEFENSE OF HIS APOSTLESHIP

In the first chapter of this book we discussed the question: Do We *Make Too Much of Paul?* In this chapter let us consider the further question: *Did Paul Make Too Much of Himself?*

Most people think of Paul as being more or less of the same rank as Peter, James, John and the rest of the Lord's apostles. They feel, and rightly so, that the twelve and Paul were, all of them, appointed apostles by Christ Himself, sent forth to testify of Him. As we have seen, some even consider Paul *one of the twelve, God's* choice for Judas' successor.

But here comes Paul, disclaiming most of this. Indeed, the personal element stands out prominently in his epistles. He refers to himself *by name* some thirty times in these few epistles, and by the personal pronoun *several hundred times.*

Here comes Paul, speaking again and again of "my gospel." In Rom. 2:16 he says, "God shall judge the secrets of men by Jesus Christ according to *my gospel."* In Rom. 16:25 he opens a benediction with the words, "Now to Him that is of power to establish you according to *my gospel.* . . ." And in II Tim., 2:8 he says, "Remember that Jesus Christ, of the seed of David, was raised from the dead according to *my gospel."*

Here comes Paul, referring to *"the gospel which was preached of [by] me"* (Gal. 1:11), and *"that gospel which I preach"* (Gal. 2:2). And such phraseology is found throughout his writings.

Indeed, he goes farther than this, for he is the only one of all the apostles who takes upon his lips the words of our Lord, *"Follow me."* Twice he exhorts the Corinthians: *"Be ye followers of me"* (I Cor. 4:16; 11:1), and to the Philippians he says, *"Brethren, be ye followers together of me, and mark them which walk so as ye have us for an example"* (Phil. 3:17). Such phraseology too is familiar to Paul's epistles.

But even this is not all, for in II Cor. 11:5 he declares,

"For I suppose that I was not a whit behind the very chiefest apostles."

Did Paul have a right thus to promote his own ministry and distinguish it from that of the twelve? Certainly those who claim that Paul and the twelve all proclaimed

the same message have never given a satisfactory explanation of this aspect of his epistles.

But as we consider the Galatian epistle Paul's convictions - and the teachings of the Holy Spirit as to the uniqueness of his position, become even more pronounced. Here he takes up almost two chapters to defend his apostleship, which evidently had been called into question. In these two chapters he appears to belittle the apostles at Jerusalem and to exalt his own apostleship. In the eleventh and twelfth verses of the first chapter he *certifies* to the Galatians that he had not received his message from the twelve or from *any* human source, but by *direct revelation from the glorified Lord Himself.*

Indeed, in Gal. 2:2-5 he declares: "I *went up by revelation, and communicated unto them that gospel which I preach among the Gentiles.* . ." and adds that when, at Jerusalem, some insisted that Titus should be circumcised, he *"gave place, by subjection, no, not for an hour,"* that his "gospel of the grace of God" might continue uninterrupted among the Gentile believers at Antioch.

In Ver. 6 he refers to James, Peter and John (in that order) as *"those who seemed to be somewhat,"*[36] and adds:

". . . in conference [they] added nothing to me:

"But contrariwise, when they saw that the gospel of the uncircumcision was committed unto me, as the gospel of the circumcision was unto Peter. . . .

"And when James, Cephas and John, who seemed to be pillars, perceived the grace that was given unto me, they gave to me and Barnabas the right hands of fellowship, that we should go unto the heathen [Gentiles] and they unto the circumcision" (Vers. 6-9).

Consider well what has happened here. The twelve apostles, who had originally been sent to *"all the world"* and to *"all nations,"* now, through their leaders, actually *turn over the evangelization of the Gentiles to Paul, agreeing henceforth to confine their own ministry to Israel!* Thus Paul declares to the Romans, not from pride, but by inspiration of the Holy Spirit:

". . . *I am the apostle of the Gentiles; I magnify mine office!"*

And he demonstrated this authority in Antioch, where Peter would have compromised the decision which, under the Spirit's leading, had been made at the Jerusalem Council. Read his words in Gal. 2:11,14:

“When Peter was come to Antioch, I withstood him to the face, because he was

[36] Evidently because this James, not even one of the twelve, had usurped Peter's leadership (See Matt. 16:18,19 and cf. Acts 15:13,19).

to be blamed."

". . . when I saw that they walked not uprightly according to the truth of the gospel, I said unto Peter before them all, If thou, being a Jew, livest after the manner of the Gentiles, and not as do the Jews, why compel lest thou the Gentiles to live as do the Jews?"

And this was *published in a letter* to "the churches of Galatia."

Here we would almost call a halt and say to Paul: "Have you forgotten your position? Do you realize that you are making a public example of the leader of the twelve apostles? Should you not consider that he was an apostle before you, that you have but recently been appointed to this position? Have you forgotten that the Lord Himself gave to Peter the keys of the kingdom of heaven and that thousands of souls have been saved through his ministry?" This would be difficult to explain if we did not understand "the mystery," the secret.

But even this is not all. One of Paul's strongest statements in this connection is found in Gal. 1:8, where he says:

"But though we, or an angel from heaven, preach any other gospel unto you than that which we have preached unto you, let him be accursed."

And he *means* to speak strongly, for in the next verse he repeats himself for emphasis:

"As we said before, so say I now again; if any man preach any other gospel unto you than that ye have received let him be accursed."

So Paul actually pronounces a curse upon any who would dare to preach to these Gentiles any other gospel than that which he has preached to them. When this is considered in the light of Gal. 2:7, the seriousness of this curse is seen, for "the gospel of the circumcision" was certainly *not* the same as "the gospel of the *un*circumcision."

How shall we explain all this?

Suppose for a moment that I, the author of this book, should begin to talk about *"my gospel"!* Would you not rightly condemn me for setting myself up above other servants of Christ and preaching another gospel? Indeed, you would rightly say: "If it is *your* gospel I do not wish to hear it."

And suppose I should say to my audiences: *"Brethren, be followers of me"!* Would you not exclaim: "What consummate pride!"

INADEQUATE EXPLANATIONS

In seeking to explain these statements of Paul some would explain them *away!* They contend that his term "my gospel" simply means that he too preached the gospel, and deny that it distinguishes his message from that of the twelve. They say that when he told others to follow him he merely meant that they should imitate his *main purpose* in life. They argue that when he went up to Jerusalem to communicate his gospel to the twelve it was only to check with them and make sure that they were all preaching the same thing. But all this is contrary to the simple, obvious meaning of his words.

There are a few who argue that Paul could say, "Be followers of me" because he really lived the life, but surely this explanation too is inadequate. If the most sincere, godly Christian today should begin to say, *"Brethren, be followers together of me and mark them which walk so as ye have us for an example,"* we would realize at once that he had lost all his humility and his spirituality. Is *any man* safe to follow in everything? Did Paul have no trouble with the old nature? (See Rom. 7:18, 21-24).

How then shall we explain Paul's apparent boasting; his insistence on the distinctiveness of his ministry and message, his apparent belittling of the other apostles to exalt his own apostleship, his insistence that in conference they had added nothing to him but rather he to them, his refusal to give place to the Hebrew Christian leaders even for an hour, his public rebuke of Peter, his call to others to follow him, his curse upon any who should dare to preach to the Gentiles any other gospel than that which he had preached to them? How shall we explain all this?

The answer to this question of Paul's emphasis on his own ministry is the key to the whole message of grace.

THE GLORY OF GOD'S GRACE

We must not forget that the same one who says in II Cor. 11:5: "*I suppose I was not a whit behind the very chiefest apostles,"* also says in I Cor. 15:9,10:

"I am the *least* of the apostles, that am not meet to be called an apostle, because I persecuted the Church of God, BUT BY THE GRACE OF GOD I AM WHAT I AM."

It is in the last clause of this verse that we find the solution to the whole problem: *"By the grace of God I am what I am."*

In immediate conjunction with Paul's "boasting" we have his acknowledgement *that he himself is nothing.* In other passages he calls himself the chief of sinners, and "less than the least of all saints," but in each case he magnifies God's grace

in making him what he now is.

The glorious fact was that God had taken Saul, the guilty leader of the rebellion against Christ, and had made him the herald and the living demonstration of His infinite grace. When Paul defends and exalts his own apostleship, therefore, he does so, not for the glory of Paul, but for the glory of God; not to exalt himself, but to exalt the grace of God. Consistently he associates his apostleship with the riches of God's grace. Note the following examples of this fact; note them thoughtfully:

Rom. 1:5: "By whom we have received grace and *apostleship. . . .*"

Rom. 12:3: "For I say, *through the grace given unto me. . . "*

Rom. 15:15, 16: "Nevertheless, brethren, *I have written the more boldly unto you. . . because of the grace that is given to me of God, that I should be the minister of Jesus Christ to the Gentiles . . . ."*

I Cor. 15:9, 10: "For I am the least of the apostles, that am not worthy to be called an apostle. . . *but by the grace of God I am what I am; and His grace which was bestowed upon me was not in vain, but I labored more abundantly than they all; yet not I, but the grace of God which was with me."*

Gal. 1:15, 16: ". . . *it pleased God who... called me by His grace, to reveal His Son in me, that I might preach Him among the heathen. . . ."*

Gal. 2:9: "And when James, Cephas, and John, who seemed to be pillars, perceived *the grace that was given unto me*, they gave to me and Barnabas the right hands of fellowship; *that we should* go *unto the heathen,* and they unto the circumcision."

Eph. 3:8: *"Unto me, whom am less than the least of all saints, is this grace given, that I should preach among the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ."*

Doubtless the most notable passage in which Paul associates his apostleship with the grace of God is I Tim. 1:12-16:

"And I thank Christ Jesus our Lord, who hath enabled me, for that He counted me faithful, putting me into the ministry;

“Who was before a blasphemer, and a persecutor, and injurious: but I obtained mercy, because I did it ignorantly in unbelief.

"And the grace of our Lord was exceeding abundant, with faith and love which is in Christ Jesus.

"This is a faithful saying and worthy of all acceptation, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners; *of whom I am chief.*

"Howbeit, for this cause I obtained mercy, that in me first Jesus Christ might show forth all longsuffering, for a pattern to them which should hereafter believe on Him to life everlasting."

We must not forget to consider the apostle's *former* position when we study his subsequent role in the program of God. We can only understand *Paul* when we have first considered *Saul.* In the passage just cited he marvels that God should have put *him* into the ministry who before had been *"a blasphemer, and a persecutor, and injurious,"* and accounts for it only by pointing out that *"the grace of our Lord was exceeding abundant."*

When Paul here calls himself the "chief of sinners" he does not mean that he was the *worst* of sinners. Judas, the Pharisees and the Sadducees were doubtless more unscrupulous in their sins than he, but Paul's position as *the flaming leader of the rebellion* against Christ, constituted him the *"chief"* of sinners. He was God's greatest enemy on earth.

Look at the picture historically. God had given up the ungodly Gentile nations and had chosen one nation, the Hebrew nation, for His own, and now, behold *this* nation rebels against Him! And who is the leader of the rebellion? The book of Acts answers this too plainly to misunderstand. It was not the high priest, or the Sanhedrin. It was Saul of Tarsus who took the initiative in the persecution that raged against Christ. It was he who *"made havoc of the Church"* and, *"breathing out threatenings and slaughter against the disciples of the Lord, went unto the high priest, and desired of him letters to Damascus to the synagogues, that if he found any of this way, whether they were men* or *women, he might bring them bound unto Jerusalem"* (Acts 8:3 and 9:1,2). And these are only two of the long list of Scriptures which indicate the intensity of Saul's enmity against the Lord Jesus Christ and His disciples.

The word "chief," then, does not imply merely degree but *rank,* and it is not strange that this term is applied to him as the one who inspired and led the bitter and aggressive rebellion which caused God to cast away Israel ("for a season") and conclude the nation, along with the Gentiles, in unbelief.

There is a tendency to excuse Saul because he says: *"I did it ignorantly in unbelief."* It is true that the very sincerity of his hatred of Christ moved the compassionate heart of God to save him, but we must not suppose that his ignorance was excusable. He *could and should* have known that Jesus was the Christ, and in this very passage the Holy Spirit, through Paul himself, emphasizes the exceeding riches of God's *grace* to Saul *the sinner.*

Surely it was amazing grace that took *this man* and saved him and put him into

the ministry, and it is because Paul's apostleship was the supreme demonstration of God's infinite grace to sinners that he defended it so vigorously.

In this same passage he says:

"Howbeit for this cause I obtained mercy, that in me first[37] Jesus Christ might show forth all longsuffering, for a *pattern* to them which should hereafter believe on Him to life everlasting."

In Paul, pre-eminently, the rejected Lord showed forth *all longsuffering.* Paul was the *pattern* for those who should thenceforth believe on Christ to life everlasting. He was even the pattern for the nation Israel, who too must learn that "there is no difference" (Rom. 3:22,23; 10:12,13) and, having learned this, will one day be saved wholly and solely by the matchless grace of God.

For long centuries the Church as a whole has lost sight of the distinctive position Paul holds in the program of God. They have called him "one of the apostles," forgetting that whereas the twelve had been sent into all the world in connection with the *acceptance* of Christ, the *rise* of Israel and the *authority* of God. Paul was sent to all the world in view of the *rejection* of Christ, the *fall* of Israel and the *grace* of God.

As a result, multitudes of earnest believers, even to this day, are at a loss to explain Paul's apparent boasting and are utterly disagreed and confused as to God's message and program for our day. Think of the confusion that still prevails as to the signs of the times, the work of the Holy Spirit, water baptism and the return of Christ, all so needless in view of what the Scriptures plainly say with regard to the distinctive character of Paul's apostleship and his message.

In the light of the Scriptures here considered it is difficult for us to understand how Fundamentalist leaders and dispensational Bible teachers can continue to contend that there was no basic difference between the messages of Paul and of the twelve. But to the degree that they do so contend, their confusion and their divisions deepen.

Question for a moment the distinctive character of Paul's ministry, or place him in the same category with the twelve, and you tarnish the glory of God's wonderful grace and becloud His eternal purpose in Christ. This is why Paul throws the "certificate of his ordination" down on the table, as it were, with the declaration:

". . . I certify you, brethren, that the gospel which was preached of me is not after man.

"For I neither received it of man, neither was I taught it, but by the revelation of Jesus Christ" (Gal. 1:11, 12).

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[37] In the Greek this same word *chief* is employed again.

And this is why he declares, by divine inspiration, "I am the apostle of the Gentiles; I magnify mine office" (Rom. 11:13).

Let us take care, then, not to disregard what God so emphatically "certifies," or minimize what He magnifies, lest we grieve Him and forfeit His most precious blessings. Rather let us heartily receive His Word and experience to the greatest possible degree, the power that Paul experienced in his ministry for Christ.

Did Paul Have A Special Temporary Ministry?

Chapter XII

PAUL'S EARLY MINISTRY

A DISPENSATIONAL PROBLEM

Some aspects of the early ministry of Paul have puzzled many earnest and diligent Bible students.

They see quite clearly what his ministry *led up to.* They rejoice in his pure message of grace. They understand fully that water baptism and the Pentecostal signs have no more place in the Body of Christ than do circumcision and the Law, but they are perplexed, not to say somewhat disappointed, to find circumcision, baptism and miraculous signs all practiced by Paul during his early ministry as recorded in the book of Acts.

A FAULTY EXPLANATION

This problem has led some to suppose that the mystery was not revealed to Paul until his Roman imprisonment, and that the Body of Christ, the Church of the present dispensation, did not begin, historically, until after Acts 28:28, when Paul declared to the Jewish leaders at Rome:

"Be it known therefore unto you, that the salvation of God is sent unto the Gentiles, and that they will hear it."

But such a conclusion only makes the problem more difficult, for we read of the mystery and of the Body of Christ in Paul's *earlier* epistles, written before Acts 28, as well as in those written after. Indeed, this fact has driven those who date the Body from Acts 28 to the conclusion that there must be *two bodies* - that "the body of Christ" of which Paul speaks in Romans and I Corinthians is a different body from "the body of Christ" to which his later epistles refer.

They have been *driven* to this conclusion, we say, for such an explanation is, to say the least, forced and unnatural. We cannot help feeling that such theories must sound flimsy even to those who propose them and should cause them to re-examine the foundation of their structure, for a wrong premise will surely lead to wrong conclusions. Certainly the "two body" theory has led to many unscriptural conclusions.

One leader of this school of thought has stated that "since Paul's ministry was primarily to the Jews during the Acts, his epistles written during that same time could not be otherwise."

This extravagant statement is wholly unsupported by Scripture; indeed the Scriptures pronounce it palpably erroneous.

PAUL'S ACTS MINISTRY

In Acts 22:18, 21 Paul relates how, upon his *first* return to Jerusalem after his conversion, the Lord had revealed to him that his testimony would not be received there and that he was to go to the Gentiles:

"And [I] saw Him [Christ] saying unto me, Make haste, and get thee quickly out of Jerusalem, for *they will not receive thy testimony concerning Me."*

"And He said unto me, *Depart: for I will send thee far hence unto the Gentiles."*

And the story of his ministry from then on is in perfect harmony with this.

Acts 13:46, 47: "lo, we turn to *the Gentiles, for* so *hath the Lord commanded* us. . . ."

Acts 15:3: "And being brought on their way by the church, they passed through Phenice and Samaria, *declaring the conversion of the Gentiles.* . . ."

Acts 18:6: *"From henceforth I will go unto the Gentiles."*

Acts 21:18, 19: "And the day following Paul went in with us unto James; and all the elders were present. And when he had saluted them, *he declared particularly what things God had wrought among the Gentiles by his ministry."*

PAUL'S EARLY EPISTLES

When we compare Paul's early epistles with the latter part of the book of Acts (the period during which they were written) the picture remains unchanged.

To the Romans he wrote:

"I speak to you Gentiles, inasmuch as I am the apostle of the Gentiles" (Rom. 11:13).

To the Corinthians:

"Ye know that ye were Gentiles, carried away unto these dumb idols" (I Cor. 12:2).

To the Galatians:

". . . it pleased God . . . to reveal His Son in me, *that I might preach Him* among

the heathen [Gentiles]" (Gal. 1:15, 16).

"Howbeit then, when ye knew not God, ye did service unto them which by nature are no gods" (Gal. 4:8).

To the Thessalonians:

"For *ye,* brethren, became followers of the churches of God which in Judaea are in Christ Jesus: *for ye also have suffered like things of your own countrymen, even as they have of the Jews"* (I Thes. 2:14).

Surely all these quotations from Acts and the early epistles of Paul prove conclusively that his early ministry was *primarily to the Gentiles* and *not* "primarily to the Jews." It is true that during this time he went to the Jew *first* in city after city, but this is a very different matter. And herein lies the solution to the problem of Paul's early ministry.

THE SOLUTION

When Paul went to the Jew first, it was *not* because it seemed that Israel might yet accept Christ and His kingdom, but simply because God would leave Israel no excuse for rejecting Messiah.

Paul confirmed Peter's message, and mightily contended with the Jews everywhere that *"Jesus is the Christ."* And miracles accompanied this confirmation testimony - greater miracles, indeed, than Peter himself had wrought. But, unlike Peter, *Paul never offered the kingdom to Israel.* His ministry among them was not to turn *the nation* to Christ, but to save any from among them who might believe, receiving salvation by grace, and to leave the rest without excuse. Thus God was concluding Israel in unbelief and, even at that early date, mightily using Paul to proclaim grace to the Gentiles.

True, Paul, who but lately had been the leading persecutor of Christ, first thought that his testimony might turn the tide of unbelief in Israel, but God knew better. He knew that the crisis in Israel's history had been reached at the stoning of Stephen. Persuasion would be useless. Salvation was now to be sent to the Gentiles, not *through* Israel, but *in spite of* her, and Paul himself was chosen for this purpose.

This incident in Paul's early Christian experience should already be viewed in the light of three important verses of Scripture:

Rom. 11:15: "If the costing away of them [Israel] be the reconciling of the world. . . ."

Rom. 11:32: "God hath concluded them all in unbelief that He might have mercy upon all."

Eph. 2:16: "And that He might reconcile both unto God in one body by the cross, having slain the enmity thereby."

Of course, God's gracious purpose in the casting away of Israel (and indeed the casting away itself) was only in *process* of being revealed. Its fullness is only unfolded in the later epistles, where Paul prays that believers may be given wisdom and spiritual understanding to comprehend it. But the reconciling of believing Jews and Gentiles to God in one body and the blessing of the Gentiles through the *fall* of Israel, most assuredly commenced well before the close of the book of Acts.

PETER, PAUL AND ISRAEL

One fact should be clear to even the casual observer: Peter's ministry very definitely had Israel's *acceptance* of Messiah in view (Acts 1:6; 2:30, 38, 39; 3:17-26), but Paul's just as definitely had Israel's *rejection* of Messiah in view. In fact, Paul was raised up by God in view of Israel's rejection of Christ. God's gracious response to the stoning of Stephen and the bitter persecution of Acts 8:1-3 was *the salvation of Saul,* the chief persecutor and the leader of the rebellion. Matchless grace! especially as we realize that the prophesied response was - and is - to be the *wrath* of God and the *subjugation* of our Lord's enemies (Psa. 2:5; 110:1).

According to prophecy the Gentiles were to have been - and one day will be - blessed *through the rise of Israel* (Isa. 60:1-3) but now, even though Israel had rejected Messiah and the glory of His reign, Paul could write to the Gentiles:

"*Now the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing,* that ye may abound in hope, through the power of the Holy Ghost."

". . . I have written the more boldly unto you in some sort [in a way], as putting you in mind, because of *the grace that is given to me of God,*

"That I should be the minister of Jesus Christ to the Gentiles, ministering the gospel of God, that the offering up of the Gentiles might be acceptable, being sanctified by the Holy Ghost" (Rom. 15:13, 15, 16).

Blessing had now come to the Gentiles, not through Israel's rise, but through her *fall:*

". . . through their fall salvation is come to the Gentiles. . ." (Rom. 11:11).

Rom. 11:7 and 25 *("Israel hath not obtained,"* and *"Blindness is happened to Israel")* should surely convince the thoughtful student of the Word that *Paul understood* that God had given up the nation and that a judicial blindness was already settling upon her.

As he opens his Romans epistle, therefore, he argues for his *responsibility* to go to the Gentiles. See the emphasis in this passage:

". . . that I might have some fruit among you also, even *as among other Gentiles.*

"I am debtor, both to the Greeks and to the Barbarians; both to the wise and to the unwise. [He does not even mention the Jew here.]

"So as much as in me is, I am ready to preach the gospel *to you that are at Rome also.*

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel of Christ, for it is the power of God unto salvation *to every one that believeth;* to the Jew first, and also to the Greek" (Rom. 1:13-16).

His argument here is clearly that he is not ashamed to go to the *Gentiles at Rome* with the gospel, since it is the power of God unto salvation TO EVERY ONE THAT BELIEVETH.

The gospel *had been* sent to the Jew first, but now, through Paul, was being sent to the Gentiles, and Paul was ready, with all that was in him, to preach the gospel to those *at Rome also.*

Rom. 1:16, thus considered in the light of its context, by no means conflicts with the rest of Romans. But those who use this passage to teach Jewish precedence today miss one of the basic lessons of the book of Romans.

"For there is *no difference, for all have sinned and come short of the glory of God"* (Rom. 3:22,23).

"For there is no *difference between the Jew and the Greek; for the same Lord over all is rich unto all that call upon Him,*

"For whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved" (Rom. 10:12, 13).

The great motive for Jewish missionary work today is not given us in Rom. 1:16, but in Rom. 11:30-33:

"For as ye [Gentiles] in times past have not believed God, yet have now obtained mercy through their [Israel's] unbelief; even so have these also now not believed, *that through your mercy they also may obtain mercy.*

"For God hath concluded them all in unbelief *that He might have mercy upon all."*

"O the depth of the riches both of the wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable are His judgments, and His ways past finding out!"

PAUL AND THE MYSTERY

The question of Paul's early ministry is important to the understanding of the mystery. There are many who see the component parts of the mystery but fail to put the pieces together. Result? They still have a puzzle instead of a picture.

They fail to see the sweep, the progress, the development in the unfolding of God's wonderful plan. They do not see how, when it seemed that the prophetic purpose had failed and the Gentiles would be deprived of blessing because of Israel's unbelief, God overruled and unfolded His secret, eternal purpose of grace, which at the same time explained how, and how alone, the prophetic purpose could and would after all be fulfilled; indeed, how alone *any* sinner could ever be saved. And this causes us to cry with the Psalmist, *"Surely the wrath of man shall praise Thee; and the remainder of wrath shalt Thou restrain."*

But this secret, eternal purpose was not unfolded to Paul in one revelation, but gradually in many (See Acts 22:17, 18; 26:16; II Cor. 12:1, 7).

Undoubtedly the Apostle both received and communicated *one* great body of truth *gradually,* otherwise *his* term "my gospel" (singular), and *our* term, "the distinctive ministry of Paul" are misnomers.

The old program gradually passed away as the new took its place. There was development in the revelation given to Paul as well as in the historical unfolding of God's purpose. God raised up Paul for *one* great purpose, to declare *one* great message (Eph. 3:1-3; Acts 20:24), though his message confirmed and in no way contradicted the message of Peter and the eleven concerning Christ.

There was a time when the author viewed the mystery as a particular point in Paul's preaching, but now, thank God, he sees it as one great, grand message, the comprehension of which is unspeakably precious.

We would ask our "two body" brethren to consider the following proposition:

We agree that before Paul God had a *revealed, prophetic* purpose. We also agree that through Paul He made known His secret, eternal purpose. Did God have still *another* purpose, a sort of *buffer* between the two? What was Paul's message during his early, or Acts, ministry? Was it the gospel of the kingdom? Most certainly it was not. Was it the gospel of the circumcision? Gal. 2:7 proves that it was not. What was it then? It was "the gospel of the uncircumcision," "the gospel of the grace of God," and these cannot be dissociated from the mystery.

Surely it is altogether gratuitous to argue that Paul had "a special temporary

ministry" during the Acts period, for it was toward the close of the Acts period that he said:

"But none of these things move me, neither count I my life dear unto myself, *so that I might finish my course with joy, and the ministry which I have received of the Lord Jesus, to testify the gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24).

What we must recognize is simply that the old economy was that under which he was saved and *from which he gradually emerged,* also that God brought the new economy in gradually, historically. Therefore it was right and consistent for him to do certain things before Acts 28 which would have been contrary to the will of God after that time.

It is also gratuitous to insist that Paul received the revelation of the mystery in his prison at Rome.

We have no record of such a revelation. And to argue I that such a supposed revelation superseded his other revelations is not only gratuitous - it is a flat contradiction of Scripture, for in Eph. 6:20 and Col. 4:3 he distinctly states that he is in prison FOR the mystery, i.e., for proclaiming it.

It had been *prophesied* that God would bless the nations through Israel's *rise.* It was a *mystery* (until revealed through Paul) that God would bless the nations through Israel's *fall,* and that, casting the nation aside, He would reconcile believing Jews and Gentiles to Himself in one body by the cross. *This is the very heart of the mystery, and it is found in Paul's early epistles.*

NONE OTHER THINGS

We must not stray too far from the purpose of this book to deal further with incidents from the book of Acts and passages from Paul's epistles that prove that Paul's early ministry was primarily to the Gentiles, but there is one passage which should still be examined, since it has been used, probably, more than any other by our "two body" brethren. This passage is Acts 26:22, where the apostle, standing before Agrippa, states:

"Having therefore obtained help of God, I continue unto this day, witnessing both to small and great, *saying none other things than those which the prophets and Moses did say should come*."

This passage, in their opinion, is sufficient proof that until the close of Acts Paul had said *nothing* that the prophets had not already foretold, confining his ministry entirely to the proclamation of God's prophetic purpose. Thus, in effect, they have Paul preaching "the gospel of the circumcision," which he distinctly says was *not* committed to him.

But this is only the beginning of their inconsistencies, for to teach from Acts 26:22 that Paul had thus far taught nothing that the prophets had not already foretold is manifestly *contrary to the record.*

Had the prophets foretold the salvation of the Gentiles through the *fall* of Israel? Had they foretold "the gospel of the grace of God," in which neither circumcision nor the law was to have any part? Had they even hinted that Jews and Gentiles would be baptized into one body by the Spirit? Had they said or even known anything about the rapture of the Church? Yet all of this and more is found in the Acts and in Paul's *early* epistles written during this period.

The trouble is that our brethren have separated Acts 26:22 from its context, for the rest of the quotation clearly specifies the "none other things" to which the apostle refers:

"That Christ should suffer and that He should be the first that should rise from the dead, and should show light unto the people and to the Gentiles" (Ver. 23).

The Jews had turned against Paul for going to the Gentiles, and he here protests that this is nothing but what the prophets and Moses had said should come. The Jews had no reason to complain, for it had been clearly prophesied that Christ should suffer death and should rise again to show light, not only to Israel, but also to the Gentiles.

Thus there are *connections* between prophecy and the mystery proclaimed by Paul, but there are also *distinctions,* for the *reason* God was now blessing the Gentiles was not the same as that which had been predicted in prophecy. This is brought out, for example, in Acts 13:46, where the apostle declares:

“It was necessary [according to the prophetlc program] that the Word of God should first have been spoken to you [Jews]: *But [*Note that something *different* is now taking place] seeing ye *put it from you* and judge yourselves unworthy of everlasting life, lo, we turn to the Gentiles."

Thus blessing was now going to the Gentiles, as God had planned from the beginning. However, God was not blessing them through Israel's *rise* (as per prophecy) but through her *fall* (as per the mystery). He was blessing the Gentiles *in spite of* Israel's obstinacy rather than through her instrumentality. Israel's rebellion had created a "bottle neck," as it were, but God in grace broke the neck!

In summary, *how* did the salvation of God go to the Gentiles? *Through* Israel? No, *in spite of* Israel (Acts 13:46). As a result of Israel's *rise?* No, as a result of her *fall* (Rom. 11:11). Through the power of Christ enthroned? No, by the *grace* of Christ *rejected* (I Tim. 1:13-16). Through the ministry of *Peter and the eleven?* No, through the ministry of *Paul* (Rom. 11:13; 15:16). Under the *"great commission"?* No, under a much greater commission (II Cor. 5:16-21).

Chapter XIII

PAUL'S PRISON MINISTRY –

DEFEAT OR TRIUMPH?

Paul's imprisonment in Rome has enriched the! Church with the most precious of his letters -- those which take us to the pinnacle of spiritual truth, as for example, in Ephesians, which has so much to say about the Body, Colossians, which so exalts the Head, and Philippians, where we see the Head working through the Body.

With this in mind let us here consider whether Paul did right or wrong in making his last journey to Jerusalem - which eventuated in his imprisonment at Rome.

In our research on this subject we have been amazed at two things: (1) the extreme scarcity of comprehensive writings on a subject so manifestly significant, and (2) the fact that the brief comments in most commentaries on Acts are so one-sided, ignoring the arguments on one side or the other, according to the writer's views.

We therefore list the main Scriptural arguments on both sides to see how they may be reconciled.

THE ARGUMENTS FOR PAUL'S GOING TO JERUSALEM AT THIS TIME

1. Paul's plans were not made "according to the flesh" (II Cor. 1:15-17).

2. Later, standing before the Sanhedrin, and still I later, in a letter to Timothy, the apostle declared that from his youth he had served God with a clear conscience (Acts 23:1; II Tim. 1:3).

3. He declared his determination to continue the journey to Jerusalem so that he might finish his course and his ministry *"with joy"* (Acts 20:24).

4. When his friends could not dissuade him from his purpose, they said: *"The will of the Lord be done"* (Acts 21:14).

5. After Paul had reached Jerusalem the Lord, rather than rebuking him, *encouraged* him, saying: *"Be of good cheer, Paul, for as thou has testified of Me in Jerusalem, so must thou bear witness also at Rome"* (Acts 23:11).

6. Shortly before his death, Paul wrote: "*I have fought a good fight, I have*

finished my course, I have kept the faith" (II Tim. 4:7) which, it is alleged, he could not have said had he been out of the will of the Lord in making this journey to Jerusalem.

But these arguments are not as conclusive as they may seem at first sight.

As to No.1 above, the apostle did not refer in II Cor. 1:15-17 to *all* his plans, or purposes, much less to his purpose to visit Jerusalem for the last time. Rather he referred to his former plan to visit the *Corinthians* (Ver. 15). It was with respect to the *change* in this plan that he protested: *"'Did I use lightness? Or the things that I purpose do I purpose according* to *the flesh?"* (Ver. 17).

As to No.2, it is clear from his own testimony that he was far from perfect, and that his claim to have lived before God from his youth with clear conscience refers, not to all the details of his life, but to his adopted course in first opposing Christ, then turning to Him and serving Him. Indeed, the fact that he even persecuted Christ with a clear conscience (Acts 26:9) proves that it is possible to do wrong with a clear, though warped, conscience.

No.4 will be dealt with directly, but first let us consider Nos. 5 and 6.

No one would deny that Paul's *motives* in going to Jerusalem at this time were the highest. He felt deeply indebted to his kinsmen, and was risking his very life in going to preach grace to them. Is it strange, then, that God should *encourage* him after his noble stand before the angry multitude at Jerusalem and before the Sanhedrin? Would we not *expect* God to do this? See how He encouraged fainting Elijah after his bold stand at Mt. Carmel (I Kings 19:5-8). God's encouragement of Paul in this case in no way proves that he was in God's *directive* will in going to Jerusalem at this time, or that God had
sent him there.

Thus those words of acquiescence, *"The will of the Lord be done"* (under No.4), refer to God's *permissive will, not to His directive will.* They were spoken when the apostle *"would not be persuaded."*

Finally as to No.6: Take any failures you can find in Paul in the record of Scripture; then compare them with the *rest* of the record and ask yourself whether he was not more than justified in declaring: "*I have fought* a *good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith."* Who of us has done half so well?

THE ARGUMENTS AGAINST PAUL'S GOING TO JERUSALEM AT THIS TIME

These, in turn, are mostly as follows:

1. Long before this the Lord had commanded Paul to leave Jerusalem explaining:

"They will not receive thy testimony concerning Me" (Acts 22:18).

2. There is no record that Paul had any opportunity to testify "the gospel of the grace of God" at Jerusalem as he had hoped. He certainly did not do so by subjecting himself to a Jewish ceremony.

3. There is no record that the Lord Jesus or the Holy Spirit directed Paul to make this visit to Jerusalem (Ctr. Gal. 2:2). If he *had* been directed to go surely it would have been so stated, especially in view of all the warnings and pleas *against* his going.

4. While on the way, he received several warnings *from the Spirit* as to what would befall him if he went up to Jerusalem (Acts 20:23; 21:10,11), and it is distinctly stated that the disciples at Tyre *"said to Paul through the Spirit, that he should not go up to Jerusalem"* (Acts 21:4).

5. He was taken from Jerusalem to Rome as *"the prisoner of Jesus Christ for [the] Gentiles"* (Eph. 3:1). He was also a prisoner *for* Christ, but in *this* connection he was the prisoner *of* Christ for the sake of the Gentiles.

We must confess that we are nonplussed to find so few commentators who have grasped the simple significance of this phrase, *"the prisoner of Jesus Christ for you Gentiles."* He does not say here that he was a prisoner *for* Christ (though this was also true). He does not say that he was a prisoner of the Jews or of the Romans. He says that he was *"the prisoner OF Jesus Christ, FOR you Gentiles,"* i.e., Jesus Christ was holding him in prison for the sake of the Gentiles, not as punishment, but because his heart kept turning back to his kinsmen according to the flesh; to those for whose apostasy he held himself so largely responsible.

PAUL'S SPIRIT AND THE HOLY SPIRIT

The question as to just how much the Holy Spirit and Paul's own spirit were involved in this episode is really not difficult to answer.

Five times in the record the word *spirit* (Gr. *pneuma)* is used, and we believe that in each case it is clear whether Paul's spirit or the Holy Spirit is referred to.

In Acts 19:21 we read that *"Paul purposed in the spirit. . . to go to Jerusalem."* Now the phrase "in the spirit" is often used of man's own spirit[38] and had there not been a point to prove no one, probably, would ever have questioned the natural interpretation, that Paul resolved in his spirit to go to Jerusalem.

Note carefully that it was *Paul* who *purposed* to go to Jerusalem. Would it not be stretching things a bit to interpret this to mean that the *Holy Spirit* led, or instructed him to go?

[38] See Acts 18:5,25; I Cor. 5:3; II Cor. 2:13, all of which, like 19:21, contain the definite article in the original.

This is not to deny, of course, that the term "in the spirit" indicates that it was the highest part of Paul's being that moved him to go.[39]

In Acts 20:22 the apostle says of himself: *"And now, behold, I go bound in the spirit unto Jerusalem," i.e., he felt himself bound to go.* That his own spirit is referred to here is evident from the fact that he then proceeds to say that "the Holy Ghost [Gr., *the Spirit, the Holy*] witnesses in every city that bonds and afflictions await him (Ver. 23).

The *King James Version* and, indeed, most translations render the word "spirit" with a small "s" in both Acts 19:21 and 20:22 as the natural meaning of the original, and this rendering is confirmed by the fact that unquestionably *the Holy Spirit* is referred to in all three of the warnings and exhortations *not* to go to Jerusalem.

We have seen above that Paul himself declared that "the Holy Spirit" had warned him of the results if he went to Jerusalem at this time. And to this statement we must add Acts 21:4, where the disciples at Tyre "said to Paul *through the Spirit,* that he should not go up to Jerusalem" and Acts 21:10, 11, where "Agabus . . . took Paul's girdle, and bound his own hands and feet, and said, *Thus saith the Holy Ghost,* So shall the Jews at Jerusalem bind the man that owneth this girdle, and shall deliver him into the hands of the Gentiles."

Here K.J.V. and most other translations employ the capital "S" and rightly so, for in these two passages the references are clearly to the Holy Spirit.

Thus there can be no question that Luke and Paul's other companions, as well as "they of that place," viewed Agabus' prophecy as a warning from God as to what would befall Paul if he persisted in his purpose to go to Jerusalem, for they *all* besought him, *with tears, "not* to go up to Jerusalem" and it was only when *"he would not be persuaded"* that they said, *""The will of the Lord* [i.e., His *permissive* will] *be done"* (Acts 21:12-14).

THE SOLUTION

In the light of all the principal Scriptures, then, which bear on the question of God's will in Paul's going or not going to Jerusalem at this time, we are in a better position to find the solution to this problem.

First, there is *no indication* in the record that Paul was in the *directive* will of God in taking this last journey to Jerusalem, yet it is evident also that he was not *consciously out of God's will* in going; indeed, he felt himself bound by the highest part of his nature to go.

[39] But even the believer's *spirit* may err, as I Thes. 5:23 clearly implies.

Paul had three stated reasons for going to Jerusalem at this time: (1) *"to minister unto the saints"* (Rom. 15:25), (2) *"to worship"* (Acts 20:16; 24:11) and (3) *"to testify the gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24). The first two were to foster better relations between the Jewish believers and the Gentile churches and to assure both believers and unbelievers at Jerusalem that he did not despise the Law of Moses. The third reason, however, was the most important.

We view the whole scene as follows:

Upon his first visit to Jerusalem after his conversion, the Lord had distinctly commanded him:

"Make haste, and get thee quickly out of *Jerusalem for they will not receive thy testimony concerning Me"* (Acts 22:18).

At that time Paul had even debated the question with the Lord. These people, he argued, knew how he had led them in the persecution against Christ; how he had imprisoned and had beaten in every synagogue those who believed on Christ, and had consented and helped in the stoning of Stephen. Surely they would listen to *him,* and his testimony might well turn them from their enmity to trust in Christ. But the Lord knew better, and replied summarily:

"Deport: for I will send thee far hence unto the Gentiles" (Acts 22:21).

Yet, though sent to the Gentiles with glorious news, the apostle's heart kept bleeding for his beloved people, whom he had led in rebellion against Christ. He writes of this with great feeling. In Rom. 9:1-3 he writes of his *"great heaviness and continual sorrow"* over their condition, and solemnly swears before God that if it were possible he could wish *himself* accursed for them. Further, in Rom. 10:1 he says fervently that his *"heart's desire and prayer to God for Israel is, that they might be saved."*

Not only did Paul pity his headstrong kinsmen; he felt *responsible* for having led them, only a few years back, in their opposition to Christ. Also, he felt responsible to *the Lord* for having stirred up all this hatred against Him.

Thus it was that even though the Holy Spirit bore witness in every city that bonds and afflictions awaited him if he went to Jerusalem, he still felt *"bound in the spirit"* to go. Indeed, he felt he *must* go to finish his appointed course and ministry.[40]

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[40] A footnote in the *Scofield Reference Bible* (P. 1178) suggests that Paul had the "law-bound Jewish *believers"* in mind when he spoke of "testifying the gospel of the grace of God." This seems improbable, however, since he had already "communicated" his message to the believers at Jerusalem (Gal. 2:7-9) and had even "disputed" with them about it, so that a testimony to *them* about the gospel of grace would not be required to finish his course. It was the Jewish multitude and their leaders to whom he had not yet been able to give this testimony (Cf. Acts 22:19,20).

The declaration of the disciples at Tyre is, of course, the strongest argument of those who contend that Paul was wholly wrong and out of the will of God in going. These disciples evidently had the gift of prophecy. They "said to Paul *through the Spirit,* that he should *not* go up to Jerusalem" (Acts 21:4).

It should be noted that the Greek for *"not"* here, however, is not the Greek *ou,* but *me.* It is *subjective* rather than *objective,* dealing with thoughts and feelings rather than with facts, as *ou* does. While *ou denies or forbids a thing directly and absolutely, me* does so according to judgment or desire. Thus the Greek here does not indicate a direct prohibition, but rather a *warning* and a *plea.*

These Tyrean disciples, however, were not merely concerned about Paul's welfare; it was "through the Spirit" that they said he should not go up to Jerusalem. Whether Acts 21:4 refers to *one* prophetic statement, or to their pleas during the seven-day visit is not certain.

The greatest test, probably, came when at Caesarea the prophet Agabus,[41] in a dramatic and impressive warning, predicted the apostle's arrest and imprisonment in Jerusalem, causing both his companions in travel and his Caesarean friends to beseech him, weeping, not to persist in his purpose (Acts 21:10-12).

To argue that the above incidents were only meant by the Holy Spirit as a challenge to Paul to summon the courage to go to Jerusalem is surely contrary to what these passages so plainly say. But human nature is complex, and it is evident that *he* did not consider them as *condemning* his action, but rather as tests of his faithfulness (Acts 21:13; cf. 20:24).

Thus while Paul was not divinely *directed* to go to Jerusalem on this occasion, as he had been on at least one other (Gal. 2:2), and indeed was warned of bonds and afflictions if he went, he still did so out of a sense of faithfulness to his Lord, and - this is important - God *used it to give Israel one more impassioned plea from the lips of one who had been warned not to go to them, who had been told that they would not listen; who stood before them now in chains, relating the story of his conversion, if, perchance, it might lead to theirs.*

After this the apostle was taken to Rome in chains to become "the prisoner of Jesus Christ for [the] Gentiles" (Eph. 3:1). We repeat that the passages which state this do not say that he was a prisoner *for* Christ (though this also is true). It does not say that he was a prisoner of the Jews or of the Romans. It says he was *"the prisoner OF Jesus Christ FOR [the] Gentiles."* I.e., Jesus Christ was holding him in prison for the sake of the Gentiles, not as punishment, of course, but because his heart kept turning back to his kinsmen according to the flesh, to those for whose apostasy he held himself so largely responsible.

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[41] Already known as a true prophet (Acts 11:27,28).

(Parts of the foregoing section are taken basically from the author's book, *Acts Dispensationally Considered,* Vol. III, pp. 230-241.)

PAUL'S MINISTRY AS A PRISONER

It is touching to note that the record from here on contains not a single hint of any rebellion on Paul's part, or of his chafing at God's dealings with him.

On the contrary, before the Jewish multitude and the Sanhedrin, both of whom interrupted his speeches because of *their* ill temper, he maintained his equilibrium and behaved himself as a true and great man of God.

Agabus' prophecy was already being fulfilled, not that the Jews themselves bound Paul, but, as in the case of his Lord, they *caused* him to be bound "with two chains" (Acts 21:33). Indeed, it was the Jews who now kept insisting, not merely on his imprisonment, but on his execution as a criminal deserving death. "More than forty" of them "bound themselves with a curse," vowing "that they would neither eat nor drink until they had killed Paul" (23:12,13). This, however, resulted in his being sent to Caesarea under heavy guard for a hearing before the governor Felix.

But the high priest, Ananias, lost no time pursuing the man who had called him a "whited wall," for it was only five days after Paul's departure from Jerusalem that he, and the Jewish elders, with an "orator" named Tertullus, travelled the seventy miles to Caesarea to prosecute the apostle (24:1). Their charges, however, did not result in Paul's immediate sentencing. Rather he was left at Caesarea, under *military custody*[42] for two years (Acts 24:27).

Felix had been hoping that Paul, who had come to Jerusalem with large sums of money, might offer him a bribe, *"wherefore he sent for him the oftener, and communed with him"* (Acts 24:26). But no bribe was forthcoming, and the record informs us that,

". . . after two years Porcius Festus came into Felix' room: and Felix,[43] willing to do the Jews a pleasure, left Paul bound" (Ver. 27).

But Festus too was *"willing to do the Jews a pleasure,"* suggesting to Paul that perhaps he should go back to Jerusalem for a further hearing. This is when Paul, claiming his rights as a Roman citizen, appealed to Caesar (Acts 25:9-12).

Thus Israel is left farther and farther behind in the apostle's ministry, and he emerges ever more prominently as *"the apostle of the Gentiles."*

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[42] See the author's *Acts Dispensationally Considered,* Vol. IV, P. 100, on the subject of *military custody.*

[43] Note: *Felix,* not Festus. He had evidently had no intention of calling for Lysius, the Roman chief captain, to give his testimony, as he had intimated (Ver. 22).

It was during the few days while Paul was waiting to be taken to Caesar at Rome, that King Herod Agrippa II, Festus' superior, appeared on the scene and expressed a desire to hear Paul himself. It is at this hearing that Paul's grateful, happy frame of mind shines forth most brightly.

Festus' opening words, *"Ye see this man,"* lends pathos to the scene. There stands the great apostle, evidently a man of some means at this time,[44] and certainly one who should have been lavished with high honors rather than accused of crimes. There he stands, a prisoner in chains, before all these dignitaries: Agrippa and Bernice, Festus, the governor, the chief captains, and principal men of the city, the High Priest, Tertullus, and the elders of the Jews (24:1; 25:23, 24).

From the above, and Paul's words in 26:29, it appears that the courtroom was crowded with interested listeners in addition to the leading figures just mentioned.

Twice Paul's defense was interrupted: first by Festus who, evidently greatly agitated, said with "a loud voice":

"Paul, thou art beside thyself; much learning doth make thee mad" (26:24).

At this Paul, under complete control, courteously replied:

"I am not mad, most noble Festus, but speak forth the words of truth and soberness" (Ver. 25).

He understood that Festus was probably trying to cover up his feelings of conviction with this outburst. Thus, referring himself immediately back to the king, he explains to Festus that King Agrippa knows all about these things; that he can speak freely before him, and that he is convinced that the details of his account have not been hid from him, since they were not "done in a comer."

The apostle knew that Agrippa had not only been brought up in the Jewish religion, but that he had long been intimately associated with Israel politically.

And now he does something more likely to convince Festus than any argument in his own defense. Turning to address Agrippa personally, he asks: "King Agrippa believest thou the prophets?" and then immediately adds: *"I know that thou believest"* (Ver. 27). In declining to wait for Agrippa's answer to his question the apostle again did what was both proper and wise. *Paul,* not Agrippa, was on trial, and to put the king in an embarrassing position would only have enraged him. Thus, with superb tact the apostle *indirectly* appeals to Agrippa himself, using *him* as his witness, and at the same time driving home the *truth* of his argument. This was what brought about the second interruption - by Agrippa - as he says to Paul:

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[44] See *Acts Dispensationally Considered,* Vol. IV, pp. 107, 108.

"Almost thou persuadest me to be a Christian"[45] (Ver. 28).

Whatever the degree of Agrippa's sincerity in this matter; whether he too sought to cover up the depths of his feelings by speaking facetiously, or whether he indeed meant to express his true conviction, Paul was quick to take advantage of the situation. Revealing the burden of his heart, not only for Agrippa, but for Festus and *all* those present, he replied, with great feeling:

"I would to God, that not only thou, but also all that hear me this day, were both almost and altogether such as I am, except these bonds" (Ver. 29).

Does this sound like the words of one who was unhappy over God's dealings with him? What a truly great servant of God the apostle was! How deeply in earnest: "*I would to God."* How large-hearted: *"not only thou, but also all that hear me this day."* How selfless: *He* stands there in chains, but longs for *their* salvation. How gloriously triumphant: *"I wish that you - all of you - could be as I am."* How powerful his plea: "Almost" is not enough. It *must* be *"altogether."*

And the most exquisite touch of Christian courtesy and grace is found in his words: *"except these bonds."* He had suffered much for Christ, but he did not say, "I wish *you* could feel the weight of these bonds." He wished none of *that* for them. He wished only that they might experience the peace and assurance and joy that filled his heart. We fancy that he may have added this last phrase with a twinkle in his eyes, too, for it indicated that he *was* sane!

ISRAEL'S REJECTION OF CHRIST CONFIRMED

On arriving at Rome, "the centurian delivered the prisoners to the captain of the guard: *but Paul was suffered to dwell by himself with a soldier that kept him"* (Acts 28:16). Thus, for *"two whole years"* he dwelt in *"his own hired house [always guarded by a soldier], and received all that came unto him"* (Ver. 30).

But he himself invited the first company of visitors. Calling "the chief of the Jews" together they agreed on a date when they could discuss more fully his situation and his message. We read that "there came many" to this discussion and that the apostle "testified" and "persuaded" them concerning Jesus "from morning till evening" (Ver. 23).

It was at this time that it was made clearest of all - to Paul - that Israel and her kingdom hopes had, for the time, been set aside. He had by now travelled all the way from Jerusalem to Rome, consistently going "to the Jew first," but invariably with the same results.

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[45] We reject the arguments of those who would change this sentence, which KJV has here so beautifully expressed, to make it mean something quite different.

It should be noted that in each of the crises in which Paul turned from the Jew to the Gentile, it was made clear that *the Jew himself was to blame* since he had refused to accept Messiah and the fulfillment of the promises.

At Jerusalem the Lord Himself had appeared to Paul, saying:

"Get thee quickly out of Jerusalem, for *they will not receive thy testimony concerning Me"* (Acts 22:18).

At Pisidian Antioch the apostle had said to the Jews with regard to God's Word to them:

"Ye put it from you, and *judge yourselves unworthy* of ever*lasting life"* (Acts 13:46).

At Corinth, after they had set themselves in opposition and had blasphemed:

"Your blood be upon your own heads; I am clean" (Acts 18:6).

And now *at Rome* it is the same, only his response is strongest and most final. "When they agreed not among themselves, they departed,"[46] but ere they had actually left Paul pronounced upon them this stern indictment:

"Well spake the Holy Ghost by Esaias the prophet unto our fathers,

"Saying, Go unto this people and say, Hearing ye shall hear, and shall not understand; and seeing ye shall see, and not perceive;

"For the heart of this people is waxed gross, and their ears are dull of hearing, and their eyes have they closed; lest they should see with their eyes, and hear with their ears, and understand with their heart, and should be converted, and I should heal them.

"Be it known therefore unto you, that the salvation of God is[47] *sent unto the Gentiles, and that they will hear it"* (Acts 28:25-28).

All along the way God had shown the apostle that the nation had been set aside, but now after all this evidence, and with patience almost exhausted by his long contest with prejudice and unbelief, what further doubt could there be?

His own call as an apostle after the stoning of Stephen could only speak of the ushering in of a new dispensation. Our Lord *had* twelve apostles to reign with Him over the twelve tribes of Israel.

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[46] "Began to depart," the imperfect tense is used.
[47] *"has been,"* past perfect, as in Ver. 27, *"has become."*

Then, as we have seen, upon his return to Jerusalem after his conversion the Lord emphatically declared to him: *"They will not receive thy testimony concerning Me."*

Later, to the Thessalonians, where Jewish opposition was so intense, the apostle himself had written, *"the wrath is* come *upon them unto the uttermost"* (I Thes. 2:15,16).

And now, with all this supernatural testimony, with all this evidence of Israel's attitude all the way from Jerusalem to Rome, how could he but settle the question in his own mind, even though his heart must still have gone out to his rebellious kinsmen. Now, in the most decisive way, he will be *"the apostle of the Gentiles."* It had been easy to write this *to the Romans,* but harder to accept it as final where the welfare of his own kinsmen was concerned.

It is a pity that some, reading how in his own hired house at Rome the apostle "preached the kingdom of God," have interpreted this to mean that he proclaimed the "gospel" of the kingdom or its earthly establishment. How wrong! Naturally he would tell them what had *become* of the kingdom. He would explain to them how the earthly establishment of this kingdom, proclaimed by John the Baptist, Christ and the twelve, was now being held in abeyance. He would tell them how the people of Israel had rejected the King and His kingdom and how the kingdom was *now vested in Christ in heaven* - for He *is* the rightful King (See Col 1:13).

THE PRISON EPISTLES

Later on, in a dungeon in Nero's palace the apostle had greater reason than ever to accept his imprisonment as God's gracious will for him - and for the Gentiles. To the Philippian believers, he writes:

". . . I would ye should understand, brethren, *that the things which happened unto me have fallen out rather unto the furtherance of the gospel;*

"So that my bonds in Christ are manifest in all the palace, and in all other places" (Phil. 1:12, 13).

So happy is he in the Lord that he is full of encouragement for the Philippian saints. Listen to this Roman prisoner:

"For our conversation [or citizenship] is in heaven; from whence also we look for the Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ;

"Who shall change our vile body, that it may be fashioned like unto His glorious body, according to the working whereby He is able even to subdue all things unto Himself" (Phil. 3:20, 21).

"Rejoice in the Lord alway; and again I say, Rejoice" (4:4).

"*Be careful ["care-full"] for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known unto God.*

"And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus" (4:6, 7).

There's a happy prisoner for you! Perhaps most of all because he clearly understands *why* he is thus detained.

Five times in these epistles he calls himself *"the prisoner of Jesus Christ,"* and in Eph. 3:1-8 he calls himself "the prisoner of Jesus Christ *for you Gentiles," and goes into detail to explain why.*

No longer could he travel[48] among the churches, or go out to establish new ones, but look at the enduring testimonies which have issued from that prison. Discouraged? Far from it! This inhabitant of a cruel, vile Roman prison, writes about sitting *"in heavenly places in Christ"* (Eph. 2:4-7). He breaks out in a doxology to God, *"who hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ"* (1:3). He declares that it is God's purpose,

"That in the ages to come He might show the exceeding riches of His grace in *His kindness toward us through Christ Jesus*" (2:7).

How great is the redeeming power of Christ! What a change it has wrought in the man who once "breathed out threatenings and slaughter against the disciples of the Lord"! Now he is breathing out doxologies of praise and joy, even as he sits in prison.

And we, who have come to know something of the "mystery" that Paul lived and died to make known, will forever keep finding new precious gems of blessing in the writings of *"the prisoner of Jesus Christ for [the] Gentiles."*

[48] Except perhaps later during the period between his earlier and later imprisonments.

Chapter XIV

PAUL AND HIS PREDECESSORS

A STUDY OF THE BROADER ASPECTS OF HIS MESSAGE AND MINISTRY

To the unbiased believer of the Word of God there is overwhelming proof that the secret of God's eternal purpose and grace was first communicated by revelation to the Apostle Paul, that he in turn might make it known to others.

Not only does Paul himself *declare* this *by divine inspiration,* but his declarations are amply confirmed by a comparison of his message and ministry with the messages and ministries of all his predecessors.

But while *particular distinctions* have often been noted in this connection, we feel that too little attention has been given to the *broader* aspects of his message and ministry as compared with those of his predecessors. Those great, grand truths which he was commissioned to unfold were the *constant* subject of his discourse and his letters, and his life and conduct harmonized perfectly with these truths and with the dispensation he ushered in.

THE DISPENSATION OF GRACE

Let us begin with the dispensation, or the dispensing of *grace.*

We are sometimes asked: "Did not others before Paul speak of grace?"

Yes, others before Paul did *speak* of grace, but before we assume too much from this let us consider a few basic facts:

It is not merely Paul, but the inspired Word that declares that *"the dispensation of the grace of God"* was committed to him (Eph. 3:2) and that it was *his "ministry. . . received of the Lord Jesus"* to make known *"the gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24). THIS CLAIM WAS MADE BY, OR FOR, NONE OF HIS PREDECESSORS, nor did any of them even mention the dispensation or the gospel of the grace of God so far as the record is concerned.

To the believer this evidence should be conclusive. Paul was God's chosen vessel, raised up especially to proclaim the message and program of grace.

But to those who hesitate to accept these inspired statements at their face value we have further important evidence to offer in the fact that NO OTHER BIBLE WRITERS - NOT EVEN ALL THE OTHERS PUT TOGETHER - HAVE SO

MUCH TO SAY ABOUT GRACE.

The Hebrew equivalent of Paul's word for grace is found only 68 times in *the whole Old Testament* (which is nearly *twelve times* the size of Paul's epistles including Hebrews) and then not always relating to *God's* grace and *never* to *"the dispensation of grace."*

In the "Four Gospels" (nearly *twice* the size of Paul's epistles) the word grace (Gr., *charis)*, with its derivatives, appears in the original only 13 times (much less often in the English KJV) and then rarely in even a doctrinal, much less a dispensational connection.

By comparison, the epistles of Paul, only about one twelfth the size of the Old Testament and one half the size of the "Four Gospels," employs the word *grace* and its derivatives no less than 144 times, *more often than all the rest of the Bible together, more than twice as often as the whole Old Testament* (12 times its size), and *about 11 times as often as the "Four Gospels,"* (twice its size). Moreover, in Paul's epistles the word *grace is nearly always* used doctrinally, in connection with "the dispensation of the grace of God."

Every epistle signed by Paul's name opens with a proclamation of *"grace and peace from God our Father and from the Lord Jesus Christ."* In his epistles we find that we are *"justified freely by [God's] grace"* (Rom. 3:24), that *"where sin abounded grace did much more abound"* (Rom. 5:20), *that "grace might reign"* (Rom. 5:21). There we read that we are *"not under the law, but under grace"* (Rom. 6:14), that *"God is able to make all grace abound"* toward us that we may *"abound unto every good work"* (II Cor. 9:8), that it is God's purpose for "the ages to come" to *"show the exceeding riches of His grace in His kindness toward us through Christ Jesus"* (Eph. 2:7). And we could go on and on, adding up the evidence that *"the dispensation of the grace of God"* was indeed committed particularly to Paul to make known to us.

An examination of the book of Acts reveals a similar comparison. There the word *grace* is found, in the original, four times *before* the raising up of Paul, and twelve times *after.* Before the raising up of Paul it is *not used once* of the dispensation of grace or of salvation by grace, but in later Acts, after his conversion, not only is the *word* used more often, but immediately it appears in connection with the *dispensation* of grace.

When Barnabas *"had seen the grace of God"* in saving Gentiles at Syrian Antioch, he "was glad" (Acts 11:23). When Jews and religious proselytes at Pisidian Antioch received Paul's proclamation of salvation through Christ without the Law, he and Barnabas "persuaded them to *continue in the grace of God"* (13:38,39,43). At Iconium Paul and Barnabas gave bold testimony to *"the word of His grace"* (14:3). Later Peter confirmed Paul's message, publicly declaring his conviction: *"We believe that through the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ we [Jews]*

shall be saved even as they [the Gentiles]" (15:11). At Ephesus Apollos proved helpful to *"them. . . which had believed through grace"* (18:27). On his way to Jerusalem Paul declared his determination to fulfil his Christ-given commission, *"to testify the gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24), and then commended the Ephesian elders to *"the word of [God's] grace"* (20:32).

THE PREACHING OF THE CROSS

Let us next consider Paul's presentation of the death of the Lord Jesus Christ.

It was again by *divine revelation* that the Apostle claimed that his was *"the preaching of the cross,"* i.e., as good news, and that the *theme* of his message was "Christ crucified" (I Cor. 1:18,23). THIS CLAIM WAS MADE BY NONE OF HIS PREDECESSORS. Furthermore, this claim also is amply confirmed by a comparison of his writings with those of his predecessors."

In the Old Testament Scriptures the predictions of our Lord's death, from Gen. 3:15 on, are purposely veiled in obscurity and we are explicitly told that while the prophets themselves *"searched diligently,"* they *did not find out* either *"what manner of time,"* or even *"what"* the Spirit "did signify, when He testified beforehand the sufferings of Christ, and the glory that should follow" (I Pet. 1:10-12).

It is the same with the Old Testament *types* of our Lord's death. We can *now* look back at them and exclaim *"God had this in mind all the while!"* but we are not told of *one single instance* where those of *that day* were informed, or understood, that the death of Christ was being prefigured.

Then, when our Lord appeared on earth He did not even *begin* to tell His apostles that He must suffer and die until near the close of His ministry (Matt. 16:21; Mark 8:31; Luke 9:22), and then we read:

"Then Peter took Him and began to rebuke Him, saying, Be it far from Thee, Lord: This shall not be unto Thee" (Matt. 16:22).

So ignorant were our Lord's own apostles of even the *prophesied fact* of His death (let alone its *significance)* that later, in the very shadow of the cross, when He told them *again* how He must suffer and die and rise again, they were still nonplused.

"And they understood none of *these things, and this saying was hid from them, neither knew they the things which were spoken"* (Luke 18:34).

In fact, even at Pentecost, when the death of Christ had become a historical fact, its full accomplishments were not yet understood.

In the early chapters of Acts we do not yet find the death of the cross proclaimed for salvation. It is rather spoken of as a matter of shame to be repented of. Peter does not offer his hearers Christ's shed blood for the remission of sins. He *charges* them with the shedding of that blood and demands repentance and baptism for the remission of sins.

But with the raising up of Paul all this is changed. The crucifixion takes on a new, wonderful significance. The cross, the blood, the death of Christ become the very *theme* of his message. He constantly speaks of them, not in hidden meanings, but in open declaration, *as good news,* as that around which God's eternal purpose revolves and from which all our blessings flow.

NO OTHER BIBLE WRITER HAS SO MUCH TO SAY ABOUT THE DEATH OF CHRIST.

By the inspiration of the Spirit the Apostle tells us that:

When we were yet *without strength,* in due time Christ died for the ungodly (Rom. 5:6).

While we were yet *sinners* Christ died for us (Rom. 5:8).

When we were *enemies,* we were reconciled to God by the death of His Son (Rom. 5:10).

We are saved through *faith in* His blood (Rom. 3:25).

We have *redemption* through His blood (Eph. 1:7).

We are *justified* by His blood (Rom. 5:9).

We are *reconciled* to God in the body of His flesh, through death (Col. 1:21,22).

We have *peace* through the blood of His cross (Col. 1:20).

We *are made nigh* by the blood of Christ (Eph. 2:13).

We are *baptized into* His death (Rom. 6:3).

We are joined into *one body* by the cross (Eph. 2:16).

The Covenant of the Law was nailed to the cross (Col. 2:14).

Through death our Lord *destroyed him that had the power of death* (Heb. 2:14).

He died that they which live *should no longer live unto themselves, but unto Him*

who died for them and rose again (II Cor. 5:15).

He died *that whether we wake or sleep, we should live together with Him* (I Thes. 5:10).

Christ crucified is *the power of God and the wisdom of God* (I Cor. 1:23,24).

We are to *boast* in the cross alone (Gal. 6:14).

We are to *show forth the Lord's death* [at His table] *till He come* (I Cor. 11:26).

In view of the *above - and much more* - little wonder that Paul's message is called *"the preaching of the cross."*

THE BELIEVER'S WALK

Again, with regard to the broad subject of the believer's spiritual life and conduct: NO OTHER BIBLE WRITER DEVOTES SO LARGE A PROPORTION OF HIS TEACHINGS TO THE SUBJECT OF THE BELIEVER'S WALK.

Moses had much to say about loving God and obeying His commands, but it became evident that the Mosaic Law would not produce results, as God pronounced it "old"[49] and promised to make a new covenant with His people, under which He would so work within them that they would spontaneously do His will (Jer. 31:31-34; Ezek. 36:26, 27; note the word *"cause").*

At Pentecost there was a foretaste of this kingdom blessing as the Holy Spirit caused Christ's disciples to prophesy and also *caused* them to do His will, according to His promise.

Hence in the early chapters of Acts we find the apostles and disciples neither committing sins nor making blunders. They were *all FILLED* with the Spirit (Acts 2:4), *completely* under His control.

Thus God demonstrated the fact that the only way in which even His own can perfectly obey Him is when He *takes possession* of them and *causes* them to do His will.

As we know, however, Israel rejected the King and His kingdom and *that* operation of the Holy Spirit ceased. Today He no longer takes possession of men, supernaturally causing them either to prophesy and speak with tongues or to do His will.

But in God's grace Paul was raised up to show how even in "this present evil age" we may have spiritual victory *by grace through faith,* for while the Spirit does

[49] "In that He saith, A *new* covenant, He hath made the first old" (Heb. 8:13).

not *cause* us to do God's will automatically, He does dwell within, always ready to help, and what is thus provided by grace we may appropriate by faith. *What a challenge!*[50]

This is why the Apostle Paul has so much to say about the operation of the Spirit *now* and about our spiritual life and conduct *now* in this age of Christ's rejection. This is why the doctrines in each of his great epistles to the churches are followed by practical applications to our behavior in "this present evil age."

What a volume of Paul's writings we could cite in support of these facts! The following are but a few representative passages:

". . . *Reckon ye* also yourselves to be *dead indeed* unto *sin, but alive* unto *God through* Jesus *Christ* our *Lord.*

"Let not sin therefore reign in your *mortal body,* that ye should obey it in the lusts thereof.

"Neither yield ye your members as *instruments* of unrighteousness unto *sin,* but *yield yourselves* unto *God* as those that are alive from the dead, and *your members as instruments of righteousness unto God.*

"For sin shall not have dominion over you, for ye are not under the law, but under grace" (Rom. 6:11-14).

"The law of *the Spirit,* [that] of life in Christ Jesus, *hath made me free from the law of sin and death*" (Rom. 8:2).

"But if the Spirit of Him that raised up Jesus from the dead dwell in *you, He that raised up Christ from the dead shall also quicken your mortal bodies by His Spirit that dwelleth in you.*

"Therefore, brethren, we are debtors, not to the flesh, to live after the flesh" (Rom. 8: 11, 12).

“What? know *ye* not that *your body is the temple of the Holy Spirit,* which is in you, which ye have of God, and ye are not your own?

"For *ye are bought with a price: therefore glorify God in your body and in your spirit, which are God's*" (I Cor. 6:19, 20).

"I therefore, the prisoner of the Lord, beseech you that *ye walk worthy of the vocation wherewith ye are called,*

"With all lowliness and meekness, with longsuffering, forbearing one another in

[50] For a fuller discussion of this subject see the author's book, *True Spirituality,* pp. 87-99.

love;

"Endeavoring to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace" (Eph. 4:1-3).

To all this much more could be added *to* show how no one until Paul proclaimed the truths of the believer's practical sanctification through believing appropriation of the Holy Spirit's operation in his life, as did Paul. How all this cumulative evidence marks Paul as the one specially raised up of God *to* make known the particular truths for the present dispensation!

But there is still more evidence of another kind.

PAUL'S OATHS

How often the Apostle speaks with an oath!

"God is my witness" (Rom. 1:9).

"I say the truth in Christ; I lie not" (Rom. 9:1).

"As God is true..." (II Cor. 1:18).

"I call God for a record upon my soul" (II Cor. 1 :23).

"As the truth of Christ is in me. . ." (II Cor. 11:10).

"The God and Father of our lord Jesus Christ, which is blessed for evermore knoweth that I lie not" (II Cor. 11:31).

"Behold, before God, I lie not" (Gal. 1:20).

"God is my record" (Phil. 1:8).

"I speak the truth in Christ and lie not" (I Tim. 2:7).

"I charge thee before God, and the lord Jesus Christ" (I Tim. 5:21).

"I give thee charge in the sight of God" (I Tim. 6: 13).

"I charge thee therefore before God, and the Lord Jesus Christ" (II Tim. 4:1).

As Dean Howson says: "When [Paul] makes a solemn statement under the sense of God's presence, he does not hesitate to *express* this" *(Hulsean Lectures* for 1862, P. 160).[51]

[51] An important commentary on Matt. 5:33-37.

But had not others spoken under the sense of God's presence? Indeed Peter, by the Spirit, says, ”If *any man* speak, let him speak as the oracles of God" (I Pet. 4:11). Yet even a superficial reading of the Scriptures will reveal that PAUL CALLS GOD TO WITNESS FAR MORE OFTEN THAN ANY OTHER BIBLE WRITER and mostly with regard to *his personal integrity.* Why is this? Why did he ever *need* to speak with an oath?

The answer to this question is again to be found in the distinctive character of the Apostle's ministry as the revelator of the mystery.

John the Baptist did not need to speak with oaths for he proclaimed the kingdom which had already been predicted by all the Old Testament prophets. The four "evangelists" did not need to speak with oaths for they depicted our Lord as the prophesied Messiah. Peter at Pentecost could point out that *"this"* was *"that which was spoken by the prophet Joel"* (Acts 2:16); why would *he* need to swear that he was telling the truth? Moreover, both he and his associates were all evidently under the control of the Holy Spirit (Acts 2:4).

But with Paul it was a different matter. Separate from the twelve, who were widely known as the apostles of Christ, Paul had been raised up to make known a wonderful secret which God had kept hidden from all who had gone before. While in no way a *contradiction* of prophecy, this secret was nevertheless *not* to be found in the sayings or writings of any who had preceded him. Moreover, the revelation of "this mystery" brought with it a revolutionary change in message and program - a new dispensation. Hence it is appropriate that the Apostle should insist again and again that he writes as in the presence of God.

PAUL'S CONSCIENCE

On the same basis the Apostle was keenly aware of *conscience* and taught others to be so. Indeed, again PAUL HAS MORE TO SAY ABOUT CONSCIENCE THAN ANY OTHER BIBLE WRITER.

We have already seen how in Rom. 9:1 he swears by the name of Christ that he is not lying, but he adds:

". . . my conscience also bearing me witness in the Holy Ghost ."

In Acts 23:1 we find him "earnestly beholding the council," and saying:

"Men and brethren, *I have lived in all good conscience before God until this day*" (See also II Tim. 1:3).

He had even been conscientious (though conscien*tiously wrong)* in his persecution of Christ (Acts 26:9) and while it is clear that he was not *saved* by obedience to his conscience, this characteristic of his makeup became the more

strongly marked after his regeneration and enlightenment by the Holy Spirit.

To Felix he could say:

"Herein do I exercise myself, to have always a conscience void of offense toward God and toward men" (Acts 24:16).

And he proved this to Felix himself as he refused to yield to the temptation to seek freedom by giving him a bribe (Acts 24:26).

To the Corinthians he could write:

"For our rejoicing is this, *the testimony of our conscience,* that in simplicity and Godly sincerity, not with fleshly wisdom, but by the grace of God, we have had our conversation in the world, and more abundantly to you-ward" (II Cor. 1:12).

And this is representative of many similar passages.

Further he appeals to the consciences of *others:*

". . . not walking in craftiness, nor handling the Word of God deceitfully; but *by manifestation* of *the truth commend*ing *ourselves* to *every* man's *conscience* in *the sight* of *God"* (II Cor. 4:2).

Timothy was exhorted to keep faith *"and a good conscience"* (I Tim. 1:19), and was reminded that the deacons must hold "the mystery of the faith *in a pure conscience"* (I Tim. 3:9).

In dealing with the believers' relations with each other the Apostle beseeches them to be sensitive with regard, not only to their own, but to each other's consciences (I Cor. 8:7-12; 10:25-29).

It is important to note that the Apostle both showed and exhorted conscientiousness, especially where financial matters were concerned. Not only did he exhort others to *"provide things honest in the sight of all men"* (Rom. 12:17), but he himself practiced this. In connection with the large contributions being made by the Gentile churches to the saints at Jerusalem, he wrote to the Corinthians that along with Titus (sent to collect *their* contributions) he was sending another brother who was well known to all the churches and appointed *by them* to travel with him in taking the gift to Jerusalem;

"Avoiding this, that no man should blame us in this abundance which is administered by us:

"Providing for honest things, not only in the sight of the Lord, but also in the sight of men" (II Cor. 8:20, 21).

Indeed, he had already written them:

"And when I come, *whomsoever ye shall approve by your letters,* them will I send to bring your liberality unto Jerusalem.

"And if it be meet that I go also, they shall go with me" (I Cor. 16:3, 4).

Does not all this indicate that the kingdom program had been interrupted and the dispensation of grace ushered in?

There would have been no need for such precautions and exhortations, or even for such collections, had the Pentecostal program continued uninterrupted, for then,

". . . the multitude of them that believed were of one heart and of one soul: neither said any of them that aught of the things which he possessed was his own; but they had all things common. . . . Neither was there any among them that lacked. . ." (Acts 4:32-34).

Under such Spirit-controlled conditions it was superfluous to caution one to regard the conscience of another. *They all lived for each other.* Nor was it necessary to exhort them to mind their own consciences. *They were all filled with the Holy Spirit.* Indeed, two who sought to join the company by means that disregarded conscience were *stricken dead* (Acts 5:1-11). It would likewise have been superfluous to exhort Peter and his brethren to hold the truth in a pure conscience for, Spirit-filled, they spoke *"as the Spirit gave them utterance."*

But the supernatural manifestations of Pentecost have since passed away and we now live under the dispensation of *grace.* It is supremely appropriate, therefore, that our apostle has so much to say about *conscience,* urging us always to maintain personal integrity and to show due consideration for the spiritual welfare of others, thus bearing the *fruits* of grace.

PAUL'S SUFFERINGS

In conclusion let us consider one more feature in which Paul is to be distinguished from all his predecessors: *his sufferings.*

It is recognized that no merely human sufferings are to be compared with the sufferings of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. He bore judgment that would have sunk a world to hell. But among mortal men in God's service surely none have suffered more than Paul. As far as the record is concerned, PAUL SUFFERED MORE FOR CHRIST THAN DID ANY OF HIS PREDECESSORS.

We have at least one inspired intimation of this in the record of our Lord's own

words regarding Saul:

". . . I will show him how great things he must suffer for My name's sake" (Acts 9:16).

But again, this fact is more amply confirmed by a comparison of the record of Paul's sufferings with that of the sufferings of his predecessors.

How can we begin to cite all he went through from his escape over the Damascus wall (Acts 9:23-25) to those hours of waiting in the Roman prison for his execution as a criminal (II Tim. 4:6)? Suffice it to say that even by the time he had written two of his *earlier* epistles, those to the Corinthians, he had already surpassed others in the persecutions and sufferings he had borne for Christ. Writing to the Corinthians he says of himself and his associates:

". . . *we are made a spectacle unto the world. . . to angels, and to men.*

"We are fools for Christ's sake. . . we are weak. . . we are despised.

"Even unto this present hour we both hunger, and thirst, and are naked, and are buffeted, and have no certain dwelling place;

"And labor, working with our own hands: being reviled, we bless; being persecuted, we suffer it.

"Being defamed, we entreat: we are made as the filth of the world, and are the offscouring of all things unto this day" (I Cor. 4:9-13).

That this "we" refers mostly to himself is clear from the long, detailed list given us in the following letter (II Cor. 11:23.33) of all the sufferings he had personally endured up *to* that time. This list is al. ways read too hurriedly. A bit of meditation upon the details: the scourgings, the beatings, the stoning, the shipwrecks, the wearisome journeys, the perils from floods, robbers, Jews, Gentiles, the perils in the city, in the desert, in the sea, among false brethren, the fatigue, the pain, the watchings, the hunger, the cold, the nakedness, and then, *"the care of all the churches"* - a bit of meditation on each of these particular details in his life of persecution and suffering will soon explain why he cried out:

"Are *they* ministers *of* Christ (I speak as a fool), *I am more: in labors more abundant, in stripes above measure, in prisons more frequent, in deaths oft. . . . Who is weak, and I am not weak? Who is offended, and I bum not?"* (II Cor. 11:23-29).

This view would, of course, be one-sided, but to show the brighter side of the Apostle's sufferings we must first learn *why* he suffered all this.

It must be remembered that he had led Israel and the world in rebellion against the Son of God. As the flaming leader of this rebellion he had "made havock of the Church" (Acts 8:3), had "persecuted" it "beyond measure" and "laid it waste" (Gal. 1:13), until his hands dripped with the blood of martyrs.

In this he but represented the world's attitude toward Christ, but when the world was ripe for the prophesied judgment, the time of God's wrath, God graciously intervened, *saving,* rather than judging, Saul of Tarsus and sending him forth to offer reconciliation to His enemies by grace through faith.

In the nature of the case Saul, as an ambassador of grace among enemy aliens, would now have to bear the same sufferings which he had inflicted upon others. This constant suffering, however, was in a real sense "the sufferings of Christ," the continued consequence of the world's enmity against God and His Christ. This explains an otherwise difficult passage in his letter to the Colossians:

"[I] now rejoice in my sufferings for you, and *fill up that which is behind [which remains] of the afflictions of Christ in my flesh for His Body's sake, which is the Church"* (Col. 1:24).

Such sufferings are sweet! Little wonder the apostle rejoiced in them as they brought him into closest fellowship with the rejected Christ Himself. Little wonder it was his deep desire:

"That I may know Him, and the *power* of His resurrection, and *the fellowship of his sufferings,* being made conformable unto His death" (Phil. 3:10).

Thus even in his sufferings Paul stands out as the apostle of God's grace, chosen to proclaim the love of the rejected Christ to a doomed world.

It is only as we recognize these Scriptural distinctions between Paul and all his predecessors that we will be enabled to proclaim the gospel of the grace of God with clarity and power, and the only way we can become workmen whom *He* can approve (II Tim. 2:15).

Chapter XV

A RECAPITULATION OF PAUL'S OWN WORDS ON THE SUBJECT

The Scriptures teach *as a fact,* beyond the shadow of a doubt, that Paul's apostleship and message were absolutely unique and separate from that of the twelve or of any who had preceded him. This is what Christendom as a whole has refused to accept, thus confusing God's prophesied kingdom program with that committed to Paul for us in this present dispensation.

In this chapter we present a recapitulation of Paul's own words on the subject, and since he writes by the inspiration of the Holy Spirit, they are also *the Word of God* on the subject, not to be taken, or dealt with, lightly.

The following Scripture passages emphasize not only the apostle's repeated use of the first person pronoun, "I," "me," "my," - many more of these could be cited - but the *unique character* of his apostleship and message. Ignore this fact and confusion must inevitably result; accept it and a hundred seeming contradictions in Scripture disappear.

"PAUL, AN APOSTLE (NOT OF MEN, NEITHER BY MAN, BUT BY JESUS CHRIST, AND GOD THE FATHER, WHO RAISED HIM FROM THE DEAD)" (Gal. 1:1).

Matthias, too, could have claimed that his apostleship was "not *of* men," but unlike Paul's, it *was "by man"* (i.e., by human instrumentality), for God used men to appoint him an apostle (Acts 1:15-26). But Paul's apostleship was entirely unique. It neither originated with men, nor was he chosen by human instrumentality.

". . . I CERTIFY YOU, BRETHREN, THAT THE GOSPEL WHICH WAS PREACHED OF ME IS NOT AFTER MAN,

"FOR I NEITHER RECEIVED IT OF MEN, NEITHER WAS I TAUGHT IT, BUT BY THE REVELATION OF JESUS CHRIST" (Gal. 1:11,12).

Note carefully: Paul did not learn the truths he preached from others. He received them by direct revelation from the Lord Jesus Christ.

". . . I went up *by revelation* and communicated unto them THAT GOSPEL WHICH I PREACH AMONG THE GENTILES, but privately to them which were of reputation, lest by any means I should run, or had run, in vain" (Gal. 2:2).

Paul did not go to Jerusalem to make sure he was preaching the same message as the twelve. On the contrary, he was *sent* there *"by revelation"* to make known to", the leaders there "*that gospel"* which he preached *among the Gentiles.* Why this phraseology if his message was the same as theirs, and why the need to first deal *privately* with the leaders?

". . . they who seemed to be somewhat, in conference added nothing to me:

"But contrariwise. . . THEY SAW THAT THE GOSPEL OF THE UNCIRCUMCISION WAS COMMITTED UNTO ME, AS THE GOSPEL OF THE CIRCUMCISION WAS UNTO PETER" (Gal. 2:6, 7).

The leaders at Jerusalem "added nothing" to Paul. He understood the prophetic program fully as well as they. *"But contrariwise,"* he added something to them: *"that gospel"* which he preached *"among the Gentiles,"* a further step in the program of God. Further: we may at least understand how some may *confuse* "the gospel of the kingdom" with "the gospel of the grace of God," but surely *"the gospel of the circumcision"* and *""the gospel of the UNcircumcision"* cannot be one and the same.

"AND WHEN JAMES, CEPHAS [PETER] AND JOHN, WHO SEEMED TO BE PILLARS, PERCEIVED THE GRACE THAT WAS GIVEN UNTO ME, THEY GAVE TO ME AND BARNABAS THE RIGHT HANDS OF FELLOWSHIP, THAT WE SHOULD GO TO THE HEATHEN GENTILES AND THEY UNTO THE CIRCUMCISION ISRAEL" (Gal. 2:9).

As Paul communicated his gospel to the leaders at Jerusalem, *""they saw"* (Gal. 2:7), and *"perceived"* (Ver. 9), the validity of his claims and *publicly, officially* acknowledged Paul (with his co-workers) as God's appointed apostle to the Gentiles, agreeing henceforth to confine their own ministry to Israel. Thus the twelve, who had at first been commissioned to go to "all nations" (Matt. 28:19), now acknowledged Paul as God's apostle to the Gentiles and agreed to resume their ministry to Israel.

". . . I have written the more boldly unto you in some sort [in a sense], as putting you in mind, because of THE GRACE THAT IS GIVEN TO ME OF GOD,

"THAT I SHOULD BE THE MINISTER OF JESUS CHRIST TO THE GENTILES. . . " (Rom. 15:15, 16).

How could he state more clearly that by the grace of God *he* was now "the minister of Jesus Christ to the Gentiles"?

"FOR I SPEAK TO YOU GENTILES, INASMUCH AS I AM THE APOSTLE OF THE GENTILES: I MAGNIFY MINE OFFICE" (Rom. 11:13).

It was not from pride, but by divine inspiration, that Paul *magnified* - not himself, but - his office. Is it not a sin, then, to *minimize* what God has magnified?

"For there is one God, and one Mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus:

"Who gave Himself a ransom for all, TO BE TESTIFIED IN DUE TIME,

"WHEREUNTO I AM ORDAINED A PREACHER, AND AN APOSTLE (I SPEAK THE TRUTH IN CHRIST AND LIE NOT); A TEACHER OF THE GENTILES IN FAITH AND VERITY" (I Tim. 2:5-7).

Mark well: this message of grace to all, through Calvary, was *not* made known *immediately* after Christ's death and resurrection, but *"in due time,"* and through Paul.

"For this cause I, Paul, the prisoner of Jesus Christ for you Gentiles,

"If ye have heard of THE DISPENSATION OF THE GRACE OF GOD, WHICH IS GIVEN ME TO YOU-WARD;

"HOW THAT BY REVELATION HE MADE KNOWN UNTO ME THE MYSTERY. . . .

". . . WHICH IN OTHER AGES WAS NOT MADE KNOWN UNTO THE SONS OF MEN, AS IT IS NOW REVEALED UNTO HIS HOLY APOSTLES AND PROPHETS BY THE SPIRIT" (Eph. 3:1-5).

Note: "by revelation" the Lord revealed to Paul "the mystery. . . which in other ages was *not made known* unto the sons of men." Thus as *Paul* communicated it

to [God's] holy apostles and prophets," they saw it *"by the Spirit,"* just as we do today. Thus "the mystery" was made known to Paul "by the revelation of Jesus Christ" and then to others "by the Spirit."

". . . for His body's sake, which is the Church;

"WHEREOF I AM MADE A MINISTER, ACCORDING TO THE DISPENSATION OF GOD WHICH IS GIVEN TO ME FOR YOU, TO FULFILL COMPLETE THE WORD OF GOD:

"EVEN THE MYSTERY WHICH HATH BEEN HID FROM AGES AND FROM GENERATIONS, BUT NOW IS MADE MANIFEST TO HIS SAINTS" (Col. 1:24-26).

How could he have stated more clearly that this "dispensation" was first committed *to him, for us,* or that it was *"hid from ages and from generations, BUT NOW. . . made manifest to [God's] saints"?*

"Remember that Jesus Christ, of the seed of David, was raised from the dead according to MY GOSPEL" (II Tim. 2:8).

The resurrection of Christ *according to Paul's gospel* is a basic element of God's message for the world today. The twelve had proclaimed Christ's resurrection to sit on the throne of David (Acts 2:29-31), which had been prophesied and was by no means a secret. But Paul proclaimed a *new* truth about the resurrection. It was *"for our justification"* and *our resurrection with Him* (Rom. 4:25; 6:3,4; Eph. 2:4-6).

". . . God shall judge the secrets of men by Jesus Christ according to MY GOSPEL" (Rom. 2:16).

Ponder this verse thoughtfully. Clearly it contains an important truth -and note particularly the words *"my gospel."*

"Now to Him that is of power to establish you according to MY GOSPEL, AND THE PREACHING OF JESUS CHRIST *ACCORDING* TO *THE REVELATION OF THE MYSTERY, WHICH WAS KEPT SECRET SINCE THE WORLD BEGAN,*

"BUT NOW IS MADE MANIFEST. . ." (Rom. 16:25, 26).

The saints of this dispensation are established, not by "the gospel" generally, but specifically by *Paul's gospel* ("my gospel": cf. Acts 20:24): Not merely by "the preaching of Jesus Christ," but by *"the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the mystery."* Note: *in context* the term "the gospel" often refers to Paul's gospel.

"FOR CHRIST SENT ME NOT TO BAPTIZE, BUT TO PREACH THE GOSPEL: NOT WITH WISDOM OF WORDS, LEST THE CROSS OF CHRIST SHOULD BE MADE OF NONE EFFECT" (I Cor. 1:17).

Paul's message centered in what he calls "the preaching of the cross," the *good news* of Christ's all-sufficient redemptive work. This is *why* he was not sent to baptize. Christ's finished work for us is *enough.* It is all we need for acceptance with Him.

"This is a faithful saying, and worthy of all acceptation, that CHRIST JESUS CAME INTO THE WORLD TO SAVE SINNERS; OF WHOM I AM CHIEF:

"HOWBEIT, FOR THIS CAUSE I OBTAINED MERCY, THAT IN ME FIRST JESUS CHRIST MIGHT SHOW FORTH ALL LONGSUFFERING, FOR A PATTERN TO THEM WHICH SHOULD HEREAFTER BELIEVE ON HIM TO LIFE EVERLASTING" (I Tim. 1:15, 16).

Could the Apostle have stated more clearly that God had a special purpose in saving him, the chief of sinners?

"In hope of eternal life, which God, that cannot lie promised before the world began:

"But hath in due times manifested His Word THROUGH PREACHING WHICH IS COMMITTED UNTO ME according to the commandment of God our Savior" (Tit. 1:2, 3).

Observe: Manifested *"in due times" through preaching committed to Paul!* What could be plainer?

". . . THE GLORIOUS GOSPEL OF THE BLESSED GOD, WHICH WAS COMMITTED TO MY TRUST" (I Tim. 1:11).

Why the first person pronoun here if this "glorious gospel" had been committed to others before him?

"But none of these things move me, neither count I my life dear unto myself, so that I might finish my course with joy, and THE MINISTRY WHICH I HAVE RECEIVED OF THE LORD JESUS, TO TESTIFY THE GOSPEL OF THE GRACE OF GOD" (Acts 20:24).

Did any other apostle besides Paul claim to have been entrusted with "the gospel of the grace of God?"

"WHEREOF I WAS MADE A MINISTER, ACCORDING TO THE GIFT OF THE GRACE OF GOD, GIVEN UNTO ME BY THE EFFECTUAL WORKING OF HIS POWER.

"UNTO ME, WHO AM LESS THAN THE LEAST OF ALL SAINTS, IS THIS GRACE GIVEN, THAT I SHOULD PREACH AMONG THE GENTILES THE UNSEARCHABLE RICHES OF CHRIST:

"AND TO MAKE ALL MEN SEE WHAT IS THE FELLOWSHIP OF THE MYSTERY, WHICH FROM THE BEGINNING OF THE WORLD HATH BEEN HID IN GOD, WHO CREATED ALL THINGS BY JESUS CHRIST" (Eph. 3:7-9).

How could he state more clearly that he had been divinely chosen, *out of all mankind,* to make known what had until then been "hid in God"?

"FOR I HAVE RECEIVED OF THE LORD THAT WHICH ALSO I DELIVERED UNTO YOU. . ." (I Cor. 11:23).

Directly *from* the Lord, and directly *to* them. Can this be interpreted in any other way?

"FOR I DELIVERED UNTO YOU FIRST OF ALL THAT WHICH I ALSO RECEIVED. . . ." (I Cor. 15:3).

Again he insists that his message to them had been "received," i.e., *from the Lord.*

"Behold, I SHOW YOU A MYSTERY [I TELL YOU A SECRET] WE SHALL NOT ALL SLEEP, BUT WE SHALL ALL BE CHANGED.

"IN A MOMENT, IN THE TWINKLING OF AN EYE, AT THE LAST TRUMP: FOR THE TRUMPET SHALL SOUND AND THE DEAD SHALL BE RAISED INCORRUPTIBLE, AND WE SHALL BE CHANGED" (I Cor. 15:51,52).

Note: *"I tell you a secret."* Could this possibly allow that others before him had already proclaimed these truths?

ACCORDING TO THE GRACE OF GOD WHICH IS GIVEN UNTO ME AS A WISE MASTERBUILDER, I HAVE LAID THE FOUNDATION, AND ANOTHER BUILDETH THEREON, BUT LET EVERY MAN TAKE HEED HOW HE BUILDETH THEREUPON" (I Cor. 3:10).

Does not the laying of a foundation indicate *a new beginning?*

"BUT THOUGH WE, OR AN ANGEL FROM HEAVEN, PREACH ANY OTHER GOSPEL UNTO YOU THAN THAT WHICH WE HAVE PREACHED UNTO YOU, LET HIM BE ACCURSED.

"AS WE SAID BEFORE, SO SAY I NOW AGAIN, IF ANY MAN PREACH ANY OTHER GOSPEL UNTO YOU THAN THAT YE HAVE RECEIVED, LET HIM BE ACCURSED" (Gal. 1:8, 9).

How this should cause us to fear lest *we* preach "any other gospel" than that which Paul preached, or confuse his gospel with other good news proclaimed by those who preceded him. Does not this passage explain why the curse of confusion and division has gripped the Church of our day?

Chapter XVI

THE DEPARTURE FROM PAUL'S MESSAGE

THE RESULTS OF DISOBEDIENCE

The Church – even the *true* Church of believers in Christ, is doubtless larger today than it has ever been. Yet it is weak and sick, confused and divided.

Many feel that the causes of the Church's low spiritual state are: failure to live separated lives, lack of prayer, indifference toward the lost, etc. These, however, are the *effects,* not the causes. The *cause* is the Church's departure from God's message and program for our day, as revealed through the writings of the Apostle Paul. There lies the root of the trouble, though few as yet recognize or acknowledge it.

With Israel it was the departure from Moses' law that constantly got her into trouble; with us it has been the departure from Pauline truth. For, remember, *as surely as the dispensation of the Law was committed to Moses, so surely was the dispensation of grace committed to Paul* (Eph. 3:1-3), and those who have lapsed or backslidden from his day to ours, have done so, not so much by departing from the Word of God in general as by departing from the Word of God *through Paul* in particular.

Toward the close of his life Moses urged the people of Israel not to take the riches of Canaan for granted. Indeed, he warned them that if they did this they would soon "utterly perish from off the land" which they had gone to possess, and would be scattered among the heathen.

Likewise Paul, also, warned believers that they would lose the blessings intended for them if they departed from the truth and the program made known to them. Some, indeed, had already begun to depart, and the loss of blessing had become evident. The Galatians are a striking example of this - and a lesson to us.

How they had rejoiced when Paul first came to them with "the preaching of the cross" and "the gospel of the grace of God"! As they heard him preach, and noted the difficulty, and perhaps pain, he experienced with his eyes, one said to another: "I wish I could give him *my eyes!* I would gladly do without them. He needs his sight so badly, and think of the joy and blessing he has brought to us!"

Soon after his departure, however, they were taken in by the Judaizers who "zealously affected [courted]" them to draw them away from Paul and his message (Gal. 4:17). And now Paul had to write them:

"I marvel that ye are so soon removed from him that called you into the grace of Christ unto another gospel" (1:6).

"O foolish Galatians, who hath bewitched [charmed] you, that ye should not obey the truth, before whose eyes Jesus Christ hath been evidently [plainly] set forth, crucified among you?" (3:1).

"WHERE IS THEN THE BLESSEDNESS YE SPAKE OF? for I bear you record, that, if it had been possible, ye would have plucked out your own eyes, and have given them to me" (Gal. 4:15).

Gone was the blessedness! Those who had rejoiced SO greatly in the riches of God's grace proclaimed by Paul, had now turned back to Moses and the Law.

In Paul's epistles we find both the tendency on the part of believers to depart from the path of blessing and God's diagnosis of the particular cause of the trouble. In every case the cause is rebellion against Paul's God-given authority and departure from his God-given message and program.

WE SHOULD HAVE LISTENED

It was in a situation of grim despair that Paul was used of God to offer hope and assurance to men in great jeopardy, by a declaration which at the same time teaches us a valuable spiritual and dispensational lesson. It took place during the fearful storm at sea which the apostle encountered on his way to Rome.

“After long abstinence" on the part of both passengers and crew, the apostle "stood forth in the midst" to address all those aboard. While they, doubtless (except Paul and his companions) had been crying to their heathen gods for deliverance,[52] Paul had been in communion with God and had received further assurance of safe arrival at Rome - and this for those who traveled with him as well.

"Sirs," he cried above the noise of the storm, *"Ye should have harkened unto me, and not to have loosed from Crete, and to have gained this harm and loss"* (Ver. 21).

It was not like Paul to thus embarrass the captain and his crew, the owner of the ship and Julias, the centurian, before all, but the present circumstances called for such measures so that they might now heed his words.

How similar is the situation in the Church today! It is because believers, and especially their spiritual leaders, have ignored Paul's God-given instructions and the men of God who have striven to make them known, that the Church is now

[52] As in Jonah 1:5.

"tossed to and fro" and has suffered so much harm and loss. And once more, as the dispensation of grace appears to be drawing to a close, it is Paul who cries: *"ye should have hearkened unto me."*[53]

And now the apostle exhorts his hearers to be of good cheer, assuring them that there will be no loss of life among them, but only of the ship. This can surely be said of the true Church today. There will be no loss *of life,* not one of its members will be lost, though the *professing* Church, "the ship," the organization, will go down a dismal failure.

But how had Paul received this assurance? Hear him tell it as he stands there in the raging storm:

"For there stood by me this night the angel of God, whose I am, and whom I serve,[54]

"Saying, Fear not, Paul; thou must be brought before Caesar; and lo, God hath given thee all them that sail with thee" (Vers. 23,24).

Again there is a striking spiritual and dispensational analogy. In the present dispensation all those who sail with Paul, and only those, are saved and safe. Ill-taught preachers may mix law and grace, prophecy and the mystery, the kingdom and the Body, but their hearers are saved only as they hear and receive the Pauline revelation regarding the finished work of Christ and salvation by grace through faith alone. Indeed, the hearers, by erroneous association, may read these truths into passages which do not exactly teach them, but the fact remains that they are saved through these truths of the glorious revelation committed to Paul. Certain it is that they are *not* saved by bringing sacrifices, as was Abel (Gen. 4:4, 5), or by efforts to keep the Law (Ex. 19:5), or by repentance and water baptism (Mark 1:4; Acts 2:38), but only by *"the preaching of the cross"* and *"the gospel of the grace of God."*

This scene in Acts closes with a most remarkable demonstration of faith: a man standing on a storm-battered deck, crying above the roar of a raging sea to more than two hundred seventy famished, fainting men:

". . . Sirs, be of good cheer; for I believe God, that it shall be even as it was told me" (Ver. 25).

LET US NOW LISTEN AND OBEY

Paul's words in Phil. 1:27 speak to the Church of our day as well as to the Church of his day:

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[53] Note the analogy with Eutychus, who fell asleep under Paul's preaching, plunged from his position in a window on "the third loft" and was then restored through Paul's instrumentality (Acts 20:9-12).
[54] Cf, I Kings 17:1: *"As the Lord God liveth, before whom I stand."*

"Only let your conversation [conduct] be as it becometh the gospel of Christ; that whether I come and see you, or else be absent, I may hear of your affairs, that ye stand *fast* in one *spirit, with* one *mind,* striving *together for the faith* of *the gospel."*

But what does the apostle mean by *"the faith of the gospel"?* What was it they were to stand and fight for together? Was it the message which Christ *on earth* and His twelve apostles had preached? No, it was *"the faith which should afterward be revealed"* (Gal. 3:23). The *"one faith"* of Eph. 4:5, the distinctive message committed to Paul, *"the gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24), *"the preaching of Jesus Christ* a*ccording to the revelation of the mystery"* (Rom. 16:25).

The truths for which the Philippians were to stand together and fight together were the same truths which Paul commanded Timothy to *"hold fast"* and to "commit to others"; the particular truths revealed to and through Paul himself:

"Hold fast *the form* of *sound words which thou hast heard of me, in faith and love which is in Christ Jesus"* (II Tim. 1:13).

"And *the things that thou hast heard of me* among many witnesses, the same commit thou to faithful men, who shall be able to teach others also" (II Tim. 2:2).

God help us to *"hold fast"* these precious truths and to *"stand fast* in one spirit, with one mind, striving together" to make them known, so that the world may again hear the glorious message revealed through Paul, *"the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the mystery"* (Rom. 16:25).